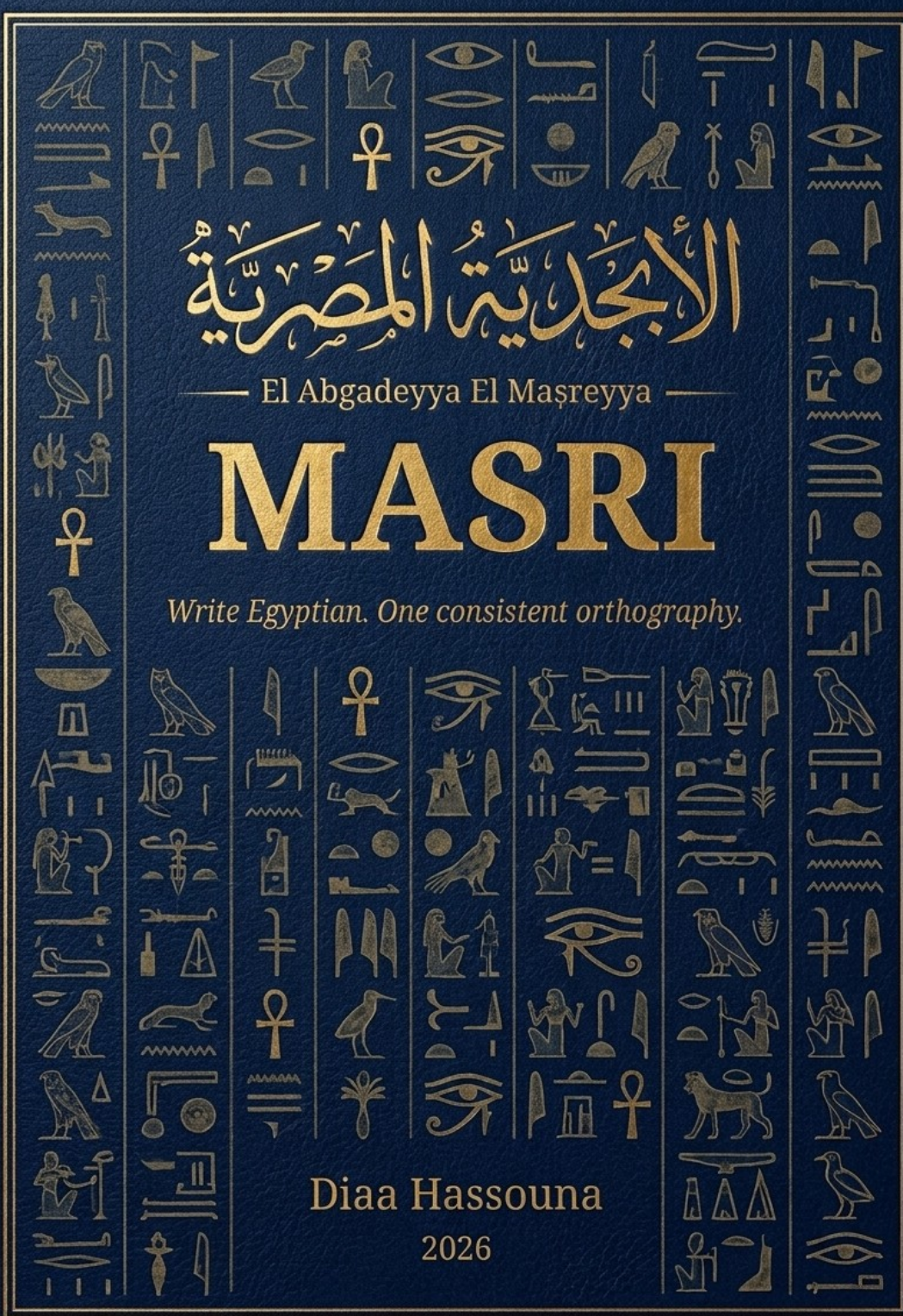


A decorative border of Egyptian hieroglyphs surrounds the central text. The hieroglyphs are arranged in vertical columns on the left and right sides, and in horizontal rows at the top and bottom. The symbols include various birds, eyes, lotus flowers, and other traditional Egyptian motifs.

الأبجدية المصرية

— El Abgadeyya El Maşreyya —

MASRI

Write Egyptian. One consistent orthography.

Diaa Hassouna

2026

الأبجدية المصرية · El Abgadeyya El Maşreyya

Masri

Write Egyptian. One consistent orthography.

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2026

El Abgadeyya El Maşreyya (Masri Writing System) — Tier 2, Academic / Cultural.

Author: Dīaa Hassouna, 2026.

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Reference dialect: Urban Cairene Modern Egyptian.

This book is a print edition of the Masri website, assembled from the site's pages and data. The website also has interactive tools — a converter, an on-screen keypad, audio and search — which cannot be reproduced on paper. Where the text refers to “the converter”, “the keypad” or “the live tool”, it means the tool on the website.

Website: <https://diaahassouna.github.io/masri-writing/>

Source and downloads: <https://github.com/diaahassouna/masri-writing>

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CHAPTER 1

Introduction

Write Egyptian. One consistent orthography.

Right now, everyone spells Modern Egyptian differently — in Arabic script, in Franco, in a mix of both. Masri gives it one canonical written form, and the converter below turns everyday Franco spellings into that form today.

Masri is a developing, proposed writing-system project. Its specification, examples, and tools are being refined iteratively — it is not an officially adopted national standard.

Masri in one sentence

The purpose of Masri, written four ways: Egyptian in Arabic script, Masri Standard (Tier 2), DRS, and Masri Basic (Tier 1).

Arabic script	أنا عارف إنَّه اللغة المصرية أحسن لغة في الدنيا، و ده اللي خلاني أشتغل فيها كل يوم.
Masri Standard · Tier 2	Ana <aaref inno el Loḡa el Maṣreya a2san loḡa fi el donya, we da elli xallaani aṡtaḡal feeha koll yoom.
DRS	Ana Eaaref inno el Loḡa el Maṣreya aḥsan loḡa fi el donya, we da elli xallaani aṡtaḡal feeha koll yoom.
Masri Basic · Tier 1	Ana `aaref inno el Logha el Mas^reya ah^san logha fi el donya, we da elli khallani ashtaghal feha koll yoom.

“I know that the Egyptian language is the best language in the world — and that’s what got me working on it every day.”

Same Egyptian word. Many spellings.

People write the same everyday word differently depending on habit, keyboard, and mood. Masri gives it one canonical form:

3ashan · ashan · 2ashan · 'ashan · `ashan · عشان

↓

◀aṡaan

canonical Masri

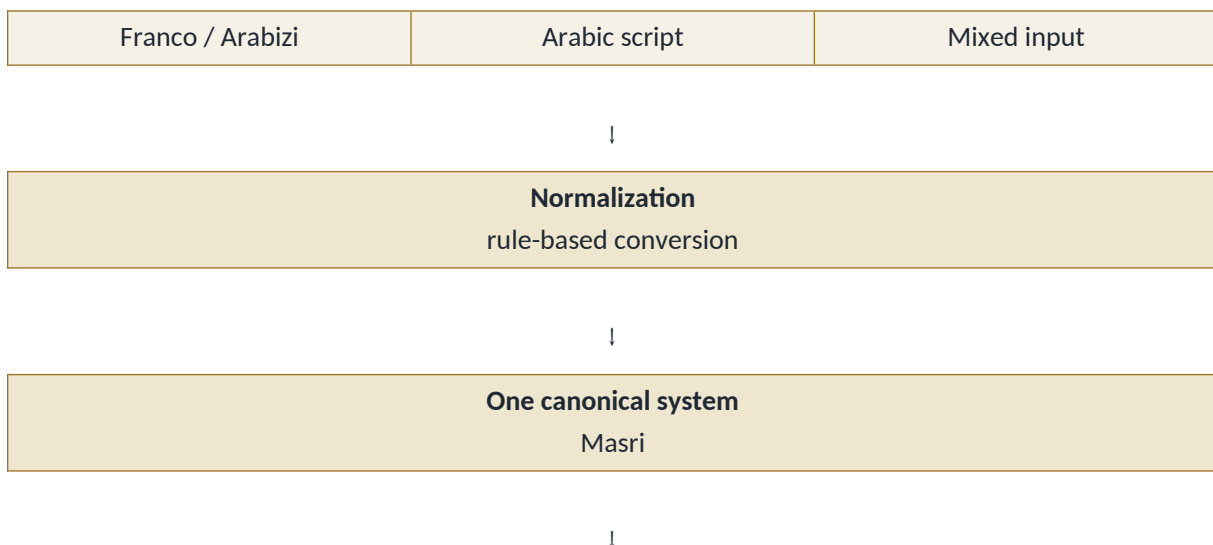
This is [canonicalization](#), and it's different from transliteration — Masri isn't just re-spelling whatever you type, it's converging different spellings on the same standard form.

What makes Masri different

- Masri has its own alphabet — Coptic- and Greek-derived letters for Egyptian sounds, not just Latin letters with extra dots and dashes.
- Canonicalization, not transliteration: Franco is a starting point people already use, not the standard itself.
- Regular sound-to-symbol correspondence, with explicit documented rules for the contextual and lexical exceptions — not silent guesses.
- No digit ever stands in for a letter — a deliberate break from Franco's 3/7/2 numeral conventions.

One canonical system, multiple representations

Masri isn't five competing writing systems — it's one underlying canonical orthography, shown in different forms depending on what you need. Today, the live converter handles the Franco/Arabizi input path. [Full architecture guide](#) · [Full representations guide](#)



Masri Standard, DRS, Arabic-V, Masri Basic and Arabic-P — see the full breakdown of all six representations, side by side, in One System, Six Representations.

The alphabet

37 letters: ASCII Latin, plus Coptic, Greek, and Latin-extended letters for the sounds Latin alone can't cover precisely.

◀ ع · Coptic	ⲟ ش · Coptic	Ⲡ ح · Coptic	Ⲑ ث · Greek	ⲡ غ · Latin ext.	Ⲣ س · Latin ext.
-----------------	-----------------	-----------------	----------------	---------------------	---------------------

[See the full alphabet reference](#)

Why Masri?

One word, one spelling

Less guessing which of ten Franco spellings someone meant.

Designed for Egyptian

Built specifically around Modern Egyptian's own sounds, not adapted from Modern Standard Arabic or another dialect.

Built for people and machines

A consistent canonical layer is a foundation for search, dictionaries, and future NLP tooling.

CHAPTER 2

How Masri Works

The conceptual manual: what Masri actually is, how it turns Arabic-script, Franco, and mixed writing into one canonical form, and how Tier 1, Tier 2, and DRS relate to each other. Start here before the reference pages — this is the map, not the territory.

Masri is a developing, proposed writing-system project for Modern Egyptian — not an officially adopted national standard.

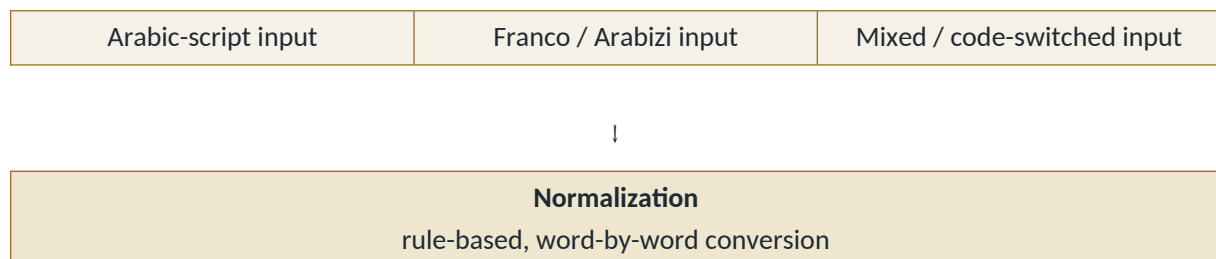
What Masri is

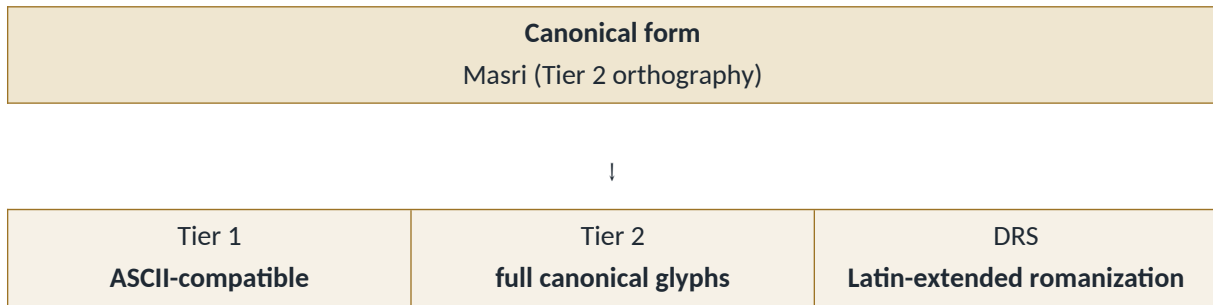
*Masri is a proposed **canonical orthography** for Modern Egyptian — not merely a transliteration scheme. It is designed to take the many ways people already write Modern Egyptian (in Arabic script, in Franco/Arabizi, or in a mix of both) and normalize them into one consistent written form, which can then be represented in three different ways depending on the environment.*

The problem it addresses: Modern Egyptian is spoken by tens of millions of people every day, but has no single standard way to write it. Arabic script is used for it informally, but the language's own grammars and dictionaries are almost all written for Modern Standard Arabic, not the spoken dialect. Franco/Arabizi fills the gap online, but every writer spells the same word differently, and it isn't a designed system so much as an improvised workaround built around number-substitutes like 3, 7, and 2. Masri is a proposal to give the spoken language an orthography of its own.

Architecture

Any input a person types is routed through a normalization step before it becomes canonical Masri, which can then be output in one of three representations:





Tier 2 is the reference point: Tier 1 and DRS are both representations of Tier 2, not independent systems. See [Masri representations](#) below.

What the live tool actually does today: the [converter](#) implements the Franco/Arabizi → canonical Masri path (including mixed Franco+English text). Arabic-script → canonical Masri normalization is part of Masri's conceptual architecture and design goal, but isn't implemented in the interactive converter yet — typing Arabic script into it currently passes the text through unchanged rather than normalizing it.

Normalization vs. representation

Not every conversion on this site is the same kind of operation, and the site tries to name them accurately rather than calling everything "transliteration":

Normalization / canonicalization

Converting Arabic script, Franco, or mixed input into one preferred canonical form. Example: **3ashan** and **ashan** both normalize to the same canonical word. This is what the converter's dictionary and rule set do.

Romanization / representation

Re-expressing the canonical Masri orthography in a different character set for a different environment. Converting Tier 2 to DRS is representation, not normalization — the underlying word and its rules don't change, only the glyphs used to write it.

Transliteration

Mapping from one writing system to another while preserving the source's own spelling/structure as closely as possible — the approach used by scholarly transcription systems for Arabic (see the [prior-attempts history](#)). Masri's Arabic-to-canonical step is closer to normalization, because it deliberately standardizes rather than mirrors the source spelling.

Masri representations

Masri is one underlying canonical orthography — not five competing systems, and not a numbered sequence of tiers. Only two of its representations are called "tiers" (Tier 2 and Tier 1);

this section covers those two plus DRS in depth, since all three are Latin-script representations with a live converter. Masri also has two Arabic-script representations, Arabic-V (vocalized) and Arabic-P (plain) — see the [full Representations guide](#) for all six side by side.

Tier 2 / Masri Standard — the full canonical orthography

The reference form of Masri. Uses the full 37-letter inventory, including the Coptic, Greek, and Latin-extended letters that give the system precise, mostly one-to-one grapheme coverage. This is what the [Alphabet page](#) documents in full.

Tier 1 / Masri Basic — the ASCII-compatible form

The same words, spelled with plain Latin letters for ordinary keyboards, casual typing, and environments with limited Unicode support. ` (backtick) is ع; th kh dh sh gh are the digraphs; an emphatic is the plain letter plus a caret (s^ ص, d^ ض, t^ ط, z^ ظ, h^ ح — the emphatic h; plain h stays o). A hyphen keeps a would-be digraph apart (Mas - h^oor). No digit ever stands in for a letter: Franco's 2/3/6/7/9 are read as input and never written. Tier 1 letters are representations of specific Tier 2 graphemes, not a separate alphabet — see [How Tier 1 is written](#) and the input-mapping tables on the [converter page](#).

DRS — the Latin-extended romanization

Diaa Romanization System: Tier 2's own alphabet, with a keyboard-safe Latin substitute swapped in only for the handful of Coptic/Greek glyphs that aren't on a standard keyboard (e.g. Θ→Ƨ, 2→Ƨ). Every other letter is identical to Tier 2. Full table on the [DRS page](#).

Because DRS substitutes a small, fixed set of characters, converting Tier 2 → DRS is mechanical and reversible by table lookup. The harder direction is Franco/Arabic-script → canonical Masri: that step depends on the rule types described below, and some cases (gemination, vowel length, formal/merger consonant choices) aren't fully recoverable from casual input alone — the site does not claim that conversion is lossless in that direction.

Phonology vs. orthography

Masri is sometimes summarized as "one sound, one letter." That is a useful slogan and a real design goal, but it isn't literally true of the finished system, and the site is explicit about the two kinds of exception:

Documented sound mergers

In the Cairene reference dialect, θ (ث) is pronounced /s/ and ð (ذ) is pronounced /z/ in ordinary speech; ط commonly merges toward ض in many contexts; and the Cairene realization of ق merges with the glottal stop ʕ. Masri keeps the historical letters distinct in Tier 2 (so θ/ð/z exist as their own graphemes) while Tier 1's everyday mode and the "casual" toggle can spell some of these phonetically (s/z) instead. Both choices are documented, not silently applied.

Orthography that preserves identity over pronunciation

Some Masri spellings deliberately don't track surface pronunciation. The clearest example: the definite article is always spelled **eḷ**, even where Cairene speech assimilates it to the following consonant (sun letters). Masri prioritizes one consistent spelling over transcribing that assimilation, the same way English "the" is spelled one way regardless of how it's actually pronounced before a vowel or consonant.

How Egyptians pronounce something is not automatically identical to how Masri chooses to spell it. That's a strength of treating Masri as an orthography rather than a phonetic transcript — see [Terminology](#) for the vocabulary this page uses to keep those two things separate.

Terminology

Phoneme

An underlying sound category a language treats as distinct — e.g. Modern Egyptian /ʕ/ (ع).

Phonetic realization

How a sound is actually pronounced in a specific context, which can vary even when the underlying phoneme doesn't.

Grapheme

A written unit or symbol — a Masri letter, in this context.

Orthography

The set of rules that determine the canonical spelling of a language — what Masri itself is.

Transliteration

Mapping between writing systems while preserving the source's own spelling as closely as possible.

Romanization

Representing a language or script using Latin characters — what DRS does to Tier 2.

Normalization / canonicalization

Converting multiple possible inputs (Arabic script, Franco, mixed) into one preferred canonical representation.

Rule types

Framing every conversion decision by type makes the system easier to audit today and easier to implement in software later:

Deterministic — Always applies the same way, regardless of context — e.g. the numeral–letter substitutions (3→٣, 7→٧).

Contextual — Depends on neighboring characters — e.g. word-initial glottal stop being silent, but written mid-word or finally.

Lexical — Depends on a known word being present in the standardized word list — e.g. 3ashan → <aʿaʿan with a long vowel the input didn't spell out.

Heuristic — A best-effort interpretation of ambiguous input where no rule or dictionary entry resolves it outright.

Human review — Cannot be reliably resolved from the input alone (e.g. some gemination and vowel-length cases) — flagged rather than guessed.

The ʿ rule

The ʿ Problem — Most Critical Rule

In Tier 2, ʿ is always represented by < (uppercase = lowercase for visual consistency).

` (backtick) → < (Coptic Old Ain, U+2CB4)

`aaref → <aaref (knowing) · ba'deen → ba<deen (afterwards) · `ashan → <aʿan (because/for) · `ala → <ala (on/upon) · ma'aak → ma<aak (with you)

The definite article, the glottal stop, the Cairene ق/hamza merger and digraph integrity are Tier 2 spelling rules — see the complete, numbered list in DRS: The Romanization.

Sounds, vowels & numbers

This page covers the architecture; the full letter-by-letter, sound-by-sound detail lives on dedicated reference pages so it isn't duplicated (and can't drift out of sync) here:

Consonants & vowels

Full inventory with IPA values, Arabic equivalents, and Tier 1/Tier 2/DRS forms for every letter — see the [Alphabet page](#).

Franco/Arabizi normalization

How informal numeral- and digraph-based spellings map onto canonical letters, with the Franco-digit and digraph tables (digits are read as input only, never written) — see the [converter's rules panel](#).

Numbers

Number words from zero to a billion, each with one standardized Tier 2 spelling — see the [Numbers page](#).

Keyboards

How to actually type the Coptic/Greek/Latin-extended letters — on-screen keypad, native OS compose layouts, and the Windows installer — see [Keyboards & Keypads](#).

Edge cases

Rather than claim the system has no ambiguity, here are the cases that genuinely require a rule — and where that rule still leaves room for judgment:

Case	Masri's rule	Ambiguity
ع ('ayn)	Always written as its own letter, < in Tier 2 / backtick in Tier 1 — see the ع rule above.	None once recognized as ع rather than glottal stop or hamza; the ambiguity is purely on the input side (Franco writers often use 3 for it and 2 for hamza/ق, so the converter has to tell them apart from context).
ق / ع (Cairene)	Treated as one glottal-stop phoneme, written ∇ in Tier 2 (Rule 5); formal q is reserved for MSA/formal registers.	Deciding when a given word should use the formal q instead of the Cairene glottal merger is a lexical/register choice, not something the spelling of the input alone determines.
Word-initial glottal stop	Always silent in spelling, whatever its etymology (Rule 3).	None — this is a deterministic rule.
Gemination	Doubled consonants are written doubled; long vowels are written doubled or with a macron (Rule 1).	Casual Franco input rarely marks gemination explicitly, so recovering it from unmarked input is a lexical/heuristic judgment, not a deterministic conversion.
Vowel length	Short vowels are optional in fluent writing; long vowels use doubling/macrons.	Same as gemination — length isn't always recoverable from Franco input without a dictionary hit.
θ/ð mergers (ث/ذ)	Tier 2 keeps θ/ð as distinct historical letters; Tier 1 everyday mode and the casual toggle can spell them phonetically as s/z.	Which spelling is "correct" for a given register is a project decision the site states explicitly rather than picking silently.
Loanwords / formal vocabulary	P and V are treated as independent letters (Rule 6), used mainly for loanwords and words with those original phonemes.	None once a word is recognized as a loanword; recognizing it as one in the first place is a lexical lookup, not a general rule.

How this compares to other approaches

*Modern Egyptian already has several ways of being written down. They solve different problems, and Masri doesn't claim to make the others obsolete — its distinct claim is narrower: **canonical orthography, input method, and romanization are three different things**, and most existing approaches only address one of them.*

System	Primary purpose	What it optimizes for
Arabic script	Mainstream everyday Modern Egyptian writing	Familiarity — everyone already reads it; no standard dialectal spelling convention, though.
Franco / Arabizi	Informal digital writing	Zero setup on any keyboard; optimizes for speed of adoption, not consistency between writers.

System	Primary purpose	What it optimizes for
Scholarly transcription (e.g. the Orientalist grammars)	Linguistic analysis for specialists	Phonetic precision for trained readers — see Prior Attempts for the history.
EG-Lang	Latin-based Modern Egyptian orthography	Keyboard-typable Latin letters with a phonological system worked out in detail; doesn't distinguish canonical spelling from romanization as separate layers.
Masri Tier 1	ASCII-compatible representation of Masri	Typability on any keyboard, no Unicode input needed.
Masri Tier 2	Full canonical Masri orthography	Precise, mostly one-to-one grapheme coverage using Egypt's own historical scripts.
DRS	Latin-extended romanization of Masri Tier 2	A Latin-only stand-in for Tier 2 in environments that can't render Coptic/Greek glyphs.

None of these is objectively better in every respect — a librarian cataloguing books needs scholarly transcription, not Masri; someone texting a friend already has Franco. Masri's proposal is specifically for readers who want one consistent canonical spelling that Franco doesn't provide, with the choice of three representations (Tier 1, Tier 2, DRS) depending on where they're writing.

Design principles

Only principles genuinely reflected in the current specification (also the source of truth used by the converter's own rules panel):

- Regular sound-to-symbol correspondence: Masri aims for a highly regular correspondence between speech sounds and written symbols, with explicit orthographic rules — not silent exceptions — governing the contextual, morphological, and lexical cases where a sound and a symbol don't map one-to-one (e.g. the $\theta \rightarrow /s/$ and $\delta \rightarrow /z/$ Cairene mergers, the ء/ق glottal-stop merger, and gemination).
- Orthography over phonetics where the two conflict: some Masri spellings preserve lexical or morphological identity rather than surface pronunciation (for example, the definite article is always written 'el' regardless of sun/moon-letter assimilation in speech). That is a deliberate orthographic choice, not a claim about how the word is actually pronounced.
- Simplicity prioritized over aesthetics: speed and ease over formal elegance.
- Cairene reference dialect: urban Cairo Modern Egyptian is the normative standard.
- No numerals: no Arabic or Western numeral substitutes a letter.
- Keyboard accessibility (Tier 1): everyday symbols typeable on standard Latin keyboards — ع is the backtick (`), ث ذ خ ش غ are the digraphs th dh kh sh gh, and an emphatic is the plain letter followed by ^ (s^ ص, d^ ض, t^ ط, z^ ظ, h^ ح — the emphatic h, distinct from plain h ه); the glottal stop is the apostrophe ', written only mid-word and word-finally, never at the

start; if a digraph-looking pair must be pronounced as two separate letters, a hyphen goes between them (Mas-h^oor); never a digit. Tier 2 requires supplementary Greek/Coptic input.

- Hija'i letter order: the alphabet follows the common hijā'i order of Modern Standard Arabic, with minimal modification. Extra letters not present in MSA (P, V, J, C) are inserted immediately beside their nearest phonetic or graphemic relative rather than reordering the whole system: P after B, V after F, J after G (G is the Cairene hard ج; J is /ʒ/, always written ج in Arabic script), and C after S.

CHAPTER 3

One System, Six Representations

One canonical system. Multiple representations.

Masri isn't five competing writing systems — it's one underlying canonical orthography, shown in different forms depending on what you need. This page explains all six: what each is for, and how they relate.

What are Masri representations?

Masri has one underlying writing system. You can display it in different forms depending on what you need — a screen that only supports Latin, a formal document, a text message. These are representations of the same canonical content, not five separate languages or a ranked sequence of tiers. Only Masri Standard and Masri Basic are ever called "tiers" (Tier 2 and Tier 1, respectively) — the other three are representations alongside them.

Canonical representations

Masri Standard • Tier 2

The main Masri form — Masri's own script.

◀aṡaan

Diaa Romanization System • DRS

A Latin technical form — same letters, standard keyboard.

Ḑaṡaan

Vocalized Arabic • Arabic-V

Arabic script with full vowel marks.

عَاشَانْ

Practical fallbacks

Masri Basic • Tier 1

ASCII-friendly fallback — types on any keyboard, never uses a digit as a letter.

`ashan

Plain Arabic • Arabic-P

Familiar everyday Arabic script.

عشان

Hybrid Origin — Latin + Coptic + Greek + Latin-extended

The primary, full canonical representation of Masri, using its own alphabet. Tier 1 and DRS are both representations of Tier 2 — not independent systems.

ⲉⲁⲱⲁⲛ

Diaa Romanization System · DRS — canonical companion

Latin — standard keyboard

DRS is Tier 2's own alphabet with a small override applied only to the letters that aren't on a standard keyboard (the Coptic/Greek-derived letters). Every other Tier 2 letter is rendered exactly as-is, so DRS stays in sync with Tier 2 automatically.

Ɛaṣaan

Vocalized Arabic · Arabic-V — canonical companion

Arabic + full Harakat/Tashkeel

Arabic-V is the canonical vocalized Arabic-script representation of Masri: the same underlying orthography as Masri Standard, written with Harakat/Tashkeel, mandatory sukūn wherever no vowel follows a consonant, shadda for doubling, carrier letters (ا و ي) for long vowels, and dedicated Egyptian-specific markers (Cairene realizations, the fatha indicator for ou and é, Masri J) so pronunciation that plain Arabic-P leaves implicit is made explicit. See the dedicated [Arabic-V reference page](#) for the full rule set, Unicode code points, and worked examples.

عَشَّانْ

Simplified Arabic · Arabic-S — canonical companion

Arabic + dedicated vowel letters (no Harakat)

Arabic-S is a simplified Arabic-script representation of Masri that gives Egyptian vowels their own dedicated letters — including two reused Arabic Unicode letters, ع for /ɛ/ and و for /o/ — rather than relying on ḥarakāt. See the dedicated [Arabic-S reference page](#) for the full vowel inventory and worked examples.

اسانسِير → ءاسانسِير

Masri Basic · Tier 1 — practical fallback

ASCII

An ASCII-compatible representation of Tier 2's graphemes, for typability on any keyboard without Unicode input — not a separate alphabet. ع is the backtick (`); ث ذ خ ش غ are th dh kh sh gh; an emphatic is the plain letter plus ^ (s^ ص, d^ ض, t^ ط, z^ ظ, h^ ح). No digit ever stands in for a letter — Franco's 2/3/6/7/9 are read as input, never written.

`ashan

Plain Arabic · Arabic-P — practical fallback

Arabic, no Harakat

Ordinary Arabic script without vocalization, representing the same canonical Masri content as the other forms — the site's existing plain-Arabic example line, presented here as a named representation rather than a one-off translation. As in Arabic-V, the Masri letter J is always written ج in Arabic-P too; ح stays reserved for G, the Cairene hard /g/.

عشان

Technical comparison

All six, side by side. Arabic-V's vocalization column stays marked pending rather than describing rules that don't exist yet.

Representation	Script	Canonical ?	Purpose	Vocalization	Compatibility
Masri Standard	Hybrid Origin — Latin + Coptic + Greek + Latin-extended	Yes	Primary Masri writing	Explicit, per Masri Tier 2 rules	Extended Unicode
Diaa Romanization System	Latin — standard keyboard	Yes	Technical/linguistic use, standard keyboard	Same explicit vowels as Tier 2, Latin-spelled	Broad Latin support
Vocalized Arabic	Arabic + full Harakat/Tashkeel	Yes	Full Arabic-script representation	Explicit — Harakat, mandatory sukūn, shadda-based doubling, Egyptian realization markers	Arabic Unicode
Simplified Arabic	Arabic + dedicated vowel letters	Yes	Alternative Arabic-script representation with explicit vowel letters	Explicit — dedicated vowel letters (ا, إ, ئ) instead of harakat	Arabic Unicode + 2 extended letters

Representation	Script	Canonical ?	Purpose	Vocalization	Compatibility
Masri Basic	ASCII	Fallback	Compatibility — typable anywhere	Limited by ASCII form	Maximum compatibility
Plain Arabic	Arabic, no Harakat	Fallback	Everyday Arabic- script use	No Harakat/Tashkeel	Common Arabic input

CHAPTER 4

The Alphabet and Keyboards

Every letter. Every sound. All 37.

Not a pronunciation table bolted onto Latin diacritics — a full alphabet, rebuilt from Egypt's own scripts: Coptic, Greek and Latin-extended, sitting right on top of the Latin core you already type.

37 letters	3 heritage scripts	0 digits used as letters
----------------------	------------------------------	------------------------------------

The Alphabet

What letters do you need?

The alphabet is ordered in the common **hija'i order** of Modern Standard Arabic, with minimal modification for the letters MSA doesn't have. Extra letters (P, V, J, C) are each inserted right next to their nearest phonetic or graphemic relative rather than tacked on at the end: P sits after B, V after F, J after G — since G represents ج (Cairene hard /g/) while J represents /ʒ/ and is always written ج in Arabic script — and C after S.

No.	Letter	Arabic	Name · Sound · Origin	Notes
1	A a	ا	Alef /ʔ/, /a/, /εə/ ASCII	Open vowel: a, á = /a/ as in 'father'; aa = /εə/, the Egyptian long a (ketaab) U+0041 / U+0061
2	B b	ب	Beh /b/ ASCII	Identical in all systems U+0042 / U+0062
3	P p	پ	Pee /p/ ASCII	Foreign loanwords only; p ≠ b U+0050 / U+0070
4	T t	ت	Teh /t/ ASCII	Identical in all systems U+0054 / U+0074
5	Θ θ	ث	Ṭeh /θ/ → /s/ Greek	Greek theta; Cairene merger → /s/ (Tier 1: th, or s in casual spelling) T1 th / s (casual) · DRS Ṭ/ṭ U+0398 / U+03B8
6	G g	ج	Geem /g/ ASCII	Hard G; never /ʒ/ in Cairo U+0047 / U+0067

No.	Letter	Arabic	Name · Sound · Origin	Notes
7	J j	ج	Jéh /ʒ/ <i>Extra</i>	Always written ج in Arabic script — Masri's standard, just like P → پ and V → ف. Covers Upper Egyptian (Ṣaʿīdi) ج — ج — the MSA/فصحى pronunciation of ج, and the loanword /ʒ/; all realized as /ʒ/, contrasting with Cairene ج (see G, hard /g/) U+004A / U+006A
8	2 2	ح	Ḥa /ħ/ <i>Coptic</i>	Coptic Hori; mirrors ح; never numeral 7 (Tier 1: h^, the emphatic h — plain h stays ٥) T1 h^ · DRS Ḥ/ħ U+03E8 / U+03E9
9	X x	خ	Ḳa /x/ <i>ASCII</i>	Pan-European /x/ T1 kh U+0058 / U+0078
10	D d	د	Daal /d/ <i>ASCII</i>	Identical in all systems U+0044 / U+0064
11	Ḍ ḍ	ذ	Ḍaal /ð/ → /z/ <i>Latin ext.</i>	Eth; Cairene merger /ð/→/z/ T1 dh / z (casual) U+00D0 / U+00F0
12	R r	ر	Reh /r/ <i>ASCII</i>	Identical in all systems U+0052 / U+0072
13	Z z	ز	Zeen /z/ <i>ASCII</i>	Identical in all systems U+005A / U+007A
14	S s	س	Seen /s/ <i>ASCII</i>	Identical in all systems U+0053 / U+0073
15	C c	—	See /s/, /k/ <i>Extra</i>	Restricted to code-switched words U+0043 / U+0063
16	Ṣ ṣ	ش	Sheen /ʃ/ <i>Coptic</i>	Coptic Shai; replaces sh digraph T1 sh · DRS Š/š U+03E2 / U+03E3
17	Ṣ ṣ	ص	Ṣaad /sˤ/ <i>Latin ext.</i>	Emphatic S (Tier 1: s^) T1 s^ U+1E62 / U+1E63
18	Ḍ ḍ	ض	Ḍaad /dˤ/ <i>Latin ext.</i>	Emphatic D (Tier 1: d^) T1 d^ U+1E0C / U+1E0D
19	Ṭ ṭ	ط	Ṭah /tˤ/ <i>Latin ext.</i>	Emphatic T (Tier 1: t^) T1 t^ U+1E6C / U+1E6D

No.	Letter	Arabic	Name · Sound · Origin	Notes
20	Z z	ظ	Zah /ðˤ/ <i>Latin ext.</i>	Merges with Ḍ in most Cairene contexts (Tier 1: z^) T1 z^ U+1E92 / U+1E93
21	◀ ◀	ع	ʿAin /ʕ/ <i>Coptic</i>	Coptic Old Ain; descends from hieroglyph for 'eye' (Tier 1: backtick `) <b>T1</b> ` (backtick) · DRS Ε U+2CB4
22	Y y	غ	Gheen /ɣ/ <i>Latin ext.</i>	IPA voiced velar fricative; Extended Latin letter (LATIN LETTER GAMMA, used in the IPA) visually derived from the Greek gamma (Γ/γ), not the Greek Unicode block itself T1 gh · DRS Ġ/ġ U+0194 / U+0263
23	F f	ف	Feh /f/ <i>ASCII</i>	Identical in all systems U+0046 / U+0066
24	V v	ڤ	Vee /v/ <i>ASCII</i>	Foreign loanwords only; v ≠ f U+0056 / U+0076
25	Q q	ق	Qaaf /q/ <i>ASCII</i>	Formal/MSA; colloquial Cairene → glottal ʔ U+0051 / U+0071
26	K k	ك	Kaaf /k/ <i>ASCII</i>	Identical in all systems U+004B / U+006B
27	L l	ل	Laam /l/ <i>ASCII</i>	Identical in all systems U+004C / U+006C
28	M m	م	Meem /m/ <i>ASCII</i>	Identical in all systems U+004D / U+006D
29	N n	ن	Noon /n/ <i>ASCII</i>	Identical in all systems U+004E / U+006E
30	H h	ه	Heh /h/ <i>ASCII</i>	Soft H; distinct from pharyngeal ʕ U+0048 / U+0068
31	O o	و	Oh /u/, /uː/ <i>Vowel/semivowel</i>	Close back rounded /u/ as in 'boot': o short, oo long. The /o/ of 'go' is ou (short) or uu (long, outside Cairo) U+004F / U+006F
32	U u	و	Ū /ʊ/ <i>Vowel/semivowel</i>	Foreign words only: /ʌ/, the fast 'you' (yw), as in menu. Also the second letter of ou and uu, which mark the close-mid /o/ U+0055 / U+0075

No.	Letter	Arabic	Name · Sound · Origin	Notes
33	W w	و	Dablew /ʔw/, /w/ Vowel/semivowel	Waw as consonant /w/ U+0057 / U+0077
34	E e	ي	Ee /e/, /e:/, /ɛ/, /ɛ:/ Vowel/semivowel	Front vowel: e short, ee long; é and éé are the Egyptian /ɛ/ (short and long) U+0045 / U+0065
35	I i	ي	Ai /i/ Vowel/semivowel	Word-initial and word-final only, never medial (a medial short front vowel is e, a long one ee). ii is always written ee, except a word-final ii U+0049 / U+0069
36	Y y	ي	Wye /ʔj/, /j/ Vowel/semivowel	Ya as consonant /j/ U+0059 / U+0079
37	ʾ ʾ	ء	Hamza /ʔ/ Latin ext.	Glottal stop; mirror of Alef; silent word-initially (Tier 1: ', mid-word/final only) T1 ' U+2C6F

The ع Problem

Most critical rule

Franco drops ع entirely or hides it behind a numeral 3. Masri gives it a real letter: < — the Coptic Old Ain, a direct descendant of the hieroglyph for "eye." Tier 1 applies the Backtick ` which is available on every keyboard.

عارف · <aref · "knowing"

بعدين · ba<deen · "afterwards"

عشان · <awan · "because/for"

على · <ala · "on/upon"

معاك · ma<aak · "with you"

Franco Numerals → Masri Letters

Franco (Arabizi) presses digits into service for sounds Latin script can't spell — their shapes loosely echo the missing Arabic letter. Masri gives every one of them a real letter instead.

Franco		Arabic		Masri	
2	→	ء	→	ʾ	Hamza
3	→	ع	→	ʿ	‘Ain
4	→	ش	→	ṣ	Sheen
5	→	خ	→	x	Ḳa
6	→	ط	→	ṭ	Ṭah
7	→	ح	→	ḥ	Ḥa
8	→	غ	→	gh	Gheen
9	→	ص	→	ṣ	Ṣaad

7 → ح → ḥ
 5 → خ → Ḳ
 4 → ش → ṣ
 3 → ع → ʿ
 8 → غ → gh
 2 → ء → ʾ

Original letterform reference sheet

Tier 1 ↔ Tier 2 ↔ DRS

One orthography, three representations. Only letters where at least one representation differs from Tier 2 are listed below — every other letter (the plain Latin core) is identical across all three. See [How Masri Works](#) for the full explanation of why these three exist.

Arabic	Tier 2	Tier 1	DRS	Letter name
ث	θ/θ	th / s (casual)	ṯ/ṯ	Ṭeh
ح	ḥ/ḥ	h^	Ḥ/ḥ	Ḥa
خ	x/x	kh	(same as Tier 2)	Ḳa

Arabic	Tier 2	Tier 1	DRS	Letter name
ذ	Ḍ/ḏ	dh / z (casual)	(same as Tier 2)	Ḍaal
ش	Ṣ/ṣ	sh	Ṣ/ṣ	Sheen
ص	Ṣ/ṣ	s^	(same as Tier 2)	Ṣaad
ض	Ḍ/ḏ	d^	(same as Tier 2)	Ḍaad
ط	Ṭ/ṭ	t^	(same as Tier 2)	Ṭah
ظ	Ẓ/ẓ	z^	(same as Tier 2)	Ẓah
ع	ʿ	` (backtick)	ʿ	ʿAin
غ	Ġ/ġ	gh	Ġ/ġ	Gheen
ء	ʾ	'	(same as Tier 2)	Hamza

How Tier 1 is written

- ` (backtick) is ع.
- The digraphs: th ث · kh خ · dh ذ · sh ش · gh غ.
- A caret ^ after the plain letter marks an emphatic: s^ ص · d^ ض · t^ ط · z^ ظ · h^ ح. h^ is the emphatic h; plain h stays ه.
- If two letters that look like a digraph must be pronounced separately, put a hyphen between them: Mashhoor مشهور (sh + h), but Mas-h^oor مسحور (s + h^).
- The glottal stop (ء, and Cairene ق) is the apostrophe ' — written only in the middle of a word or at the end, never at the start. A word-initial glottal stop is silent and not written: Ma'moor, bo', but Islaam (not 'Islaam).
- No digit ever stands in for a letter — Franco's 2/3/6/7/9 are read as input by the converter, never written out.

Arabic	قعدت ع المصطبة بضهرى مضبوط
Tier 1	A`addt `al mas^t^aba bed^ahri maz^boot^.
Reduced — not Tier 1	A`addt `al mastaba bedahri mazboot.

The reduced spelling drops the emphatic marks, so ص ض ط ظ collapse into س د ت ز. It is shown only for contrast.

Examples

- أحمد → Ah^mad
- ابتسام → Ibtesaam
- اسلام → Islaam
- مأمور → Ma'moor

- بوق → bo'
- مشهور → Mashhoor
- مسحور → Mas-h^oor

Vowels & Diphthongs

Masri gives every vowel **one letter**, and **Arabic-V** gives it **one Arabic form**. Vowels are defined by their sound first (IPA), then spelled: a **haraka on the consonant** writes a short vowel, and a **carrier letter** (ا و ي) with shadda and sukūn writes a long one. ◌◌ marks where the consonant goes.

Short vowels

Arabic-V	Sound	Masri	Example
◌◌	[ɑ] open back, as in 'father'	a, á	Katab كَتَبَ
◌◌	[e] front vowel	e	We وِ
◌◌	[u] close back rounded, as in 'boot'	o	borr بُر
◌◌	[o] close-mid back rounded, as in 'go' (or [ɔ], as in 'law')	ou	louṣṭ لُصْتُ · Kours كُورسْ
◌◌	[ɛ] the Egyptian short é	é	kaféhaat كَفَهَاتْ
يْ	[ʌ] the fast 'you' (yw), foreign words only	u	menu مِنِي
يْ · ◌◌	[i] word-final or word-initial only, never medial	i	Soori سُورِي · Roodi رُودِي
◌◌	final short a	a (final)	Huda هُدا
وْ	final short o	o (final)	kebro كَبْرُو · kallemo كَلَّمُو · Leedo لِيدُو

Long vowels

Arabic-V	Sound	Masri	Example
أْ + ◌◌	[ɛə] the Egyptian long a	aa	Ketaab كِتَابْ
يْ + ◌◌	[e:] long e	ee	sa'eed سَعِيدْ
يْ + ◌◌	[i:] long i, word-final only (elsewhere ee)	ii (final)	katabhomlii كَتَبَهُمْلِيْ
وْ + ◌◌	[u:] long close back rounded	oo	boor بُورْ
يْ	[ɛ:] the Egyptian long é	ée	asansээрْ
وْ	[o:] long close-mid, outside Cairo (Canal dialects, Damietta)	uu	buur بُورْ

Diphthongs

Arabic-V	Sound	Masri	Example
ي + ا	a + y (y is a consonant after a vowel)	ay	Ray رَي · Kay كَي
و + ا	a + w (w is a consonant after a vowel)	aw	law لَو

i appears only at the start or end of a word (a medial short front vowel is **e**, a long one **ee**). **ii** is always written **ee**; the one exception is a word-final **ii**, which stays **ii** by Latin convention. **w** and **y** are always consonants, so a vowel followed by **w** or **y** is a diphthong. Long **uu** is normal outside Cairo (Canal dialects, Damietta). Full rules and examples: [Arabic-V — the vowel system](#).

Keyboards & Keypads

Coptic, Greek and Latin-extended letters aren't on any physical keyboard. Here's every real way to type them — from a universal on-screen keypad that works everywhere right now, to native compose layouts for each OS, plus the custom Masri input method currently in development.

Universal Virtual Keypad

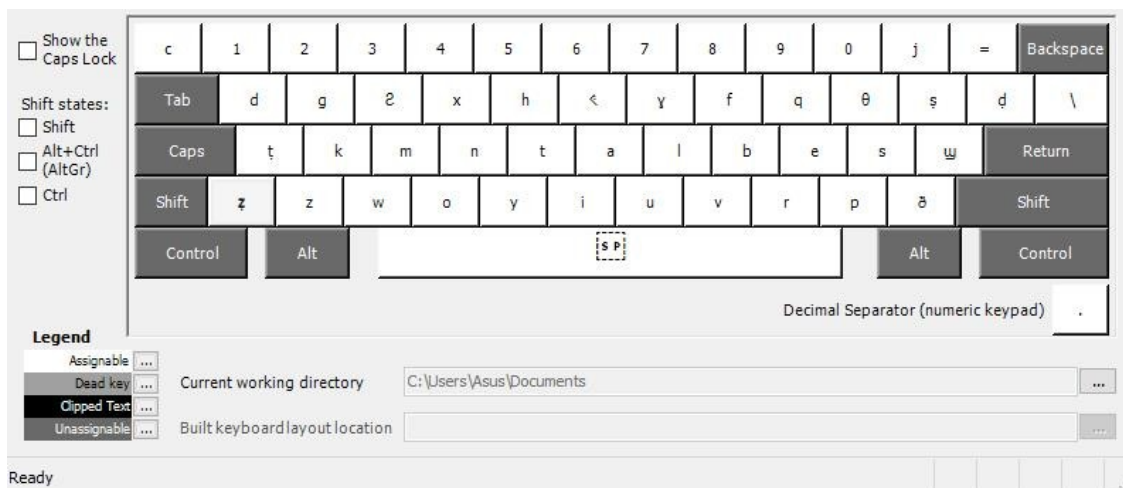
An on-screen keypad on the Masri website lets you tap the Coptic, Greek and Latin-extended letters to build text, then copy it anywhere. It works on any device with no install:

https://diaahassouna.github.io/masri-writing/masri_alphabet.html

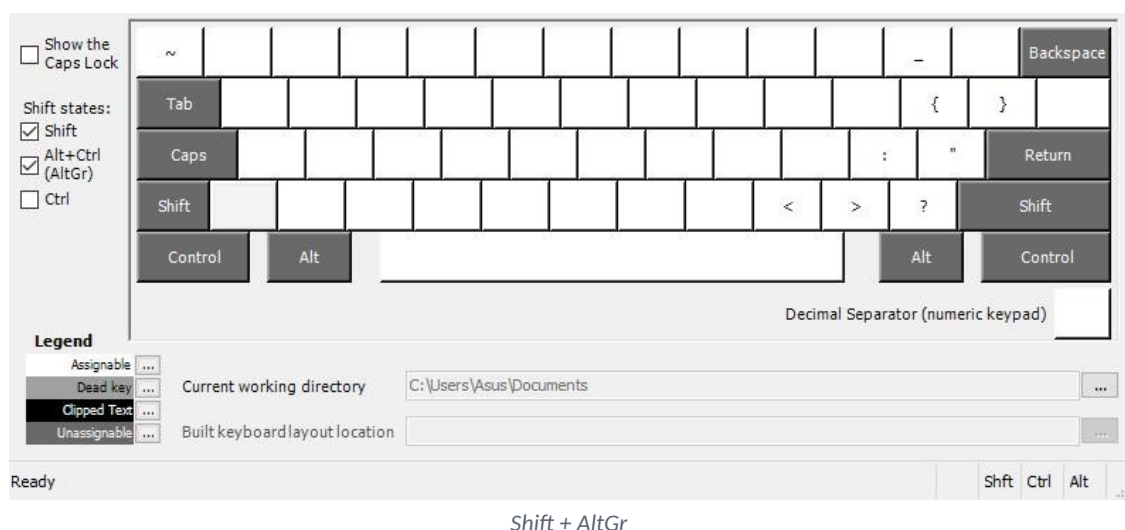
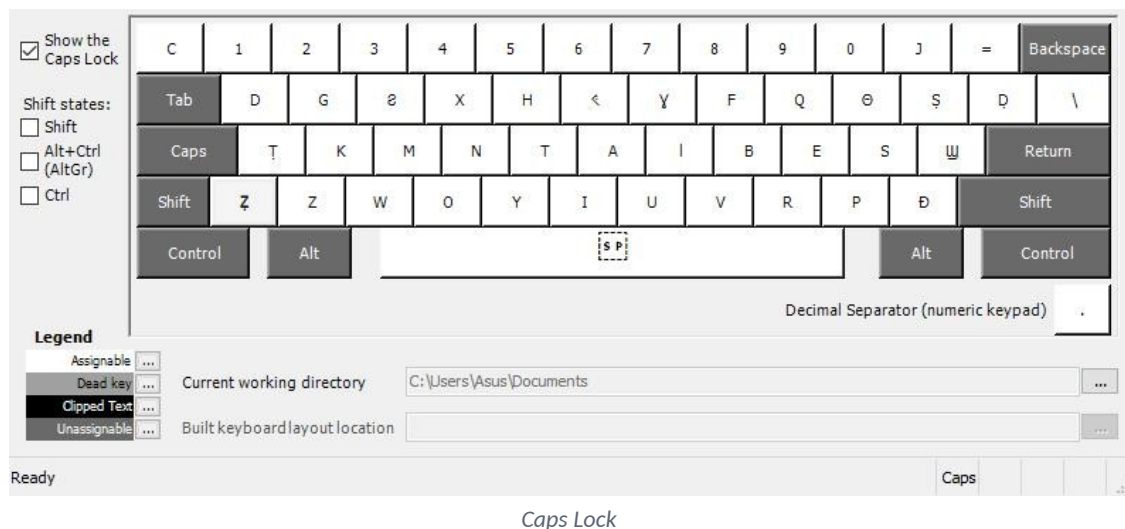
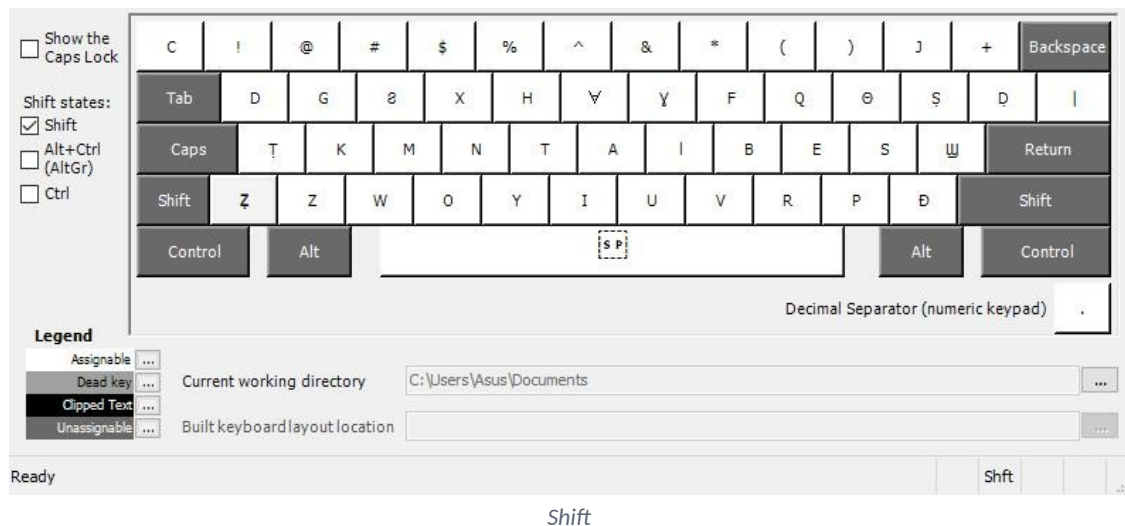
Windows

The keyboard layout — shipped and ready to install

This is the actual physical layout of the Masri Tier 2 keyboard for Windows: every Coptic, Greek and Latin-extended letter sits on the key closest to its Arabic-keyboard counterpart, across four shift states. Install it once and type Masri directly — no compose key, no hex codes.



Base



Download the Windows installer (.msi):

<https://github.com/diaahassouna/masri-writing/tree/main/Masri%20Keyboard%20LTR%20Windows>

Fastest, no install: in Word or Outlook, type the Unicode hex code then press **Alt+X** to convert it into the letter. Full code table below.

Recommended for everyday typing: install [WinCompose](#) (free, open source) and load the Masri sequence file. It gives you a Compose key — hold it, then type two letters, e.g. Compose → **h a** → 2.

Letter	Type this...	...then press	Compose (WinCompose)
2	03E8	Alt+X	h a
2	03E9	Alt+X	H A
ω	03E3	Alt+X	s h
ω	03E2	Alt+X	S H
◁	2CB4	Alt+X	a i
⧿	0263	Alt+X	g h
⧿	0194	Alt+X	G H
θ	03B8	Alt+X	t h
Θ	0398	Alt+X	T H
ð	00F0	Alt+X	d h
Ð	00D0	Alt+X	D H
ş	1E63	Alt+X	s s
Ş	1E62	Alt+X	S S
đ	1E0D	Alt+X	d d
Đ	1E0C	Alt+X	D D
ţ	1E6D	Alt+X	t t
Ț	1E6C	Alt+X	T T
ẓ	1E93	Alt+X	z z
Ẓ	1E92	Alt+X	Z Z
ʋ	2C6F	Alt+X	'

macOS

Built in, no install: go to *System Settings* → *Keyboard* → *Text Input* → *Input Sources*, add **Unicode Hex Input**. Switch to it, hold **Option** and type the 4-digit hex code to get the letter.

For a real compose key (so Masri letters sit on their own Option layer, mnemonic like the Linux/Windows scheme below), build a custom layout with the free app [Ukelele](#). It's a manual build since macOS has no plain-text compose format — happy to generate a starter layout file on request.

Letter	Hold Option, type...
2	03E8
2	03E9

Letter	Hold Option, type...
ω	03E3
ω	03E2
◄	2CB4
γ	0263
Υ	0194
θ	03B8
Θ	0398
ð	00F0
Ð	00D0
ş	1E63
Ş	1E62
đ	1E0D
Đ	1E0C
ţ	1E6D
Ț	1E6C
z	1E93
Ț	1E92
∇	2C6F

Linux

Best option: Linux has a native, plain-text Compose system. Download the file below, save it as `~/XCompose`, then add `export GTK_IM_MODULE=xim` (or restart your session) so it loads. Your Compose key is whatever you've bound in your desktop's keyboard settings (often Right `Alt` or `CapsLock`).

Same mnemonic scheme as Windows: Compose – `h a` – `2`, Compose – `a i` – `◄`, and so on — full list in the file.

Letter	Compose key, then...
2	h a
2	H A
ω	s h
ω	S H
◄	a i
γ	g h
Υ	G H

Letter	Compose key, then...
θ	t h
Θ	T H
ð	d h
Ð	D H
ş	s s
Ş	S S
đ	d d
Đ	D D
ţ	t t
Ț	T T
z	z z
Z	Z Z
ʋ	'

iOS

iOS doesn't allow custom compose files or third-party layouts at the system level, but *Text Replacement* gets you 90% of the way: *Settings* → *General* → *Keyboard* → *Text Replacement* → +. Add each shortcut below once — after that, typing e.g. :3 auto-expands to < anywhere on the phone.

For anything the shortcuts don't cover (or on a shared device), use the Universal Virtual Keypad above in Safari and copy-paste — works instantly, no setup.

Letter	Add shortcut
2	:haa
2	:haa.
ω	:sheen
Ω	:sheen.
<	:ain
γ	:ghain
Υ	:ghain.
θ	:theh
Θ	:theh.
ð	:dhal
Ð	:dhal.
ş	:saad
Ş	:saad.

Letter	Add shortcut
ḍ	:daad
Ḍ	:daad.
ṭ	:tah
Ṭ	:tah.
ẓ	:zah
Ẓ	:zah.
ʾ	:hamza

Android

Gboard / most keyboards: *Settings → System → Languages & input → On-screen keyboard → [your keyboard] → Dictionary → Personal dictionary.* Add the same shortcuts as the iOS table — type the shortcut, tap the suggestion to insert the Masri letter.

Power users: [AnySoftKeyboard](#) (open source) supports fully custom layout add-ons if you want Masri letters on a dedicated keyboard layer.

Letter	Add shortcut
ḥ	:haa
Ḥ	:haa.
ṡ	:sheen
Ṣ	:sheen.
ʿ	:ain
ḡ	:ghain
Ḡ	:ghain.
ṯ	:theh
Ṫ	:theh.
ḏ	:dhal
Ḍ	:dhal.
ṣ	:saad
Ṣ	:saad.
ḍ	:daad
Ḍ	:daad.
ṭ	:tah
Ṭ	:tah.
ẓ	:zah
Ẓ	:zah.

Letter	Add shortcut
ʾ	:hamza

CHAPTER 5

DRS: The Romanization

Type it on any keyboard. All 37 letters.

DRS is the Pinyin-style romanization companion to Masri Tier 2 — same phonemic rules, same 37 letters, spelled with standard Latin-extended characters instead of Masri's own Coptic/Greek-derived script. No custom keyboard needed. DRS is one of five [Masri representations](#) — see how it relates to Tier 1, Tier 2, Arabic-V, and Arabic-P.

37 letters mapped	1:1 Tier 2 phonemic match	0 custom keyboard required
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The Letters

Every letter shown in both uppercase and lowercase, with the Arabic letter it represents.

DRS letter	Arabic	Notes
A a	ا	Open vowel: a, á = /a/ as in 'father'; aa = /εə/, the Egyptian long a (ketaab)
B b	ب	Identical in all systems
P p	پ	Foreign loanwords only; p ≠ b
T t	ت	Identical in all systems
Ʀ Ƨ	ث	Masri Tier 2 uses the Greek Θ/θ; DRS substitutes Ƨ/Ʀ since Greek letters aren't on standard keyboards. Masri Tier 2: Θ
G g	ج	Hard G; never /ʒ/ in Cairo
J j	ج	Always written ج in Arabic script — Masri's standard, just like P → پ and V → ف. Covers Upper Egyptian (Ṣaʿīdi) ج — ج — the MSA/فصحى pronunciation of ج, and the loanword /ʒ/; all realized as /ʒ/, contrasting with Cairene ج (see G, hard /g/)
Ħ ħ	ح	Masri Tier 2 uses the Coptic 2/2; DRS substitutes ħ/Ħ since Coptic letters aren't on standard keyboards. Masri Tier 2: 2
X x	خ	Pan-European /x/
D d	د	Identical in all systems
Ḑ ḑ	ذ	Eth; Cairene merger /ð/→/z/
R r	ر	Identical in all systems
Z z	ز	Identical in all systems

DRS letter	Arabic	Notes
S s	س	Identical in all systems
C c	—	Restricted to code-switched words
Ŝ ŝ	ش	Masri Tier 2 uses the Coptic Ⲫ/ⲩ; DRS substitutes Ŝ/ŝ since Coptic letters aren't on standard keyboards. Masri Tier 2: Ⲫ
Ṣ ṣ	ص	Emphatic S (Tier 1: s^)
Ḍ ḍ	ض	Emphatic D (Tier 1: d^)
Ṭ ṭ	ط	Emphatic T (Tier 1: t^)
Ẓ ẓ	ظ	Merges with Ḍ in most Cairene contexts (Tier 1: z^)
Ɛ Ɛ	ع	Masri Tier 2 uses the Coptic Ⲅ (Old Ain); DRS substitutes Ɛ, one glyph for both cases just like Ⲅ itself. Masri Tier 2: Ⲅ
Ĝ ĝ	غ	Masri Tier 2 uses the Greek Υ/υ; DRS substitutes ĝ/Ĝ since Greek letters aren't on standard keyboards. Masri Tier 2: Υ
F f	ف	Identical in all systems
V v	ڤ	Foreign loanwords only; v ≠ f
Q q	ق	Formal/MSA; colloquial Cairene → glottal ʔ
K k	ك	Identical in all systems
L l	ل	Identical in all systems
M m	م	Identical in all systems
N n	ن	Identical in all systems
H h	ه	Soft H; distinct from pharyngeal ʕ
O o	و	Close back rounded /u/ as in 'boot': o short, oo long. The /o/ of 'go' is ou (short) or uu (long, outside Cairo)
U u	و	Foreign words only: /ʌ/, the fast 'you' (yw), as in menu. Also the second letter of ou and uu, which mark the close-mid /o/
W w	و	Waw as consonant /w/
E e	ي	Front vowel: e short, ee long; é and éé are the Egyptian /ɛ/ (short and long)
I i	ي	Word-initial and word-final only, never medial (a medial short front vowel is e, a long one ee). ii is always written ee, except a word-final ii
Y y	ي	Ya as consonant /j/
ʔ ʔ	ء	Glottal stop; mirror of Alef; silent word-initially (Tier 1: ', mid-word/final only)

Vowels & Diphthongs

DRS reuses Masri Tier 2's vowel rules exactly — no separate vowel system to learn.

Short vowels

Symbol	Sound	DRS
◌َ	[ɑ] open back, as in 'father'	a, á
◌ِ	[e] front vowel	e
◌ُ	[u] close back rounded, as in 'boot'	o
◌ُْ	[o] close-mid back rounded, as in 'go' (or [ɔ], as in 'law')	ou
◌َْ	[ɛ] the Egyptian short é	é
يْ	[ʌ] the fast 'you' (yʷ), foreign words only	u
◌ِْ · يْ	[i] word-final or word-initial only, never medial	i
◌ِْ	final short a	a (final)
◌ِْْ	final short o	o (final)

Long vowels

Symbol	Sound	DRS
◌ِْ + ◌َ	[ɛə] the Egyptian long a	aa
يْ + ◌ِ	[e:] long e	ee
يْ + ◌ِْ	[i:] long i, word-final only (elsewhere ee)	ii (final)
◌ِْ + ◌ُْ	[u:] long close back rounded	oo
يْ	[ɛ:] the Egyptian long é	ée
◌ِْْ	[o:] long close-mid, outside Cairo (Canal dialects, Damietta)	uu

Diphthongs

Symbol	Sound	DRS
يْ + ◌َ	a + y (y is a consonant after a vowel)	ay
◌ِْ + ◌َ	a + w (w is a consonant after a vowel)	aw

Note: in plain Arabic (Arabic-P), ◌ِْ/◌ِْْ/◌ِْْ can all be written و and ◌ِْ/◌ِْْ/◌ِْْ can all be written ي, so reading plain Arabic into DRS needs phonemic context. [Arabic-V](#) removes that ambiguity: every vowel has one Arabic-V form (a haraka on the consonant, or a carrier letter), and و and ي are always the consonants و and ي — so going from DRS to Arabic-V is deterministic. Full letter-by-letter detail lives on the [Alphabet page](#).

Tier 2 Spelling Rules

DRS reuses Masri Tier 2's spelling rules exactly — every rule below applies to DRS text the same way it applies to Tier 2.

1. Gemination (Doubled consonants & Doubled vowels)

Doubled consonants are written doubled. Doubled vowels are written doubled (a → aa, e → ee, o → oo). ii is always written ee; the one exception is a word-final ii, which stays ii by Latin convention.

حُبّ → h[^]obb / 2obb · جدا → geddan

2. Definite Article

Always written 'el' regardless of sun/moon-letter assimilation in speech. Spelling consistency is prioritized over phonetic transcription to reduce writer decision load.

البيت → el beet · الشارع → el waare<

3. Glottal Stop

Written only mid-word and word-finally, using ∇ in Tier 2 (apostrophe ' in Tier 1). Word-initial glottal stop — whether etymological ء or Cairene ق — is always silent in spelling and encoded.

أنا → ana (not ∇ana) · مسئولية → mas∇ooleya

4. Digraph Integrity

Applies to Tier 1 only (sh/kh/gh as inseparable two-letter units). If two adjacent letters that look like a digraph must be pronounced separately, a hyphen goes between them: مشهور → Mashhoor (sh + h), مسحور → Mas-h[^]oor (s + h[^]). In Tier 2 these are single letters (ω, x, γ) so this rule is not applicable. *Superseded by single-character mapping: sh→ω, kh→x, gh→γ*

5. Cairene ق and Hamza Merger

∇ represents the glottal phoneme regardless of etymological origin. Cairene ق and hamza are treated as a single phoneme (glottal stop) because they are phonetically identical in the Cairene dialect; q is reserved for formal/MSA pronunciation.

يقول → ba'ool (everyday) / ba∇ool (Tier 2) — mid-word, so ∇ is written, unlike the word-initial case in Rule 3 · قرآن → Qur'an (formal, retains q)

6. The Letters P and V

P and V are full, independent letters, not interchangeable with B or F. p is used mainly in loanwords/modern vocabulary; v is an original, coexisting phoneme.

بيانو → biano (Egyptianized from piano) · بنك → bank · أوفر → over

7. Negation Suffix Phonology (verb + -sh(i))

Adding -sh(i) to a negated verb triggers regular, rule-governed vowel changes in the verb stem — written explicitly, the same way the θ→s and ð→z Cairene mergers are, never left to silent guesswork. Three sub-rules: (1) Shortening — a long vowel immediately before a single final consonant shortens when -sh is added. (2) Syncope — a short vowel in the first syllable of the stem

may be dropped once -sh is added and the stress shifts. (3) Epenthesis — an unstressed vowel e is inserted when the addition of -sh would otherwise leave the verb ending in a three-consonant cluster. Note: ma itself is written as a separate word (Rule 10) — these vowel changes affect only the verb+sh(i) unit, not ma.

اختار extaar — ما اختارش ma khtarsh(i) / ma xtarʁ(i) — shortening: long aa shortens before the single final r · كبر keber — ما كبرش ma kbersh(i) / ma kberʁ(i) — syncope: the short e in the first syllable drops · كنت kont — ما كنتش ma kontesh(i) / ma konteʁ(i) — epenthesis: an e is inserted so the word doesn't end kont-sh

8. Preposition/Particle + Article Fusion (li/bi/fi/`a/ma + el)

El is normally a free particle, always spelled separately from the word it modifies (Rule 2). A closed set of short/light prepositions and particles is an explicit exception: li- ("to"), bi- ("by/with/in"), fi- ("in"), the shortened `a-/◀a- (see Rule 11), and the topicalizing/emphatic particle ma (distinct from negation ma, Rule 10) all fuse with a following el into a single written word — li+el→lel, bi+el→bel, fi+el→fel, `a-/◀a-+el→`al/◀al, ma+el→Mal. That fused word then behaves exactly like plain el: it stays separate from the noun that follows it. This is a closed list, not a blanket rule for every preposition — and ("to have") + el stays two separate words, and el, never andel. Negation ma never fuses with the verb it negates regardless of what follows (id 10) — the Mal fusion applies only to the topicalizing ma directly preceding el.

للجامعة (li + el + gām'a) → lel gam'a (Tier 1) / lel gam◀a (Tier 2) — lel stays separate from gam◀a · بالكتاب (bi + el + kitāb) → bel ketaab / bel ketaab · ف الصميم (fi + el + şamīm) → fel şameem (= fuller, unfused fi el şameem) · يلاع القهوة (yalla + `a/◀a + el + ahwa) → yalla `al ahwa / yalla ◀al ahwa (= fuller, unfused yalla `ala el ahwa / yalla ◀ala el ahwa) · عندي البيت ده (and + el, NOT fused) → and el beet da, never andel beet da · ما المهمة دي لازم تخلص يا حضرات (topicalizing ma + el + mohemma) → Ma el mohemma di laazem texlaş ya ʒaḍaraat. (= fused Mal mohemma di laazem texlaş ya ʒaḍaraat.)

9. Noun Vowel Shortening Before Suffix

A medial/final long vowel in a noun shortens before the 'heavier' clitic set — -ha (her), -na (our), -kom (your pl.), -hom (their), and the sound feminine plural suffix -aat — but stays long before the 'lighter' set: -i (my), -ak/-ek (your m./f.), -o (his). This generalizes the verb-side shortening in Rule 7 to nouns; written explicitly rather than left to silent guesswork.

بيت beet "house": beeti/beetak/beetek/beeto keep the long ee; betha/betna/betkom/bethom shorten it · مرأة meraat "wife" (construct) + ha → meratha, not meraatha · مرات meraat "wife" (singular) + aat (sound fem. plural) → merataat "wives", not meraataat · زيت zeet "oil" + na → zetna; دقيق de'ee'/d'ee' "flour" + na → d'e'na / dʁeʁna (also shows first-syllable syncope, cf. Rule 7's kiber→keber)

10. Negation Particle Separation (ma vs. -sh(i))

ma is written as its own separate word, the same free-particle treatment as el (Rule 2) — not fused to the verb. The -sh/-esh/-sh(i) suffix stays glued to the verb (and to any object clitics attached to the verb between the stem and -sh(i)). This mirrors how Modern Egyptian is written in Arabic script,

where ما stands as its own word and ش attaches to the verb. Avoids producing an overly large single fused cluster for long negated verbs with stacked object clitics.

ماكتبش الواجب ليه؟ → Ma katabʃ(i) el waageb leeh?! · مينفعش → ma yenfaʃ(i) — "it doesn't work" (ma separate, verb+sh(i) glued) · معندناش → ma ʕndenaʃ — "we don't have" (ma separate, verb+object-clitic+sh(i) glued) · عليا النعمة ما عملت حاجة! — ʕalayya el neʕma ma ʕamalt ʕaaga! — "I swear I didn't do a thing!" (bare ma, no -sh(i) at all — a separate oath/emphatic-register negation pattern, not an abbreviation of ma-...-sh(i))

11. Preposition Shortening (ʕala/ʕala → ʕa/ʕa)

The preposition ʕala/ʕala ("on, about") can shorten to ʕa/ʕa usually before el and elli (اللي, "which/that/who" — the Modern Egyptian equivalent of MSA الذي). Both the full and shortened forms are correct. When the shortened ʕa/ʕa precedes el specifically, the two go on to fuse into a single word, ʕal/ʕal — see Rule 8.

على اللي فات → ʕa elli faat / ʕa elli faat — "about what happened/the past" · (=) يلا ع القهوة (يلا على القهوة) — yalla ʕal ahwa / yalla ʕa ahwa — shortened ʕa/ʕa then fuses with el (id 8)

12. Loanword phonemic retention vs. nativization threshold

P and V (Rule 6) are used to preserve /p/ and /v/ in a loanword's citation form — not silently merged to B/F — as long as the word hasn't taken native Egyptian derivational morphology yet. Once a loanword takes native morphology (feminine, plural, verbal derivation), phonological nativization (p→b, v→f) is permitted alongside it, but not required: the citation form and its derived forms are treated as separate lexical entries and may diverge (e.g. pizza keeps p; its derived feminine bitzaya nativizes to b). See masri_loanwords.html §4, §7.

بيتزا → bitza (citation) vs. bitzaya, bitzat (derived) · فيديو → vidyu, فيترينا → vitrina (v retained even once fully integrated)

13. Loanword θ→t / ð→d (distinct from the native Cairene merger)

For loanwords specifically, English/foreign /θ/ and /ð/ are substituted with t and d respectively — not with the native Cairene merger targets s and z (θ→s, ð→z) used for the Classical Arabic ث/ذ letters. These are two different substitutions and must not be conflated: one governs native ث/ذ spelling, the other governs how a borrowed th-sound is heard and spelled by Egyptian speakers.

ترمس (thermos) → tarmas, not tarsas

14. 'f' and 'ŋ' in loanwords — no new letters; 'ʒ' reuses ʒ

Masri Tier 2 does not add dedicated letters for /tʃ/ or /ŋ/. /tʃ/ is written as the two-letter sequence t+ʃ where retained, simplifying to plain ʃ in fully nativized forms. /ŋ/ is written as plain n before a following velar consonant, the same allophonic treatment n already gets in native words — not a distinct phoneme in Modern Egyptian. /ʒ/ is the one exception: Masri already has a letter for it, ʒ (shared with native Ṣaʿidi/MSA ج), so a retained loanword /ʒ/ may use ʒ directly; otherwise it defaults to ʃ, or to g in older, already-nativized French-origin loans that historically hard-g'd — decided by the nativization threshold, not by guessing a word's age.

جراج (garage, old French loan) → garaaj (ʒ→g) · سندوتش (sandwich) → sandawitsh (tʃ retained)
 vs. شيبسي (chips) → wibsi (tʃ→w, fully nativized) · باركينج (parking) → parking (ŋ written as n
 before k)

15. Consonant clusters and stress in loanwords

Word-initial and word-medial consonant clusters that don't occur natively are retained as pronounced by default, not broken up with an inserted vowel — unlike ordinary Egyptian phonotactics. An epenthesized variant is only recorded when it's itself an attested common pronunciation, never invented by rule. Stress is not marked orthographically for loanwords, the same as for native words.

بلاستيك (plastic) → blastik, initial pl- softened to bl- · بلوزة (blouse) → blooza, initial bl- retained

16. Canonical loanword spelling vs. accepted variant vs. wrong

Every loanword sense gets exactly one canonical Tier 2 spelling, matching its dominant attested Cairene pronunciation. A second attested pronunciation is recorded as an explicit accepted variant (slash-separated), never as a silent alternative. A hypothetical respelling nobody actually says is marked wrong, not merely omitted. This formalizes the convention already used in loanword_examples below.

بيتزا → bitza (canonical) / pitza (accepted variant); bizza marked wrong · پاسبور → passport / passpour (canonical + accepted variant); bassport / basboor marked wrong

CHAPTER 6

Numbers

Every number. Zero to a billion.

Modern Egyptian has its own number words — Talata, not Thalatha; Tamanya, not Thamaaneyya — and they've never had a single standardized spelling. Here's the complete Tier 2 reference, straight from the Development Framework.

139 numbers listed	0–10' full range	1 standard spelling each
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The Numbers

Sections are grouped the way Egyptians actually count — ones, teens, tens, then hundreds, thousands, and up.

0 – 10

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
0	Şefr	صفر
1	Wa2ed	واحد
2	Etneen	اثنين
3	Talata	ثلاثة
4	Arba◁a	أربعة
5	Xamsa	خمسة
6	Setta	ستة
7	Sab◁a	سبعة
8	Tamanya	ثمانية
9	Tes◁a	تسعة
10	◁aʷara	عشرة

11 – 20

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
11	2edaʷar	حداشر
12	Etnaʷar	اثناشر

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
13	Talattaɣar	ثلاثاشر
14	Arbaɣtaɣar	أربعاشر
15	Xamastaɣar	خمستاشر
16	Settaɣar	ستتاشر
17	Sabaɣtaɣar	سبعتاشر
18	Tamantaɣar	تمنتاشر
19	Tesaɣtaɣar	تسعتاشر
20	ɣewreen	عشرين

21 – 30

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
21	Waɣed we ɣewreen	واحد وعشرين
22	Etneen we ɣewreen	اثنين وعشرين
23	Talata we ɣewreen	ثلاثة وعشرين
24	Arbaɣa we ɣewreen	أربعة وعشرين
25	Xamsa we ɣewreen	خمسة وعشرين
26	Setta we ɣewreen	ستة وعشرين
27	Sabɣa we ɣewreen	سبعة وعشرين
28	Tamanya we ɣewreen	ثمانية وعشرين
29	Tesɣa we ɣewreen	تسعة وعشرين
30	Talateen	ثلاثين

31 – 40

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
31	Waɣed we Talateen	واحد وثلاثين
32	Etneen we Talateen	اثنين وثلاثين
33	Talata we Talateen	ثلاثة وثلاثين
34	Arbaɣa we Talateen	أربعة وثلاثين
35	Xamsa we Talateen	خمسة وثلاثين
36	Setta we Talateen	ستة وثلاثين
37	Sabɣa we Talateen	سبعة وثلاثين

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
38	Tamanya we Talateen	متانية وثلاثين
39	Teṣa we Talateen	تسعة وثلاثين
40	Arḅeen	أربعين

41 – 50

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
41	Waʒed we Arḅeen	واحد وأربعين
42	Etneen we Arḅeen	اثنين وأربعين
43	Talata we Arḅeen	ثلاثة وأربعين
44	Arbạa we Arḅeen	أربعة وأربعين
45	Xamsa we Arḅeen	خمسة وأربعين
46	Setta we Arḅeen	ستة وأربعين
47	Saḅa we Arḅeen	سبعة وأربعين
48	Tamanya we Arḅeen	ثمانية وأربعين
49	Teṣa we Arḅeen	تسعة وأربعين
50	Xamseen	خمسين

51 – 60

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
51	Waʒed we Xamseen	واحد وخمسين
52	Etneen we Xamseen	اثنين وخمسين
53	Talata we Xamseen	ثلاثة وخمسين
54	Arbạa we Xamseen	أربعة وخمسين
55	Xamsa we Xamseen	خمسة وخمسين
56	Setta we Xamseen	ستة وخمسين
57	Saḅa we Xamseen	سبعة وخمسين
58	Tamanya we Xamseen	متانية وخمسين
59	Teṣa we Xamseen	تسعة وخمسين
60	Setteen	ستين

61 – 70

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
61	Wa2ed we Setteen	واحد وستين
62	Etneen we Setteen	اثنين وستين
63	Talata we Setteen	ثلاثة وستين
64	Arbaa we Setteen	أربعة وستين
65	Xamsa we Setteen	خمسة وستين
66	Setta we Setteen	ستة وستين
67	Saba we Setteen	سبعة وستين
68	Tamanya we Setteen	ثمانية وستين
69	Tesaa we Setteen	تسعة وستين
70	Sabeen	سبعين

71 – 80

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
71	Wa2ed we Sabeen	واحد وسبعين
72	Etneen we Sabeen	اثنين وسبعين
73	Talata we Sabeen	ثلاثة وسبعين
74	Arbaa we Sabeen	أربعة وسبعين
75	Xamsa we Sabeen	خمسة وسبعين
76	Setta we Sabeen	ستة وسبعين
77	Saba we Sabeen	سبعة وسبعين
78	Tamanya we Sabeen	ثمانية وسبعين
79	Tesaa we Sabeen	تسعة وسبعين
80	Tamaneen	ثمانين

81 – 90

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
81	Wa2ed we Tamaneen	واحد وثمانين
82	Etneen we Tamaneen	اثنين وثمانين
83	Talata we Tamaneen	ثلاثة وثمانين
84	Arbaa we Tamaneen	أربعة وثمانين

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
85	Xamsa we Tamaneen	خمسة وثمانين
86	Setta we Tamaneen	ستة وثمانين
87	Sabḥa we Tamaneen	سبعة وثمانين
88	Tamanya we Tamaneen	ثمانية وثمانين
89	Tesḥa we Tamaneen	تسعة وثمانين
90	Tesḥeen	تسعين

91 – 100

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
91	Waḏed we Tesḥeen	واحد وتسعين
92	Etneen we Tesḥeen	اثنين وتسعين
93	Talata we Tesḥeen	ثلاثة وتسعين
94	Arbaḥa we Tesḥeen	أربعة وتسعين
95	Xamsa we Tesḥeen	خمسة وتسعين
96	Setta we Tesḥeen	ستة وتسعين
97	Sabḥa we Tesḥeen	سبعة وتسعين
98	Tamanya we Tesḥeen	ثمانية وتسعين
99	Tesḥa we Tesḥeen	تسعة وتسعين
100	Meyya	مئة

El Meyat — Hundreds

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
200	Meteeen	مئتين
300	Toltomeyya	ثلاثمئة
400	Roboḥmeyya	ربعمئة
500	Xosomeyya	خمس مئة
600	Sottomeyya	ستمئة
700	Soboḥmeyya	سبع مئة
800	Tomnomeyya	ثمان مئة
900	Tosoḥmeyya	تسع مئة

El Alaf — Thousands

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
1,000	Alf	ألف
2,000	Alfeen	ألفين
3,000	Talattalaf	ثلاثلاف
4,000	Arbaḡtalaf	أربعتلاف
5,000	Xamastalaf	خمستلاف
6,000	Settalaf	ستلاف
7,000	Sabḡtalaf	سبعنتلاف
8,000	Tamantalaf	تمنتلاف
9,000	Tesaḡtalaf	تسعتلاف

El ḡawarat men el Alaf — Ten-Thousands

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
10,000	ḡawartalaf	عشرتلاف
20,000	ḡewreen Alf	عشرين ألف
30,000	Talateen Alf	ثلاثين ألف
40,000	Arbḡeen Alf	أربعين ألف
50,000	Xamseen Alf	خمسين ألف
60,000	Setteen Alf	ستين ألف
70,000	Sabḡeen Alf	سبعين ألف
80,000	Tamaneen Alf	ثمانين ألف
90,000	Tesḡeen Alf	تسعين ألف

El Meyat men el Alaf — Hundred-Thousands

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
100,000	Meet Alf	ميت ألف
200,000	Meteen Alf	ميتين ألف
300,000	Toltomeet Alf	تلتमित ألف
400,000	Roboḡmeet Alf	ربعميت ألف
500,000	Xomsomeet Alf	خمسميت ألف
600,000	Sottomeet Alf	ستميت ألف

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
700,000	Sobo◀meet Alf	سبعميت ألف
800,000	Tomnomeet Alf	تمنميت ألف
900,000	Toso◀meet Alf	تسعميت ألف

El Malayeen wel Melyarat — Millions & Billions

#	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic
1,000,000	Melyoon	مليون
10,000,000	◀aṭar Malayeen	عشر ملايين
1,000,000,000	Melyar	مليار

Digitized from the Masri Development Framework's numbers reference (El Arqaam El Maşreyya).

Reference dialect: Urban Cairene Modern Egyptian.

CHAPTER 7

Arabic-V (Vocalized Arabic)

Arabic-V — The Vocalized Arabic Representation of Masri

Arabic-V is the canonical, vocalized, Egyptian-oriented Arabic-script representation of Masri — Harakat/Tashkeel, mandatory sukūn, shadda-based doubling, and dedicated Egyptian realization markers, all Unicode-defined. It is not a separate tier or a competing orthography; it is one of the six [Masri representations](#) of the single canonical system, alongside Masri Standard, DRS, Masri Basic, and Arabic-P.

Status: Arabic-V is canonical and established. **The vowel system was reworked from scratch on IPA quality, and every earlier open vowel item is now decided.** Every vowel has one Masri letter and one Arabic-V form: a haraka on the consonant writes a short vowel, and a carrier letter writes a long one. This replaces the earlier reading of َ and ِ as short vowels, and it supersedes rules AV-V01 to AV-V04 (see §35). This page documents the full rule set — Rule IDs prefixed AV- — plus the Unicode code points and worked examples an implementation needs. Areas still open for formal specification are listed in §36. Every Latin example is written in the Tier 2 alphabet (Masri Standard).

Part I — Foundations

1. Masri and its representations

Masri is one underlying canonical orthographic system with multiple representations.

Representation	Purpose
Masri Standard	Primary public Latin representation
DRS — Diaa Romanization System	Technical Latin representation
Arabic-V	Canonical vocalized Arabic-script representation
Masri Basic	ASCII-compatible practical fallback
Arabic-P	Plain Arabic-script practical fallback

Only Masri Basic / Tier 1 and Masri Standard / Tier 2 are called tiers. The relationship is one canonical Masri system, shown as Masri Standard, DRS, Arabic-V, Masri Basic, and Arabic-P in turn. Arabic-V therefore represents the canonical Masri system in Arabic script; it does not create a different orthography. See the Representations page for how all six relate.

2. What Arabic-V is for

Arabic-V provides an explicit Arabic-script representation for situations where ordinary unvocalized Arabic does not provide enough information. Its purposes include:

- representing Egyptian pronunciation explicitly
- showing vowels that Arabic-P leaves implicit
- showing final consonants with no following vowel
- representing consonant and vowel doubling
- preserving underlying letters where useful
- representing Cairene pronunciation mergers
- representing Egyptian-specific vowels
- representing foreign vocabulary according to pronunciation
- providing an Arabic-script counterpart to Masri Standard
- supporting linguistic and computational analysis

Arabic-V is therefore not simply Arabic-P + Tashkeel. It is a dedicated Masri representation.

3. Arabic-P versus Arabic-V

Arabic-P — Plain Arabic is ordinary Arabic script without explicit vocalization, e.g. **أسانسير**. It is familiar, fast, and practical, but pronunciation information may remain implicit.

Arabic-V — Vocalized Arabic explicitly represents the Masri pronunciation, e.g. **أَسَنْسِيرَ**. Conceptually, Masri Standard maps to Arabic-V the way it maps to any other representation — rather than asking the reader to infer missing vowels, Arabic-V writes them.

The distinction is Arabic-P → practical and familiar versus Arabic-V → explicit and informative. Arabic-P is not wrong, and Arabic-V is not simply "better Arabic". They serve different purposes.

4. The fundamental Arabic-V principle

Arabic-V follows one central principle:

■ ***Write the canonical Masri sequence explicitly.***

This means that Arabic-V represents:

- the consonant
- its vowel, where applicable
- doubling, where applicable
- absence of a following vowel through sukūn
- Egyptian-specific realization information where required

This makes Arabic-V structurally different from ordinary Arabic spelling. The Tier 2 spelling decides; Arabic-V spells it out.

5. Canonicalization architecture

Arabic-V is generated forward from canonical Masri (Tier 2). The preferred pipeline is:

```

Egyptian input
↓
Canonical Masri
↓
Masri Standard / DRS / Arabic-V / Masri Basic / Arabic-P

```

This prevents Arabic-V from becoming an independent spelling-normalization system. The canonical Masri representation determines consonants, vowels, doubled vowels, consonant gemination, sukūn, final forms, Cairene realization, and foreign-word pronunciation. Arabic-V then expresses those decisions in Arabic script.

Part II — Vowels and vocalization

6. The vowel system

The vowels are defined by IPA quality first, then spelled in Arabic-V.

IPA	Sound	Masri	Example
[u]	close back rounded: a pure oo, as in <i>boot</i>	o (short), oo (long)	borr, boor
[o]	close-mid back rounded: a pure oh, the first half of <i>go</i>	ou (short), uu (long)	loušt, buur
[ɔ]	open-mid back rounded: as in <i>thought</i> and <i>law</i>	ou	Kours
[ʌ]	open-mid back unrounded: as in <i>cup</i> and <i>but</i>	u (foreign words)	menu
[ɑ]	open back unrounded: as in <i>father</i>	a, ʾa	Baabaa, Fuṣṭáát
[ɛə]	the Egyptian long a	aa	ketaab

The front vowels keep their letters (e, ee, é, éé); only the Arabic-V forms of é and éé follow the pattern below. ii is always written ee; the one exception is a word-final ii, which stays ii by Latin convention (AV-R09). The long vowels in use are oo, ee, éé, aa, word-final ii and, outside Cairo, uu.

Arabic-V forms are shown as they appear before a following consonant, so sukūn is included where AV-R03 requires it.

Masri	Arabic-V	Notes
a, ʾa		fatha on the consonant. ʾa is the back [ɑ] after an emphatic and takes the same fatha, because the emphatic letter already shows it

Masri	Arabic-V	Notes
aa	ا + َ	fatha on the consonant, then the carrier with shadda and sukūn
e	َ	medial, word-final (We و) and word-initial (إ)
ee	ي + َ	kasra on the consonant, then the carrier with shadda and sukūn
ii	ي + َ	word-final only, by Latin convention; the same Arabic-V form as ee (AV-R09)
i	ي word-final · ا word-initial	never medial (AV-R09)
o	َ	damma on the consonant
oo	و + َ	damma on the consonant, then the carrier with shadda and sukūn
ou	َ	short: the fatha indicator on the damma (AV-R06)
uu	و	long: the carrier with the fatha indicator, after a consonant with sukūn
é	َ	short: the fatha indicator on the kasra
ée	ي	long: the carrier with the fatha indicator, after a consonant with sukūn
u	ي	the fast you (yw), foreign words only (AV-R06)
wa, ya	و · ي	consonant + a; the small high seen marks the separation (AV-R05)
final short a	ا	e.g. Huda هُدا
final short o	و	mirrors ي and ا (AV-R02)
feminine ending	ö free -a · ا with an addition -et	AV-R08

7. Carriers and harakat — AV-R01

The vowel carrier letters are **و ي ا**. Vowel quality is a haraka on the consonant: **a** , **e** , **o** , and **ou** and **é** with the fatha indicator (AV-R06a). A long vowel adds the carrier with shadda and sukūn (AV-S02): **aa** + ا , **ee** + ي , **oo** + و . The long open vowels have no separate haraka: **uu** is و and **ée** is ي , the carrier with the fatha indicator.

Mark	Name	Function
َ	Fatḥa	a; with damma or kasra it is the fatha indicator (AV-R06a)
ِ	Kasra	e
ُ	Ḍamma	o
◌°	Sukūn	no vowel follows (AV-R03)
◌ ^w	Shadda	doubling (AV-S02, AV-R04)
◌ ^s	Small high seen	separation mark on ي / و (AV-R05); also the realization marker on ث / ذ (19–18)

When no consonant precedes the vowel, the initial hamza-alif carries the haraka (AV-R10): **إِي، أُو**.

The alif madda **آ** is **not canonical**. It is accepted as input, read as hamza + **aa**, and normalized to **أ** at the start of a word and to **آ** + **أ** elsewhere.

8. Word-final vowels — AV-R02 and AV-R02a

AV-R02. Word-final vowels

A word-final short vowel is the bare carrier letter, preceded by a consonant carrying sukūn.

- final **i** = **ي**: Soori, Damanhoori, ʁamaasi, Roodi **رُوْدِي**
- final long **ii** = **ي** + **ي** (the Latin letters stay **ii**): katabhomlii **كَتَّهْمَلِي**
- final **a** = **أ**: Huda, sama, the pronoun ending in ʁamaaseeha
- final **o** = **و**, by the same pattern: kebro **كَبْرُو**, kallemo **كَلَّمُو**, Leedo **لِيْدُو** (Roodi we Leedo **رُوْدِي وَ لِيْدُو**)
- final **e** stays a kasra on the consonant: We **و**

A word-final **ي** after a consonant with sukūn **always means i**. It is never **e**. (A final long **ii** is a different case: its **ي** is a carrier, so it carries shadda as well as sukūn.) At the end of a word one Arabic letter then maps to one Latin letter, so a reader never has to choose between values, and final -i is the established Latin-script style for this ending (Soori, Damanhoori, ʁamaasi). After a vowel-bearing letter or a carrier, the same **ي** is the consonant **y** (AV-R07): Ray **رِي**, Kay **كِي**. The position decides, so the rule has no exceptions.

Sukūn on a final **ا** is written always. It marks a final short, non-geminated **a**. A long final **aa** is **آ** + **أ**.

AV-R02a. **ي** is input only

The alif maqṣūrah **ي** is **not canonical**. Like **آ**, it is accepted as input and never written. It is pronounced **a**, so Arabic-V writes the canonical letter **ا** instead, in the short final position (AV-R02) and in the long form (**ي** becomes **آ**).

Arabic	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic-V
هَدَى	Huda	هَذَا
مُوسَى	Moosa	مُوسَا

Reasons:

1. **Pronunciation decides.** ع in these words is pronounced **a**, never **y** or **i**, so the letter shape is an inherited spelling rather than a sound.
2. **One canonical letter per sound.** ا is the canonical letter for **a**; ع is a non-canonical alternative, the same way tanween is (AV-R04a).
3. **It protects AV-R02.** In everyday Egyptian writing a final ع and a final ي are easily confused. Since a final ي always means **i**, spelling **a** as ا keeps the two apart.

9. Sukūn — AV-S01 and AV-R03

AV-S01. Mandatory sukūn

When a consonant has no vowel after it, Arabic-V writes sukūn on that consonant. This is a fundamental difference from ordinary Arabic-P. For example, **Katab** is كَتَبَ rather than simply كتب:

Masri Standard	Arabic-V
k	كَ
a	اَ
t	تَ
a	اَ
b	بَ

Thus K a t a b — كَتَبَ. The final بَ explicitly tells the reader that no vowel follows /b/. Sukūn is not optional decoration: in fully specified Arabic-V it is required whenever the consonant is not followed by a vowel.

AV-R03. Sukūn extended to carriers

Every letter with no vowel after it takes sukūn. That covers consonants (including one directly before a final short-vowel carrier) and carrier letters:

- long vowels before a consonant: اَ وِ يَ
- final short vowels: يَ (i), اَ (a) and وِ (o)

The consonant before a long-vowel carrier carries the haraka of that vowel instead (AV-R01). Letters that carry their own haraka (وِ, يَ, وِ, اَ) take no sukūn. ا is left unmarked; its construct form اِ is a consonant and takes sukūn.

Examples: Damanhoori دَمَنْهُوْرِي, Kamaan كَمَانْ.

This extends AV-S01 to carriers, so the earlier page examples تَفَكِّيرٌ and يُودِّي are now written تَفَكِّيرٌ and يُودِّي.

10. Shadda, gemination and tanween — AV-S02, AV-R04, AV-R04a

AV-S02. Shadda as doubling

Shadda represents doubling. The element being doubled depends on what the shadda belongs to. It is best understood as a doubling operator, not merely as a "gemination mark", and it is **not** a synonym for "long vowel".

- **Consonant doubling.** For consonants, $C^w = CC$. Example: د = dd. In ywaddi → يُودِّي, the د is the doubled consonant d + d.
- **Vowel doubling.** For vowel carriers, shadda represents a doubled vowel: $V^w = VV$. For example, ee → عِي + ي (AV-R01).

AV-R04. Gemination is universal

A doubled consonant is always shadda, including word-finally, where shadda is followed by sukūn:

- Geddann جَدَّ
- Temmann تَمَّ
- baladd بَلَّ

Mark order is **haraka, then shadda, then sukūn, then the separation mark** (AV-R05), whose Unicode combining class (230) puts it last. This is already the canonical Unicode order.

AV-R04a. Tanween becomes ن + shadda

Tanween (ـًـٍـٌ) is not written as a mark in Arabic-V. The /n/ it stands for is written as the actual letter ن, doubled per AV-R04 and followed by sukūn. Credit for this substitution goes to Samy Harak (سامي حرك); see §38.

Arabic with tanween	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic-V
جَدَّ	Geddann	جَدَّ
أَبَدَّ	Abadann	أَبَدَّ

Reasons:

1. **Tanween is not canonical.** It is a mark, not a letter, and the pronounced /n/ it stands for is not written as a letter anywhere in the source spelling.

2. **It has no single written form.** The ending is realized through different seat letters depending on the word (ا ي و ى ء), or it is omitted altogether in unvocalized text.
3. **Masri spells every pronounced sound with a letter.** The /n/ is real speech, so it is written as the letter ن, like any other consonant.
4. **The doubling keeps what tanween shows.** A final -nn marks the ending as tanween-derived and stays distinct from an ordinary final n (as in Kamaan). It is also just AV-R04 applied: gemination is universal, including word-finally.

11. W and Y: consonant or carrier — AV-R05 and AV-R07

AV-R05. W and Y are consonants; harakat work on two levels

Latin **w** is always the consonant و; Latin **y** is always the consonant ي. Examples: We و, Waa2ed وَاِءِدْ.

Arabic-script harakat work on two levels, and a small sign says which level applies:

Arabic-V	Reads	Level
و	wa	consonant w + a
ي	ya	consonant y + a
و	uu	one long vowel
ي	éé	one long vowel

The small high seen ^س (U+06DC) is the **separation-of-concerns marker**. With it, the letter is a consonant and the fatha is a separate vowel after it (w + a, y + a), including before a long carrier (waa is وَاَا). Without it, the letter and its fatha together are one long vowel (uu, éé). A consonantal و or ي that carries a fatha always takes the mark, so no context is needed to read it.

There is no exception: ywaddi is yuwaddi in a shortened form, يُوَدِّي, the ي (u) followed by wa.

AV-R07. Carrier versus consonant

A carrier is immediately preceded by a consonant with sukūn, or by an initial hamza-alif. A و or ي is a **consonant** when it follows a vowel-bearing consonant, follows a carrier, begins a word, or carries a haraka other than the fatha indicator.

Example: the ي in Hedaayet follows a carrier, so it is consonantal.

A consonant with sukūn followed by و or ي is a long vowel: t + uu (تُو), b + éé (بِي). Followed by و or ي it is a consonant + a: t + wa (تَو), b + ya (بِي). The separation mark settles every case (AV-R05).

12. The vowels o, ou, uu, u, é and éé — AV-R06 and AV-R06a

AV-R06

o and **oo** are the close [u]: damma, and damma plus the doubled carrier. **borr** بُر, **boor** بُور. The rounded vowel of *look* and *boot* is always plain **o**.

ou and **uu** are the close-mid [o], with the open-mid [ɔ] as a variant of **ou** (*course, law*). Short **ou** is the fatha indicator on the damma: **loušt** لُصْتُ, **Kours** كُورْس. Long **uu** is the carrier with the fatha indicator: **buur** بُور, **Farduus** فَرْدُوس. The **u** shows that the o is the [o] of *toe* and not the [u] of *look*. Long [o] is not normative Cairene. It is normal in the Canal dialects (Port Said) and in Damietta, where it is written **uu**, not **ouou**.

é and **éé**. Short **é** is the fatha indicator on the kasra; long **éé** is the carrier with the fatha indicator: **asansээр** أَسَنْسَيْر. Short **é** is in **kaféhaat** كَفَهَات. The Egyptian /ε/ is thus no longer written by a bare **ي**; that form is the long **éé**.

u (IPA [ʌ]) is not pronounced naturally in Egyptian speech and is reserved for foreign words, where it is the fast *you* (yw): **ي**. **menu** (menyw, **منيو** in plain Arabic) is **مِنِي**. The same **ي** is why **ywaddi** is *yuwaddi* in a shortened form (AV-R05).

AV-R06a. The fatha indicator

A fatha written together with a damma or a kasra on the same consonant is the **fatha indicator**. It turns damma into **ou** and kasra into **é**, and it is what separates these short vowels from the long **uu** and **éé** that the carrier writes: **لُ** (lou) against **لُو** (luu). Mark order is fatha, then damma or kasra, which is already the canonical Unicode order.

13. The feminine ending — AV-R08

The *taa marbūṭa* **ة** is written when the word is isolated or final: the ending is **-a**. When something follows and is added to the word (the next word of a construct, or a suffix), the ending becomes **-et** and Arabic-V writes it as the letter **ت** with sukūn, as ordinary Arabic does. The **e** is a kasra on the letter before it, because **ت** is a plain consonant, whereas **ة** carries its own vowel.

-eyya and **-eyyet** are written as a kasra on the preceding consonant, then **ي**, then **ة** (free) or **ي** and **ة** (with an addition).

Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic-V
Toumeyya	تُمَيَّة
Tekeyya	تَكَيَّة
Tekeyyet el baladd	تَكَيَّتْ إِبْلَدْ
Hedaaya	هَدَايَة

Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic-V
Hedaayet el sama	هَدَايَتُ السَّمَاءِ

The consonantal ي before ة carries no mark of its own, exactly like the ي of -eyya, because the ة carries the a: Hedaaya هَدَايَة.

14. No medial i; ii is written ee — AV-R09

In Egyptianized words, Latin **i** occurs only at the start or end of a word. Every medial **i** is replaced by **e**. A medial short front vowel is **e** and a medial long one is **ee**: ʕamaaseeha شَمَّاسِيَّهَا. **ii is always written ee**. The one exception is a word-final **ii**, which stays **ii** by Latin convention; its Arabic-V form is the same as **ee** (ي + ِ). Example: katabhomlii كَتَبْتُهُمْلِي, but katabhomleew كَتَبْتُهُمْلِيْشْ once a suffix follows.

Loanword citation forms keep their usual spelling and may keep a medial **i** (*escript*, *printer*, *parking*); once a loanword is Egyptianized it follows the rule above (*piano* – *biano*, *plastic* – *blastik*, *pizza* – *bitza*). An initial **E** is the first step of Egyptianizing a loanword.

15. Initial vowels — AV-R10 and AV-R11

AV-R10. Initial vowel letter

A word-initial vowel is written with a hamza form (أ, إ, ؤ) only when the underlying word has a real hamza. The article **el** and a prothetic vowel take a bare **l** with a haraka: اَلْ, اِلْ, اَوْ.

Initial hamza is silent and unwritten in Tier 2, so this distinction comes from the underlying spelling, not from the Latin.

AV-R11. Initial I versus E

Both are written **I**. The Tier 2 letter is decided by scanning the next two consonant letters after the initial vowel. Vowel letters are skipped. If either consonant is a lowering letter the vowel is **E**; otherwise it is **I**.

Result	Letters
E	< ʕ H ʋ (pharyngeal/laryngeal) · X ʕ Q K G (uvular/velar) · ʃ ʤ ʦ Z (emphatic) · W · C when read /k/
I	B P T ʔ D ʤ Z S ʕ J F V M N L R Y · C when read /s/

Word	Scan	Result
Islaam	s, l	I
Ibtesaam	b, t	I
E<maar	<	E

Word	Scan	Result
el escript	s, c (=k)	E
Eṣlaaʕ (predicted)	ṣ	E
Eʕna (predicted)	ʕ	E
Eskenderéyya (predicted)	s, k	E
Izzaay (predicted)	z, z	I

Part III — Consonants

16. Consonant letters — AV-R12

Consonants follow the Standard Masri Alphabet: **J is always ج** (Masri's standard, like P پ and V ف), and **G is ج** (Cairene hard /g/).

None of these three letters belong to the standard 28-letter MSA alphabet; each was added to Arabic script purely to mark a sound MSA does not distinguish: پ (P — traditionally described as a "heavy" ب, /p/), ج (J — traditionally described as an "affricated" ج, /ʒ/), and ف (V — traditionally described as a "light" ف, /v/). Masri keeps all three as ordinary consonant letters rather than the diacritic-marked forms sometimes used for the same sounds elsewhere.

17. Cairene Qāf → Hamza — AV-C01

Arabic-V distinguishes between ق = /q/ and ق̣ = Cairene /ʔ/. The marked form retains the underlying ق while explicitly indicating its Cairene realization as a glottal stop. The marker is **U+0654 — ARABIC HAMZA ABOVE**.

Therefore ق + U+0654 means: underlying ق, realized as /ʔ/ in Cairene. This is information-preserving and is different from simply replacing ق with ع.

18. Cairene ث → /s/ — AV-C02

Arabic-V may preserve underlying ث while explicitly marking its Cairene realization as /s/. The marker is **U+06DC — ARABIC SMALL HIGH SEEN**. Thus ث + U+06DC means: underlying ث, realized as Egyptian /s/. The base letter remains visible.

19. Cairene ذ → /z/ — AV-C03

Likewise, ذ + U+06DC means: underlying ذ, realized as Egyptian /z/.

Base	Marker	Meaning
ث	U+06DC	underlying ث → /s/
ذ	U+06DC	underlying ذ → /z/

The marker itself does not represent a phoneme independently. Its meaning comes from the combination base letter + realization marker.

20. Underlying-preserving versus fully merged spelling

Arabic-V allows an important distinction. An Egyptian /z/ that historically corresponds to ذ may be represented either as ذ + merger marker, or, where permitted by the canonical rules, as ز. The first preserves the underlying identity; the second is the simpler fully merged representation.

Therefore the system can provide both an information-preserving representation and a simplified Egyptian representation, without treating either approach as inherently "wrong". The final normative rules should specify which form is preferred in each context.

21. Masri J — AV-C04

Arabic-V uses ج for the Masri letter J. Its sound value is /ʒ/. Therefore J → ج → /ʒ/. Example: Rooj → رُوْج (plain Arabic-P: روج). This provides an Arabic-script representation that maintains the distinction represented by Masri J.

22. Foreign C/c — AV-F01

The Latin letter C/c does not have one fixed Masri value in foreign words. Its Arabic-V representation follows its actual pronunciation.

Pronunciation	Example	Arabic-P form (consonant choice shown)	Result
C = /k/	Caterpillar	كاتريپلر	C → ك
C = /s/	center	سنتر	C → س

Therefore C + /k/ → ك and C + /s/ → س. **C must never be converted solely from its spelling.**

23. Foreign X/x — AV-F02

Arabic-V distinguishes canonical Masri X/x from foreign Latin x/X. The canonical Masri letter is X → خ → /x/. But a foreign x/X is interpreted according to its pronunciation.

Pronunciation	Example	Arabic-P form (consonant choice shown)	Result
foreign x = /ks/	Taxi	تاكسي	x → + ك س
foreign X = /z/	Xenophon	زينوفون	X → ز

Context	Arabic-V
Masri X/x	خ
foreign x = /ks/	كس
foreign X = /z/	ز

The converter must never use a universal X → خ substitution.

Part IV — Reference

24. Practical example

Masri Standard: Sayyed katab el dars.

Arabic-V: سَيِّدٌ كَتَبَ الدَّرْسَ

The representation is pronunciation-oriented and is intended to reflect Egyptian pronunciation, not MSA pronunciation.

Word 1 — Sayyed. سَيِّدٌ is د + َ + َّ + ي + َ + س + ُ. The consonantal ي follows a vowel-bearing consonant (AV-R07), carries the shadda for yy (AV-R04) and the kasra for e; the final ُ has sukūn.

Word 2 — Katab. كَتَبَ is the sequence ب + َ + ت + َ + ك + ُ, i.e. K a t a b. The final ُ has mandatory sukūn because there is no vowel after /b/.

Word 3 — el dars. الدَّرْسَ — the article takes a bare l with kasra (AV-R10), then ر with sukūn, then دَرْسَ with sukūn on both final consonants.

The complete sentence is therefore:

| سَيِّدٌ كَتَبَ الدَّرْسَ

This is a practical demonstration of what makes Arabic-V different from ordinary Arabic-P.

25. Core Arabic-V conversion table

Vowels and doubling

Masri Standard	Arabic-V principle	Arabic-V representation
a, ā	a vowel	اَ
aa	long a	آ + اَ
e	e vowel	اِ
ee	long e	يِ + اِ
i	word-final / word-initial only	يْ · يِ
ii	long i, word-final only (elsewhere ee)	يِ + اِ
o	close [u]	وْ
oo	long close [u]	وْ + وْ
ou	short close-mid [o] / open-mid [ɔ]	وْ
uu	long [o] (non-Cairene)	وْ
é	short Egyptian /ɛ/	اِ
ée	long Egyptian /ɛ:/	يِ
u	foreign [ʌ], fast <i>you</i>	يِ
final short a	(formerly اِ)	اِ
final short o		وْ
final e		kasra on the consonant
wa / ya	consonant + a	وْ / يِ

Important: Arabic-V treats shadda as doubling, not as a synonym for "long vowel". Long vowels use a carrier letter with shadda and sukūn (اَ + وْ + اِ, يِ + اِ, آ).

26. Consonant doubling table

Masri Standard	Arabic-V	Meaning
dd	دْ	doubled د
bb	بْ	doubled ب
mm	مْ	doubled م
ss	سْ	doubled س
ll	لْ	doubled ل
etc.	base letter + ّ	consonant doubling

Thus dd → دْ. The same principle applies to every consonant capable of carrying shadda. Word-finally the shadda is followed by sukūn (AV-R04): baladd بَلَدْ.

27. Core special-marker table

Masri value / structure	Arabic-V	Unicode	Meaning
/ʔ/ from underlying ق	قْ	U+0654	Cairene realization of ق
/s/ from underlying ث	ثْ	U+06DC	Cairene realization of ث
/z/ from underlying ذ	ذْ	U+06DC	Cairene realization of ذ
/ʒ/	چ	U+0686	Masri J
/p/	پ	U+067E	Masri P
/v/	ف	U+06A4	Masri V
consonant + a (wa, ya)	وْ • يْ	و/ي + U+064E + U+06DC	separation mark (AV-R05)
long éé	يْ	ي + U+064E	one long vowel
short é	◌َ	U+064E + U+0650	fatha indicator on kasra
short ou	◌ُ	U+064E + U+064F	fatha indicator on damma
long uu	وْ	و + U+064E	one long vowel
long aa	اْ + ◌ْ	ا + U+0651 + U+0652	carrier + shadda + sukūn
long ee	يْ + ◌ْ	ي + U+0651 + U+0652	carrier + shadda + sukūn
long oo	وْ + ◌ْ	و + U+0651 + U+0652	carrier + shadda + sukūn
consonant with no following vowel	◌°	C + U+0652	mandatory sukūn
consonant doubling	◌ ^w	C + U+0651	CC
final ى (input only)	—	U+0649	normalized to ا (AV-R02a)
آ (input only)	—	U+0622	normalized to hamza + aa (AV-R01)

28. Names: final i versus final y

The rule works on the letter, not on the origin of the name. Whether the source spelling ends in -i or -y, the Masri spelling ends in **i** and Arabic-V ends in **يْ**. English **y** after a consonant is a vowel (/i/), so it is respelled **i**; it is never kept as **y**.

Latin-script names that already end in i

Source name	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic-V
Rossi	Rossi	رُسِّيْ
Verdi	Verdi	فِرْدِيْ
Ferrari	Ferrari	فِرَّرِيْ

Source name	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic-V
Marconi	Markoni	مَرْكُونِي
Giovanni	Jovanni	جُفَّيْنِي

English names that end in y

Source name	Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic-V
Mary	Maari	مَارِي
Nancy	Naansi	نَانْسِي
Sally	Saali	سَالِي
Tony	Tooni	تُونِي
Andy	Andi	أَنْدِي
Randy	Randi	رَنْدِي

The Masri spellings of these names are proposals (vowel length in particular), so check them against how you want each name to be pronounced. Gemination is universal (AV-R04), so the doubled letters in Rossi, Ferrari and Jovanni become shadda.

Final y after a vowel. A final **y** after a vowel is the consonant **ي** (AV-R02, AV-R07): Ray رِي, Kay كِي.

29. Worked examples (strict form)

Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic-V
We	وِ
Waa2ed	وَّاحِدْ
ywaddi (yuwaddi)	يُودِي
Toumeyya	تُمِيَّة
Tekeyya	تِكِيَّة
Tekeyyet el baladd	تِكِيَّةُ الْبَلَدِ
Hedaaya	هَدَايَة
Hedaayet el sama	هَدَايَةُ السَّمَاءِ
borr	بُرْ
boor	بُورْ
loušt	لُصْتُ
Kours	كُورْسْ

Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic-V
buur	بُور
Farduus	فَرْدُوسْ
Nabboot	نُبُوتْ
Kamaan	كَمَانْ
Ketaab	كِتَابْ
Baabaa	بَابَا
Fusṭáát	فُسطَاطْ
Baḥdéeṇ	بَعْدِينَ
asanséeṛ	أَسْنَسِيرْ
kaféhaat	كَفَهَآتْ
kebro	كَبْرُو
kallemo	كَلَّمُو
katabhomlii	كَتَبْهُمْلِيْ
katabhomleew	كَتَبْهُمْلَيْشْ
Roodi we Leedo	رُودِيْ وَ لِيْدُو
tafkeer	تَفَكِيرْ
Sayyed	سَيِّدْ
Rooj	رُوجْ
Geddann	جِدَنَّ
Temmann	تَمَنَّ
Soori	سُوْرِيْ
Damanhoori	دَمَهُوْرِيْ
ʔamaasi	شَمَاسِيْ
ʔamaaseeha	شَمَاسِيْهَا
A2mad	أَحْمَدْ
Ibtesaam	إِبْتِسَامْ
Islaam	إِسْلَامْ
Eḥmaar	إِعْمَارْ
el escript	إِلْإِسْكْرِیْتُ
Huda	هُدَا
Waṭwaat	وَطْوَاطْ
mewa2wa2	مَوْخَوْخْ

Masri (Tier 2)	Arabic-V
lewa2di	لَوْحَدِي
Ma2mood	مَحْمُود
Mamdood	مَمْدُود
menu (menyw)	مِنِي
loušt we kont laayeš	لُصْتُ وَ كُنْتُ لَايِشْ
law enta faaker enni nséét, la ana ʕomri ma ansa	لَوِ إِنْتَا قَاكِرْ إِيَّيْ نُسَيْتْ، لَا أَنَا ʕَمْرِي مَا أَنَسَا
buur saʕeed	بُورْ سَعِيدْ

30. Information-preservation principle

Arabic-V should not discard information unnecessarily. For example, قْ contains more information than ق, because it communicates both the underlying ق and its Cairene /ʔ/ realization. Likewise تْ contains more information than س when the underlying ث matters, and ڏ contains more information than ز when the underlying ڏ matters.

This makes Arabic-V useful not only for reading, but also for normalization, linguistic analysis, machine learning, conversion between representations, and pronunciation-aware processing.

Scope. The principle governs Cairene realization markers, where an underlying letter differs from its pronounced value. It does not apply to inherited spelling variants that carry no difference in sound: ى, ٱ, and tanween marks are accepted as input and normalized (AV-R01, AV-R02a, AV-R04a).

31. Unicode authority

The actual Unicode sequence is authoritative. A visually similar glyph is not necessarily equivalent to the required Arabic-V representation. Important code points include:

Character / mark	Unicode
Alif ا	U+0627
Alif with Madda Above ٱ (input only)	U+0622
Alif Maqṣūrah ى (input only)	U+0649
Yeh ي	U+064A
Waw و	U+0648
Noon ن	U+0646
Teh ت	U+062A
Teh Marbuta ة	U+0629

Character / mark	Unicode
Masri J ج	U+0686
Fatha	U+064E
Damma	U+064F
Kasra	U+0650
Shadda	U+0651
Sukūn	U+0652
Hamza Above	U+0654
Dagger Alif (no longer part of canonical output)	U+0670
Small High Seen	U+06DC

Arabic-V implementations must preserve the actual base character and combining marks. Unicode normalization, canonical ordering, and rendering behavior must therefore be tested as part of the implementation. The canonical mark order is haraka (fatha, then damma or kasra), shadda, sukūn, then the small high seen (AV-R04, AV-R06a).

32. Arabic-V versus phonetic transcription

Arabic-V is not unrestricted IPA written in Arabic letters. It remains an orthographic representation of canonical Masri.

For example, قْ does not merely mean "write the sound /ʔ/". It means: the canonical underlying letter is ق, and its Cairene realization is /ʔ/. Similarly, سْ means: the canonical underlying letter is س, realized as /s/. This is why Arabic-V is an orthography rather than a simple pronunciation transcription.

33. Rule-development standard

Every new Arabic-V rule should be documented using the following structure:

Field	Requirement
Rule ID	e.g. AV-11
Name	descriptive rule name
Input	canonical Masri element
Arabic-V output	exact Arabic representation
Meaning	what the representation signifies
Unicode	code point and Unicode name
Examples	real Masri examples
Alternatives	whether merged forms are permitted

Field	Requirement
Edge cases	interactions with other marks
Status	proposed / established / complete / deprecated

This prevents individual examples from accidentally becoming undocumented rules.

34. Rule index

Rule	Name	Status
AV-S01	Mandatory sukūn	established; extended to carriers by AV-R03
AV-S02	Shadda as doubling	established; refined by AV-R04
AV-V01	Doubled E	deprecated — superseded by AV-R01
AV-V02	Doubled A	deprecated — superseded by AV-R01, AV-R02a
AV-V03	Yā' Maftūḥa	deprecated — superseded by AV-R06
AV-V04	Final ع	deprecated — superseded by AV-R02a
AV-C01	Cairene Qāf marker	established
AV-C02	Cairene Thā' marker	established
AV-C03	Cairene Dhāl marker	established
AV-C04	Masri J	established
AV-F01	Pronunciation-based C	established
AV-F02	Pronunciation-based X	established
AV-R01	Carriers and harakat	established
AV-R02	Word-final vowels	established
AV-R02a	ع is input only	established
AV-R03	Sukūn	established
AV-R04	Gemination is universal	established
AV-R04a	Tanween becomes و + shadda	established
AV-R05	W and Y are consonants; two-level harakat	established
AV-R06	The vowels o, ou, uu, u, é, éé	established
AV-R06a	The fatha indicator	established
AV-R07	Carrier versus consonant	established
AV-R08	Feminine ending ة / ِ	established
AV-R09	No medial i; ii is written ee (except word-final ii)	established
AV-R10	Initial vowel letter	established
AV-R11	Initial I versus E	established

Rule	Name	Status
AV-R12	Consonant letters	established

35. Superseded rules

The first version of this page defined four vowel rules that read و and ي as short vowels and preserved ع and آ. They are replaced as follows.

Old rule	Old form	Now
AV-V01 Doubled E	ee → ي (e.g. تَفَكِّير)	ee → ع + ي (تَفَكِّير)
AV-V02 Doubled A	aa → آ, or ع where the underlying letter is ع	aa → ع + آ; آ and ع are input only
AV-V03 Yāʾ Maftūḥa	ي = é = /ɛ/	ي = long éé; short é = ع
AV-V04 Final ع	ع, with dagger alif ʾ where needed	final short a = آ; long form إ

36. Areas requiring formal specification

The Arabic-V framework is established. The vowel system, sukūn, shadda and gemination, tanween, final-vowel behavior, hamza/alif behavior, definite article behavior and grammatical endings are now decided (§6–§15). The complete technical standard should continue formalizing:

- loanword rules beyond the vowel and consonant rules above
- proper names beyond the examples in §28
- additional Egyptian mergers
- additional foreign sounds
- Unicode normalization
- renderer requirements

No rule should be inferred merely from conventional MSA spelling.

37. Decision log and companion decisions

Vowel-rework decisions (all closed).

1. **Consonantal w and y followed by a.** و (wa) and ي (ya) take the small high seen (AV-R05). ywaddi is yuwaddi in a shortened form and needs no exception.
2. **uu, ii and u.** ii is always written ee; the one exception is a word-final ii, which stays ii by Latin convention (AV-R09). uu is the long [o], written و, and is normal outside Cairo. u is the fast you of foreign words, ي (AV-R06).

3. **Final and suffix details.** A final short **o** is **و** (AV-R02). **-aaya** is **أية**, with the **ي** unmarked before **ة**, and **-aayet** is **أَيْت** (AV-R08).
4. **Word-initial long aa.** **آ** is input only. The canonical form is the hamza-alif with fatha plus the doubled carrier, **آآ** (AV-R01).
5. **Page examples updated.** The examples on this page now read **تَفَكِير** and **مُسَوِّي**.
6. **Word-final consonantal y.** After a vowel-bearing letter or a carrier a final **ي** is the consonant **y**; after a consonant with sukūn it is **ي** (AV-R02, AV-R07).
7. **Short ou and é.** Short **ou** and **é** are the fatha indicator on the damma and kasra; long **uu** and **éé** are the carrier with the fatha indicator (AV-R06, AV-R06a).
8. **Medial i.** Every medial **i** in an Egyptianized word is written **e**. Loanword citation forms keep their usual spelling (*escript, printer, parking, vidyu, vitrina*), and Egyptianized loanwords use their usual forms (*bitza, biano, blastik*) (AV-R09). The Tier 1, Tier 2 and DRS spellings of native words on the site were updated to match.

Companion decisions made in the same session.

- **Tier 1 (applied on the Alphabet page).** **ح** is **h^** in Tier 1 and **ﺥ** in Tier 2 (A2mad). The glottal stop is **ʾ** in Tier 1, written only mid-word and word-finally, never at the start (Ma'moor, Islaam). If a digraph-looking pair must be pronounced as two letters, a hyphen goes between them in Tier 1 (Mashhoor مشهور, Mas-h^oor مسحور).
- **Arabic script (applied on the site).** **J** is always **ج**; **P** is always **پ**; **V** is always **ف**; **G** stays **ج**.

38. Credits

- **Tanween** — **ن** (AV-R04a). The substitution of tanween by the actual letter **ن** is credited to **Samy Harak (سامي حرك)**, author of the **بتكلم مصري** book series on Egyptian grammar (قواعد) and vocabulary (ألفاظ), which explores Modern Egyptian far more extensively than this document does.
- **Point of disagreement.** Harak writes without harakat; this proposal keeps harakat throughout, because Arabic-V is fully vocalized. Both positions have their reasons, and adopting his tanween substitution does not mean adopting his position on harakat.
 - *His words, translated directly from Bantkallem Masri (2nd edition), page 10:*

Tashkeel (Diacritics)

There is no diacritical marking (tashkeel) in writing the Egyptian language, just as ancient Egyptian and old Nabataean writing had none. Because of that, I am forced to skip rendering the vowel-marking of some sounds, and I will not mark them, considering they are well-known and familiar — like the word for God, “Allah”: if you wrote it exactly as it is pronounced, it would come out “Allaah.”

Tanween (Nunation)

I ran into the problem of writing the nunation (tanween) of words like (fe'lan) and (giddan).

The book's approach is not to use diacritical marks at all, because they are not a feature of the Egyptian language — neither the old nor the new — and because tashkeel interrupts the flow of writing, which is why every language in the world avoids it, including Arabic itself when written in Latin letters. At the same time, we must write as we pronounce, so we write (geddan geddan) instead of (giddan giddan). Writing the confirmation nūn (nūn al-tawkid) in the same texture and body of the word feels more natural, as we will see in the grammar explanation, because the nūn was originally a suffix — a connecting particle already present in older stages of the Egyptian language (muṭṭalaqan / dayman / khuṣṣan, etc.).

- *Gemination*. His method writes a doubled consonant by simple letter doubling instead of shadda.

Gemination example, Arabic-V against Harak's method:

Arabic-V	Harak's method
اززاي	اززاي

Agreement with Harak — the difference between Modern Egyptian and MSA

The Implied Markers in Arabic Grammar

The scholars of Arabic grammar invented the (estimated / assumed / implied) markers! In summary: there exist Arabic case-endings (i'rāb) that are spoken but never written!

The justification for this “implied marker,” and its sole cause, is: (ta'adhdhur — impossibility of pronunciation)! Let's look at these three examples from the Arabic grammar book:

- Jā' Mūsā (“Musa came”): (Musa) is the subject, nominative; its nominative marker is estimated (not visible), its appearance blocked by ta'adhdhur!
 - Ra'aytu Mūsā (“I saw Musa”): (Musa) is the direct object, accusative; its accusative marker, a fathā, is estimated (not visible), its appearance blocked by ta'adhdhur!
 - Marartu bi-Mūsā (“I passed by Musa”): (bi-Musa) is a prepositional phrase; the genitive marker (here alone) is a fathā, estimated (not visible), its appearance blocked by ta'adhdhur!
- So:

- When we write in Egyptian, we must commit only to the rules of the Egyptian language!
- The Egyptian language has no markers at all — neither visible nor estimated, neither real nor implied. Every sound is visible, in writing and in pronunciation!
- A word's grammatical function is decided by its position, not by its vocalization!
- We write names as: Musa/Huda/Nada, and particles as: 'ala/emta/hatta.

(Bantkalem Masri, 2nd edition, page 13 — translated)

This point, on page 13, is itself the linguistic proof that separates Modern Egyptian from MSA. The estimated/implied markers in Arabic grammar come from Arabic's synthetic, case-marking nature (i'rāb), while Modern Egyptian is analytic and has no i'rāb at all — neither visible nor estimated. That is exactly the same reason Modern Egyptian stands as a language in its own right rather than a mere dialect of Arabic, the same way English is not a dialect of French.

Why Arabic-V still uses harakat

In full agreement with Harak on this point, Arabic-V still uses harakat — not because Egyptian needs i‘rāb the way Arabic does (it does not, and that is exactly Harak’s own point), but because Arabic-V is not a representation meant for everyday reading like Harak’s book; it is a precision representation, aimed at readers already comfortable in Arabic script who want every vowel written out explicitly, so it can be checked line by line against Tier 2 and DRS without ambiguity. The harakat here are not a form of i‘rāb — they are simply full phonetic notation, the same principle Harak himself states, that every sound must be visible in writing, just applied with a different tool.

39. Beginner explanation

For ordinary users:

Arabic-V is Masri written in Arabic script with explicit vowel marks, mandatory sukūn where no vowel follows, shadda for doubling, and special signs that make Egyptian pronunciation and underlying letter distinctions explicit.

The most important concepts are:

Notation	Means
Arabic-P	everyday plain Arabic
Arabic-V	explicit vocalized Masri
C ^w	doubled consonant
◌َ ◌ِ ◌ِْ	short vowels a e o on the consonant
◌َ◌َ + ◌ِ◌ِ + ◌ِ◌ِْ + ◌ِ◌ِْ + ◌ِ◌ِْ + ◌ِ◌ِْ	long vowels aa ee oo
◌ِ◌ِْ	long éé
◌ِ◌ِْ	long uu
◌ِ◌ِْ + ◌ِ◌ِْ	consonant + a (wa, ya)
C ^o	consonant with no following vowel
◌ِ◌ِْ	underlying ق pronounced Cairene /ʔ/
◌ِ◌ِْ	underlying ث pronounced /s/
◌ِ◌ِْ	underlying ذ pronounced /z/
◌ِ◌ِْ	/ʒ/
◌ِ◌ِْ + ◌ِ◌ِْ + ◌ِ◌ِْ	final short a · i · o

40. Final definition

Arabic-V is Masri's canonical vocalized Arabic-script representation: a dedicated Egyptian-oriented orthography that combines Arabic letters, Harakat, mandatory sukūn where required, shadda-based doubling, and defined Masri-specific letters, vowel conventions, and realization markers. Tanween is not written as a mark; the /n/ it stands for is written as the letter ن.

Its fundamental principle is:

■ ***One canonical Masri system, multiple controlled representations.***

Arabic-V therefore provides an Arabic-script representation that is recognizable, Egyptian-oriented, explicitly vocalized, information-preserving, pronunciation-aware, computationally useful, and extensible.

Source: this page documents the project's Arabic-V specification in full. The condensed marks and markers are also indexed as data in `assets/data/arabic-v.json` for lookup/tooling use; see the [Representations](#) page for how Arabic-V relates to Masri Standard, DRS, Masri Basic, and Arabic-P.

CHAPTER 8

Arabic-S (Simplified Arabic Vowel Script)

Arabic-S — Explicit Vowels, Arabic Letters

Arabic-S is a simplified Arabic-script orthography designed to represent Modern Egyptian with a more explicit vowel system while retaining the familiar visual basis of Arabic script. Unlike conventional Arabic orthography, Arabic-S gives vowels their own dedicated letters rather than relying primarily on ḥarakāt. It is one of the six [Masri representations](#) of the single canonical system, alongside Masri Standard, DRS, Arabic-V, Masri Basic, and Arabic-P.

Status: Arabic-S is a new, experimental representation, introduced here for the first time. **It has not yet been cross-checked against the full Arabic-V and DRS rule sets.** Its two dedicated vowel letters (آ , ع) are drawn from existing Unicode Arabic-script code points reused here for Egyptian vowels; the rest of the inventory reuses ordinary Arabic letters as vowel carriers instead of ḥarakāt.

1. What Arabic-S is

Arabic-S gives Egyptian vowels their own dedicated letters rather than relying primarily on ḥarakāt, so a word's vowel structure is visible directly in the spelling rather than left to inference or to small marks above and below the consonants. The result is intended to remain recognizably Arabic in appearance while reducing the ambiguity that ordinary unvocalized Arabic script normally carries.

2. Vowel inventory

Egyptian vowel	Arabic-S letter	Unicode	Function
a / á	ا	U+0627	Short/open a
e	ي	U+064A	Front e/i vowel according to position/rules
i	ي	U+064A	High front i
é / ε	ع	U+06CE	Open-mid front vowel /ε/
o	و	U+0648	Rounded o/u vowel
ou / o:	ؤ	U+06C6	Mid-rounded o vowel
glottal stop	ء	U+0621	/ʔ/

3. The dedicated é letter: ئ

The character ئ is U+06CE ARABIC LETTER YEH WITH SMALL V. Unicode classifies it as an independent Arabic-script letter rather than a combining mark, which makes it particularly suitable for Arabic-S: /ε/ can be represented by a single character without using a haraka. In Arabic-S its traditional Unicode name is retained, but its orthographic function is redefined as the Egyptian /ε/ vowel:

ئ = /ε/ = “é”

For example:

اسانسیر → ءاسانسیر

where ئ represents the long /ε:/ sequence, according to the system’s vowel-length convention.

4. The ou letter: ۆ

ۆ is U+06C6 ARABIC LETTER OE. Unicode already identifies it as an Arabic-script letter used in several languages, including Uyghur, Kurdish, Kazakh, Azerbaijani, and Bosnian. Arabic-S assigns it to the mid-rounded /o/ vowel:

ۆ = /o/ ~ /o:/ (“ou”)

This makes it a natural counterpart to ئ : ئ is the front/open vowel, ۆ is the rounded/back vowel.

Example: Farduus فاردؤؤس. The two letters are especially useful because both are already encoded as single Unicode Arabic letters, rather than requiring a combining mark.

5. Core principle

Arabic-S attempts to make the vowel structure visible directly in the spelling:

Traditional Arabic: consonant letters + optional ḥarakāt

Arabic-S: consonant letters + independent vowel letters

The result is intended to remain recognizably Arabic in appearance while reducing the ambiguity caused by an Arabic spelling system in which short vowels are normally omitted.

6. Worked example

ءاسانسیر can be analyzed as:

ء + ا + س + ئ + ئ + س + ن + ا + ر

with ئ representing the long é vowel. This illustrates the central idea of Arabic-S: the vowel is not a hidden ḥaraka or an inferred pronunciation — it is an ordinary letter in the written word.

CHAPTER 9

Grammar Reference

Masri Grammar Reference

Nouns, plurals, pronouns, verbs, negation, word order, and honorifics — adapted from the descriptive grammar of Modern Egyptian into Masri's DRS (keyboard-typable romanization) and Tier 2 (Academic, native script) orthographies. Every example runs Arabic → DRS → Tier 2 — three of the five [Masri representations](#) — so it can be checked line by line against the spelling rules on the [How Masri Works](#) and [Converter](#) pages.

El Abgadeyya El Masreyya — Grammar Companion Adapted from the descriptive grammar of Modern Egyptian (Cairene/Masri dialect) into the Masri writing system's DRS (keyboard-safe Latin romanization) and Tier 2 (Academic, Coptic/Greek/Latin-ext.) orthographies.

Status: first pass, drafted for review. Every example below runs Arabic → DRS → Tier 2 so mistakes are easy to spot line by line. Flag anything that looks wrong — several judgment calls are marked **[OPEN]** where the existing spelling rules didn't give a clean answer.

0. How to read this document

Every example is given as:

Arabic script – gloss
DRS (keyboard-safe): ...
Tier 2 (academic, native script): ...

DRS/Tier 2 spellings follow the rules already fixed in `assets/data/tier2-rules.json` and `assets/data/alphabet.json`:

Sound	Arabic	DRS	Tier 2	Note
/ʕ/	ع	ɛ	◀	"The ع Problem" — most critical rule in the system
/ħ/	ح	ħ	2	Never numeral 7 in either Masri tier
/ʃ/	ش	š	ω	Tier 2 is a single letter, not a digraph
/θ/	ث	ṯ → merges to s	θ → merges to s	Cairene merger is real, not an error
/ð/	ذ	ð → merges to z	ð → merges to z	Same logic as θ
/sˤ dˤ tˤ ðˤ/	ص ض ط ظ	ṣ, ḍ, ṭ, ḏ	ṣ, ḍ, ṭ, ḏ	ظ merges into ḍ in most Cairene speech
/ɣ/	غ	ġ	γ	Single letter in Tier 2
/ʔ/ (glottal stop)	ء / colloquial ق	ʔ, med-word/fenal only	ʔ, med-word/fenal only	Silent and unwritten word-initially in both tiers, regardless of etymology

Sound	Arabic	DRS	Tier 2	Note
/q/ (formal)	ق	q	q	Reserved for MSA/formal register; colloquial ق is the glottal stop above
el (definite article)	ال	el	el	Always spelled "el," always a separate word — never assimilated to sun letters, never fused to the following noun. Exception: a closed set of short prepositions/particles (li-, bi-, fi-, shortened a-/<a-, topicalizing ma) fuse with el into *lel, bel, fel, al/<al, Mal** — but the fused word then stays separate from the following noun, same as plain el (Rule 8, §6.3)

Three structural rules carry through every section below:

1. **El is a free particle.** It is written separate from the word it modifies, in every tier, regardless of how it actually assimilates in speech (el shams, not esh-shams) — except when li- or bi- precedes it (rule 3 below).
2. **ma is a free particle too, but -sh(i) is bound to the verb.** ma is written separately, like el; -sh(i) (and any object clitics between the verb and -sh(i)) fuses to the verb as one word — see §5.
3. **A closed set of short prepositions/particles fuse with el.** li-, bi-, fi-, shortened Ea-/<a-, and topicalizing ma become lel, bel, fel, Eal/<al, Mal as one word (but Eand never fuses, and negation ma never fuses with the verb — see §5) — see §6.3.

1. Nouns — no case, no nunation

Modern Egyptian nouns don't inflect for case, unlike Modern Standard Arabic. This is inherited wholesale by Masri: there is nothing to represent.

The one common survival is the frozen accusative in a handful of fixed expressions:

- شكراً — "thank you" DRS: **šokran** Tier 2: **wokran**

Rule: Masri never marks i3rab (case endings). A word's Masri spelling reflects only what is actually pronounced in the colloquial, pausal form — matching how Modern Egyptian itself treats nouns.

2. Plurals

2.1 Broken plurals

Broken plurals are template-based (the consonant skeleton stays, the vowel pattern changes).

Because Masri's letter substitutions are consonant-level, broken-plural templates transfer automatically — you just apply the consonant table to whichever slots the template happens to land on.

Meaning	Singular (Ar.)	Singular DRS / Tier 2	Plural (Ar.)	Plural DRS / Tier 2
desk/office	مكتب	maktab / maktab	مكاتب	makateb / makateb
key	مفتاح	muftaaḥ / muftaaḥ	مفاتيح	mafateeḥ / mafateeḥ
lesson	درس	dars / dars	دروس	doroos / doroos
drawer	درج	dorg / dorg	ادرار	adraag / adraag
shoe	جزمة	gazma / gazma	جزم	gezam / gezam
cigarette	سيجارة	segaara / segaara	سجاير	sagaayer / sagaayer
newspaper	جريدة	gareeda / gareeda	جرايد	garaayed / garaayed
teacher (occ.)	كاتب	kaateb / kaateb	كّتاب	kottaab / kottaab
poor (adj.)	فقير	faṽeer / faṽeer	فقرا	foṽara / foṽara

None of the plural templates themselves need new rules; they're pure vowel-pattern spelling, already covered by the existing vowel table. The only judgment calls are per-word, same as with any singular: does this particular root contain **ق/ع/ح/ث/ذ/ش/ق**?

2.1a Sound feminine plural (-aat)

Distinct from the broken-plural templates above: a closed class of feminine nouns pluralize by suffixing **-aat** (pronounced "aat," a long vowel) directly onto the singular stem, rather than reshuffling the internal vowel pattern.

Meaning	Singular	Plural	DRS / Tier 2
wife	meraāt	wives	meraāt → merataāt

This is the noun-side counterpart to the verb vowel-shortening rule in §5.1/Rule 7: attaching the -aat suffix shortens the stem's own long vowel (meraāt → marat-) before the long -aat suffix is added — the same shortening that -ha, -na, -kom, and -hom trigger on this and other nouns (§3.2).

2.2 Color and physical-defect nouns

These take a special ʔaCCaC / CaCCa / CuCC pattern (masc./fem./plural):

Meaning	Masc. (Ar.)	DRS / Tier 2	Fem.	DRS / Tier 2	Plural	DRS / Tier 2
green	أخضر	axdar / axdar	خضرا	xadra / xadra	خضر	xodr / xodr
blue	أزرق	azraṽ / azraṽ	زرقا	zarṽa / zarṽa	زرق	zorṽ / zorṽ
black	إسود	eswed / eswed	سودا	sooda / sooda	سود	sood / sood
white	أبيض	abyad / abyad	بيضا	beeda / beeda	بيض	beed / beed

Meaning	Masc. (Ar.)	DRS / Tier 2	Fem.	DRS / Tier 2	Plural	DRS / Tier 2
deaf	أطرش ش	aṭraṣ / aṭraṣ	طرشا	ṭarṣa / ṭarṣa	طرش	ṭorṣ / ṭorṣ
blind	أعمى	aʿma / aʿma	عمياء	ʿamya / ʿamya	عمي	ʿomy / ʿomy
one-eyed	أعور	aʿwar / aʿwar	عورا	ʿoor / ʿoor	عور	ʿoor / ʿoor

The rest of the color set (bunni "brown," ramaadi "gray," banafsegi "purple," etc.) are invariable nisba adjectives and need no special handling beyond normal DRS/Tier 2 letter substitution.

2.3 Dual number, and dual/plural of professional titles & nisba nouns

Modern Egyptian keeps a genuine dual: a masculine singular takes **-een**, and the corresponding feminine singular (formed the regular way, by adding *-a*) takes **-teen** in place of that final *-a*. It shows up clearly on the professional/honorific titles already introduced in §7 and used as the dual-agreement example in §6.3 — worth spelling out the full paradigm here rather than leaving it to a single example.

Spelling note: the dual suffix is written with **é** — **Ostazéen**, not *Ostazeen* — the same "café / letter-name-A" vowel from §3.2's pronunciation note. This keeps it visually distinct from the ordinary sound masculine plural suffix, which is spelled with a plain **ee** (the "redeem" vowel): the two suffixes look identical in Arabic script (عين either way) but are grammatically unrelated, so Masri spells them differently on purpose.

Shortening note: a stem's long vowel shortens before the dual suffix exactly as it already does before *-aat* and the "heavy" possessive clitics (Rule 7/9, §2.1a/§3.2) — **Ostaaz** shortens to **Ostaz-** before *-éen/-téén*, the same pattern as *béet*→*bétna*.

أستاذ (Ostaaz) "professor, sir" — the honorific already listed in §7:

	DRS	Tier 2
singular (masc.)	ostaaz	ostaaz
dual (masc.)	ostazéen	ostazéen
dual (fem.)	ostaztéén	ostaztéén
plural (broken; masc., also covers fem.)	asatza	asatza
plural (sound fem., -aat — rare in usage)	ostazaat	ostazaat

معلم (me'alleem) "boss, craftsman" — the honorific already listed in §7, with **ع** so DRS/Tier 2 diverge:

	DRS	Tier 2
singular (masc.)	meʿalleem	meʿalleem
dual (masc.)	meʿalleeméen	meʿalleeméen

	DRS	Tier 2
dual (fem.)	meEallemtéén	me<allemtéén
plural (masc., also covers fem.)	meEallemeen	me<allemeen
plural (sound fem., -aat — very rare)	meEallemaat	me<allemaat

مدرس (modarres) "teacher (school)" — no special letters, so DRS and Tier 2 match throughout:

	DRS	Tier 2
singular (masc.)	modarres	modarres
dual (masc.)	modarreséén	modarreséén
dual (fem.)	modarrestéén	modarrestéén
plural (masc.)	modarreseen	modarreseen
plural (fem.)	modarresaat	modarresaat

مصري (maşri) "Egyptian" — a nisba adjective, not a profession noun, included here for contrast:

	DRS	Tier 2
singular	maşri	maşri
plural	maşreeeyn	maşreeeyn

No dual form here: nisba adjectives of nationality/origin skip the dual entirely and use the plural even when referring to exactly two people — unlike the profession nouns above, which have a genuine dual.

3. Pronouns

3.1 Independent subject pronouns

Person	Arabic	DRS	Tier 2
I	أنا	ana	ana
you (m)	إنت	enta	enta
you (f)	إنتي	enti	enti
he	هو	howwa	howwa
she	هي	heyya	heyya
we	إحنا	eħna	eɁna
you (pl)	إنتو	ento	ento

Person	Arabic	DRS	Tier 2
they	هما	homma	homma

3.2 Possessive clitics on nouns

Attaching to a noun that ends in a vowel vs. one or two consonants changes the suffix shape — this is pure phonology and doesn't interact with any Masri-specific rule beyond "spell what's actually said." One phonological effect does need an explicit rule, though: **a medial/final long vowel in the noun shortens before the "heavier" clitic set** — -ha (her), -na (our), -kom (your pl.), -hom (their) — while the "lighter" set — -i (my), -ak/-ek (your m./f.), -o (his) — leaves it intact. This is the same shortening already formalized for verbs in Rule 7 (§5.1), now generalized to nouns as Rule 9.

Pronunciation note: long e (spelled **ee** per this doc's doubling convention) is pronounced like the long e in the English word "redeem", while the letter é is pronounced like the English letter name "A," or like the é in café — worth keeping in mind when reading béét, bétha, etc. out loud.

بيت (béét) "house"

	DRS	Tier 2
my house	bééti	bééti
your house (m)	béétak	béétak
your house (f)	béétek	béétek
his house	bééto	bééto
her house	bétha	bétha
our house	bétna	bétna
your house (pl)	bétkom	bétkom
their house	béthom	béthom

So the trigger class is: **-ha, -na, -kom, -hom, and the sound plural -aat all shorten the stem; -i, -ak, -ek, -o do not.** The heavier/lighter split lines up with person: 3rd fem. singular, 1st/2nd/3rd plural, and the plural marker all shorten; 1st singular, 2nd singular (both genders), and 3rd masc. singular don't. A second noun confirms the same split — زيت *zeet* "oil" and دقيق *de'ee'* (also spelled *d'ee'*, with syncope of the initial i) "flour," combined with -na:

زيتنا في دقيقنا — "our oil is in our flour" DRS: **Zetna fi dVeVna** Tier 2: **Zetna fi dVeVna**

Both *zeet*→*zetna* and *de'ee'*/d'ee'→d'e'na shorten the long ee to a single e before -na, exactly like *béét*→*bétna* — and d'e'na additionally shows the same first-syllable syncope already documented for verbs (§5.1: *kiber*→*keber*), now confirmed on a noun too.

مراة (meraat-) "wife" (construct form) — chosen because the root's **أ** needs the mid-word **∇** rule:

DRS		Tier 2
my wife	meraati	meraati
his wife	meraato	meraato
her wife	meratha	meratha

أب (abu-) "father" — irregular construct base, worth flagging because it keeps the old *-u* construct ending that MSA lost in colloquial elsewhere:

DRS		Tier 2
my father	abooya	abooya
your father (m)	abook	abook
his father	aboo(h)	aboo(h)

3.3 Object clitics on verbs

شفت (shoft) "I saw" — per the standing rule that this root is always *shoft*, never *sheft*:

DRS		Tier 2
I saw him	şofto	şofto
I saw her	şoftaha	şoftaha
I saw them	şoftohom	şoftohom

Stacked direct + indirect object, from the source grammar's own example (أجيهولك):

- أجيب — ageeb / ageeb "I bring"
- أجيهولك — ageb-huu-lek → Masri: agebhuulek / agebhuulek "I bring it to you"
- ما أجيهولكش — ma-ageb-huu-lek-sh → Masri: magebholkeesh / magebholkeesh

3.4 Suffixed prepositions

A representative set (fi "in," ʔala "on," ʔand "to have"):

fi "in"		ʕala "on"	ʕand "to have"
Arabic base	في	على	عند
...me	feyya / feyya	ʕalayya / <alayya	ʕandi / <andi
...you (m)	feek / feek	ʕaleek / <aleek	ʕandak / <andak
...him	fee(h) / fee(h)	ʕalee(h) / <alee(h)	ʕando / <ando
...her	feeha / feeha	ʕaleeha / <aleeha	ʕandaha / <andaha

Shortened form: unsuffixed $\text{ʕala}/\text{ʕala}$ ("on, about") can shorten to $\text{ʕa}/\text{ʕa}$ usually before **el** and **elli** — اللي, "which/that/who," the Modern Egyptian equivalent of MSA الذي:

- على اللي فات "about what happened/the past" → **ʕa elli faat** / **ʕa elli faat** (rather than the fuller ʕala elli faat / ʕala elli faat)

When the shortened $\text{ʕa}/\text{ʕa}$ precedes **el** specifically, the two go on to fuse into a single word — **ʕa + el** → **ʕal** / **ʕa + el** → **ʕal** — the same pattern as **li+el**→**lel** and **bi+el**→**bel** (Rule 8, §6.3):

- يلا ع القهوة (= يلا على القهوة) "come on, let's go for coffee" DRS: **Yalla ʕal ahwa.** (= fuller, unfused **Yalla ʕala el ahwa.**) Tier 2: **Yalla ʕal ahwa.** (= fuller, unfused **Yalla ʕala el ahwa.**)

ka "like, as": a comparison particle, spelled and pronounced the same in DRS and Tier 2. Unlike **fi-**, $\text{ʕa-}/\text{ʕa-}$, and **bi-**, **ka** does not fuse with a following **el** — a surface **kal** would collide with the unrelated past-tense verb **kal** "ate," so the two words are always kept visually and phonetically distinct. Whether **ka + el** comes out as **ka + el**, **ka + geminated-consonant**, etc. depends on the ordinary sun/moon-letter assimilation the following noun's initial consonant triggers on the definite article "el" (§1) — **ka** itself never changes shape or absorbs the **el**:

في مسلسل النص الثاني هتلاقي النص دائماً يقول ان السقسوقة كالتالي.
Fi mosalsal El Noşş El Taani ha tlaaʕi daymann in El Noşş beyʕool inn el saʕsooʕa ka el taali.

Wrong: *Fi mosalsal El Noşş El Taani ha tlaaʕi daymann in El Noşş beyʕool inn el saʕsooʕa kal taali.* — fusing (**ka + el**) into **kal** here is incorrect, since it's indistinguishable from the past-tense verb **kal** "ate."

4. Verbs

4.1 Root-and-pattern basics

Modern Egyptian verbs are built from a 3- or 4-consonant root plus a vowel/affix pattern. Since Masri's substitution table operates at the consonant level, this system transfers cleanly: **whichever slot in the pattern the root's ع/ح/ث/ذ/ش/ق lands in, apply the same substitution you'd apply anywhere else.**

The dictionary-citation form is the 3rd person masculine singular past (Arabic has no infinitive) — e.g. كتب *katab* "he wrote," cited as *katab/yekteb*.

4.2 Full paradigm: يكتب / يكتب (katab/yekteb "write") — no special letters, control example

	Singular	Plural
Past 1st	katabt	katabna

	Singular	Plural
Past 2nd m	katabt	katabtu
Past 2nd f	katabti	—
Past 3rd m	katab	katabu
Past 3rd f	kabet	—
Pres. subj. 1st	akteb	nekteb
Pres. subj. 2nd m	tekteb	tektebu
Pres. subj. 2nd f	tektebi	—
Pres. subj. 3rd m	yekteb	yektebu
Pres. subj. 3rd f	tekteb	—
Pres. indic. (add bi-)	beyekteb	benekteb
Future (add ha-)	hakkeb	hanekteb
Imperative	ikteb / iktebi	iktebu

3rd person present indicative always takes the fuller **beye-** shape (confirmed) — never the reduced *b-* form.

4.3 Verb with **حب / يحب** (ḥabb/yiḥibb "love")

	DRS	Tier 2
I loved	ḥabbéēt	ḡabbéēt
he loved	ḥabb	ḡabb
he loves	beyeḥebb	beyeḡebb
I don't love (see §6)	ma ḥabbetš(i)	ma ḡabbetw(i)

4.4 Verb with **عرف / يعرف** (eref/yiraf "know")

	DRS	Tier 2
I know	baʕraf	ba<raf
he knows	beyeʕraf	beye<raf
knowing (participle)	ʕaaref	<aaref

(This is the same **aaref** used as the flagship example in the site's own *ayin_rule* documentation — good cross-check that the grammar doc and the alphabet doc agree.)

4.5 Hollow and doubled verbs

Two structurally important classes, since they behave differently from the strong-verb template above:

Hollow (gaab/yegeeb "bring" — middle root letter و/ي):

DRS/Tier 2	
I brought	gebt
he brought	gaab
he brings	beygeeb

Doubled (ḥabb/yiḥibb, shown above) and baṣṣ/yebuṣṣ "look":

	DRS	Tier 2
I looked	baṣṣeet	baṣṣeet
he looks	beyboṣṣ	beyboṣṣ

4.6 Form overview (selected, not exhaustive)

Form	Function	Example (Ar.)	DRS	Tier 2
I	base	كتب/يكتب	katab/yekdeb	katab/yekdeb
II	causative/intensive	درس/يدرس "teach"	darres/yedarres	darres/yedarres
III	associative	زاکر/يزاکر "study (with)"	zaaker/yezaaker	zaaker/yezaaker
V	reflexive of II	اتكلم/يتكلم "speak"	etkallem/yetkallem	etkallem/yetkallem
VII	passive of I	انبسط/ينبسط "enjoy oneself"	enbasat/yenbeset	enbasat/yenbeset
VIII	reflexive/reciprocal	اشترى/يشترى "buy"	eštara/yešteri	ewtara/yewteri
X	requestive	استعمل/يستعمل "use"	estaʿmal/yestaʿmel	estaʿmal/yestaʿmel

Note: Form VII انبسط/ينبسط (enbasat/yenbeset) has a valid variant with the VII shape اتبسط/يتبسط — etbasat/yetbeset. Both are technically the same verb; either spelling is correct.

Full paradigms for every form × root-type combination (hollow, defective, doubled, assimilated) run to several dozen tables in the source grammar — worth a separate `masri_verb_tables.md` if you want the complete reference rather than this representative slice. Flag if you want that built out next.

4.7 Tenses — full overview

§4.2's paradigm table already gives past, present, future, and imperative one person at a time; this section pulls every tense/aspect together on a single root — **katab/yekdeb** "write," no special letters, so DRS and Tier 2 match throughout — and adds the compound tenses (built with **kaan**

"was" or the active participle) that don't get their own column in §4.2. "Tense" is used loosely here, per the source grammar's own usage: Masri, like Modern Egyptian generally, marks these by prefix/particle/auxiliary rather than by a rich inflectional tense paradigm, and a couple of the rows below are really aspect or mood, not strict tense.

Tense/aspect	Arabic (how wa "he")	DRS	Tier 2	Built from
Past (perfective)	كتب	katab	katab	bare past stem (§4.2)
Present habitual/progressive	بيكتب ب	beyekte b	beyekte b	bi- + present subjunctive (§4.2). Masri doesn't grammatically split "he writes" from "he is writing" — both are beyekteb , disambiguated by context or a time word, same as Modern Egyptian generally.
Future	هيكته ب	hayekte b	hayekte b	ha- + present subjunctive (§4.2, and already used this way at §5)
Imperative	اكتب	ikteb	ikteb	bare imperative stem (§4.2)
Past habitual/progressive	كان بيكتب ب	kaan beyekte b	kaan beyekte b	kaan + present habitual — "he was writing / he used to write"
Past perfect (pluperfect)	كان كتب	kaan katab	kaan katab	kaan + simple past — "he had written"
Future perfect	هيكو ن كتب	haykoon katab	haykoon katab	haykoon (future of kaan) + simple past — "he will have written"
Near-future / "almost" (kaan + future)	كان هيكته ب	kaan hayekte b	kaan hayekte b	kaan + future — "he was about to write / he almost wrote." Per the source grammar, kaan + ha-imperfect specifically marks something that nearly or almost happened.
Resultative/perfect (active participle)	هو كاتب	howwa kaateb	howwa kaateb	active participle standing in for a present-tense verb, describing a completed action or the state it left behind rather than the bare action itself — the same construction as aaref/āaref "knowing" at §4.4

All the compound rows above run on **kaan/yekoon** "was/will be," which is irregular enough (hollow root, no bi-/ha- on the past) to be worth its own paradigm rather than assuming it inflects like katab/yekteb:

	Past ("was")	Present subj./future ("be")
1st sg.	kunt	akoon
2nd sg. m	kunt	tkoon
2nd sg. f	konti	tkooni
3rd sg. m	kaan	yekoon
3rd sg. f	kaanet	tkoon

	Past ("was")	Present subj./future ("be")
1st pl.	konna	nkoon
2nd pl.	kontu	tkoonu
3rd pl.	kaanu	yekoonu

Negating a compound tense: only **kaan** takes the *ma-...-sh(i)* circumfix (§5) — the second element (present, past, or future form) stays bare, the same "negate the first/finite element only" pattern as ordinary negation. **Kaan** also shortens before *-sh(i)*, same vowel-shortening trigger already documented for verbs and nouns at §5.1/§3.2:

- ما كانش بيكتب — "he wasn't writing / he didn't use to write" DRS/Tier 2: **ma kansh(i) beyekdeb**
- ما كانش كتب — "he hadn't written" DRS/Tier 2: **ma kansh(i) katab**
- ما كانش هيكاتب — "he wasn't about to write" DRS/Tier 2: **ma kansh(i) hayekdeb**

The resultative/participle row negates like any other participle used as a predicate — *mesh* + participle, the same "separate word, not the circumfix" pattern future takes at §5 — **howwa mesh kaateb** "he hasn't written (it) / he isn't in the state of having written."

4.8 Passive Voice

MSA's internal-vowel passive (كُتِبَ *kuteba* "it was written," vowels shifted inside the same root) doesn't survive productively in Modern Egyptian or Masri — it only turns up in a handful of frozen literary/religious set phrases and isn't a live pattern for coining new passives. The everyday passive is periphrastic instead: prefix a derived verb form onto the Form I root, reusing machinery §4.6 already introduced for other reasons.

Passive of Form I — اكتب/يكتب → كُتِبَ/يُكْتَب (itkatab/yetketeḇ) "be written," no special letters:

	DRS	Tier 2
it was written (m)	itkatab	itkatab
it was written (f)	itkatabet	itkatabet
they were written	itkatabu	itkatabu
it is/being written	beyetketeḇ	beyetketeḇ
it will be written	hayetketeḇ	hayetketeḇ

Negation follows §5 as normal, and follows the same stem-initial elision already documented there for *extaar-xtarsh(i)* (§5.1): the initial *i* of *itkatab* drops after *ma*, giving **ma tkatabsh(i)** "it wasn't written" rather than the fuller *ma itkatabsh(i)*.

A fully interchangeable **n**-variant also exists — انكتب/ينكتب **inkatab/yenketeb** — the same free, speaker-by-speaker variation §4.6 already flagged for VII vs. VIIt (enbasat vs. etbasat). Either spelling is correct; use whichever matches the pronunciation you're transcribing.

Passive of higher forms works the same way, by stepping to the paired derived form:

- Form II → Form V: علم/يعلم (allem/yiallem "teach") — اتعلم/يتعلم (itallem/yitallem) "be taught" — the same shape as the Form V reflexive already given at §4.6 (etkallem "speak," reflexive of II كلم "make talk"). Form V covers both jobs — reflexive of II and passive of II — and for teaching verbs specifically often blurs into "learn," the same double duty English "taught himself" vs. "was taught" maps onto.

الولد اتعلم العزف في المعهد — "The boy was taught to play music at the institute"

DRS: el walad etEallem el Eazf fel maEhad.

Tier 2: el walad it◀allem el ◀azf fel ma◀had.

- Form III → Form VI: زاکر/يزاکر (zaaker/yezaaker "study with," Form III) — اتزاکر/يتزاکر (etzaaker/yetzaaker) "be studied together" — the reciprocal/passive of the Form III example already used at §4.6, which didn't get its own row there since Form VI wasn't in that selected list.

Passive participle (اسم المفعول): a separate construction from the derived-verb passive above, and specific to Form I. Pattern **maCCuuC**, used adjectivally/statively — describing the resulting condition rather than the event — the passive counterpart of the active participle at §4.4 (Eaaref "knowing"):

Form I	Arabic	DRS	Tier 2
katab "write"	مكتوب	maktuub	maktuub
kasar "break"	مكسور	maksuur	maksuur
eref "know"	معروف	maEruuf	ma◀ruuf

Per the source grammar, the itkatab-type derived passives don't have a passive participle of their own — for a passive adjective you reach for this Form I maCCuuC pattern instead. So **maktuub** covers "written" as a description (ده مكتوب — "this is [in a] written [state]"), while **itkatab/yetketeb** covers "was/will be written" as an event.

5. Negation: ma (separate) + verb-sh(i) (glued)

This is the single highest-frequency structural pattern in the language, so it earns its own section.

Rule (revised): to avoid producing a very large fused cluster, **ma** is written as its own separate word — the same free-particle treatment as **el** — while **-sh/-esh/-sh(i)** stays glued to the verb (and any object clitics on it). This mirrors how Modern Egyptian is actually written in Arabic script, where ما is its own word and the ش suffix attaches to the verb. This replaces the earlier fully-fused treatment of the whole circumfix.

Arabic	Gloss	DRS	Tier 2
ما كتبش	he didn't write	ma katabû(i)	ma katabu(i)
ما بيكتبش	he doesn't write	ma beyektebû(i)	ma beyektebu(i)
ما كتبهمليش	he didn't write them to me	ma katabhomleeû	ma katabhomleew
مش هيكتب	he won't write (<i>future uses a separate word, not the circumfix</i>)	meû hayekteb	mew hayekteb
مش كتب؟	didn't he write? (<i>interrogative negation</i>)	meû katab?	mew katab?

Three fuller examples, showing *ma* separated before different word classes (a plain verb, a presentative/copula-like word, and a possession verb with object clitic):

- ماكتبش الواجب ليه؟ — "Why didn't he do the homework?!" DRS: **Ma katabû(i) el waageb leeh?!** Tier 2: **Ma katabu(i) el waageb leeh?!**
- ما هو الحال ده مينفعش — "Well, this situation isn't workable." (ما هو itself can fuse or stay separate — see below; the verbal negation مينفعش stays "ma" + glued verb) DRS: **Mahu (Ma ahu) el haal da ma yenfaʕsh(i).** Tier 2: **Mahu (Ma ahu) el ʒaal da ma yenfaʕsh(i).**
- ما احنا كل شوية معندناش من المنتج ده — "We don't have any of this product every other minute" (i.e. we keep running out) DRS: **Ma eħna (Maħna — surface pronunciation in rapid speech) koll šwayya ma ʔendenaaû min el montagg da(h).** Tier 2: **Ma eʒna (Maʒna — surface pronunciation in rapid speech) koll uwayya ma ʔndenaaw min el montagg da(h).**

Two things worth noting from these: 1. **ما هو (ma + huwa)** — a presentative/topicalizing "ma," not the verbal negator — has both a fused everyday form (**Mahu**) and a fuller separated form (**Ma ahu**); both are correct, the fused one is just the faster, more contracted pronunciation. 2. **ما احنا (ma + eħna)** similarly has a careful separated form (**Ma eħna**) and a fast-speech fused variant (**Maʒna**) — this fused variant is a *pronunciation* note, not a rewrite of the spelling rule: the standard written form keeps *ma* separate.

5.0a Bare *ma* (no -sh(i)) — oath/emphatic negation

A separate, valid negation pattern uses **ma alone, with no -sh(i) suffix at all** — most typically in oaths and emphatic swearing formulas, a more classical/literary-feeling register than the everyday *ma-...-sh(i)*:

- عليا النعمة ما عملت حاجة — "By the blessing upon me (I swear), I didn't do a thing!" DRS: **ʕalayya el neʕma ma ʕamalt haaga!** Tier 2: **ʕalayya el neʕma ma ʕamalt ʒaaga!**

Here *ma* negates *amalt* directly with nothing glued after it — no *-sh(i)*, and no shortening/syncope/epenthesis effects either, since those are specifically triggered by adding *-sh(i)* (§5.1). This bare-*ma* pattern is a distinct register choice, not an abbreviation of the *ma-...-sh(i)* form.

5.1 Phonological knock-on effects (on the glued verb-*sh(i)* portion)

The source grammar documents several vowel changes triggered by adding *-sh* to the verb. These stay exactly as documented before — only the spacing of *ma* relative to the verb has changed, not the internal phonology of the verb+*sh(i)* unit:

Resolved — Rule 7 (`tier2-rules.json`): these three effects (shortening, syncope, epenthesis) are a formal, explicit rule, treated the same way the $\theta \rightarrow s$ and $\delta \rightarrow z$ Cairene mergers are — spelled out, not left implicit:

- **Shortening:** اختار *extaar* → ما اختارش *ma khtarsh(i)* / **ma xtarw(i)** — the long *aa* shortens before the single final consonant.
- **Syncope:** كبر *keber* → ما كبرش *ma kbersh(i)* / **ma kberw(i)** — the short first-syllable vowel drops.
- **Epenthesis:** كنت *kont* → ما كنتش *ma kontesh(i)* / **ma kontew(i)** — an *e* is inserted so the word doesn't end in a three-consonant cluster.

Confirmed: the elision still happens even with *ma* written separately — *extaar* "he chose" negates to **ma xtarsh(i)** (not *ma extaarsh(i)*):

- الرجل اختار شريكة حياته — "The man chose his spouse" DRS/Tier 2: **El raagel extaar shereeket hayaato.**
- الولد ما اختارش لسه الألوان — "The boy hasn't chosen the colors yet" DRS/Tier 2: **El walad ma xtarsh(i) lessa el alwaan.**

6. Word order & syntax notes

These don't change spelling, but they matter for anything downstream that generates or corrects full sentences (the meaning-aware model in particular) — flagging them here so nothing "corrects" a grammatical Masri sentence into MSA word order.

6.1 SVO, not VSO

Masri/Modern Egyptian prefers Subject–Verb–Object, unlike Classical/MSA's Verb–Subject–Object:

- عادل قرا الكتاب — "Adel read the book" DRS: **Eaadel ara el ketaab** Tier 2: **◀aadel ara el ketaab**

6.2 Wh-in-situ (question words stay in place — with flexibility)

This is flagged in the source grammar as a likely feature inherited from the Coptic substratum — directly relevant to the project's own legitimacy narrative, since it's an actual documented Coptic-influence claim you can cite rather than assert. That said, wh-in-situ isn't rigid: fronting the question word is also grammatical, giving two valid word orders for the same question.

Arabic	Gloss	DRS (in-situ)	Tier 2 (in-situ)	DRS/Tier 2 (fronted alternative)
راح مصر امتى؟	When did he go to Egypt?	raaḥ maşr emta?	raa2 maşr emta?	Emta raa2 maşr?
راح مصر ليه؟	Why did he go to Egypt?	raaḥ maşr leeh?	raa2 maşr leeh?	Leeh raa2 maşr?
مين اللي راح مصر؟	Who went to Egypt?	meen elli raaḥ maşr?	meen elli raa2 maşr?	— (<i>meen is already clause-ineteal here</i>)

Compare to MSA, which always fronts. Masri/Modern Egyptian allows both — worth keeping both orders in mind for anything downstream that generates or corrects full sentences, so a fronted question isn't flagged as wrong.

6.3 Dual agreement collapses to plural

Dual nouns stay grammatically dual in form but trigger **plural** agreement on verbs, demonstratives, and adjectives:

- الأستاذين السوريين دول يمشوا للجامعة — "These two Syrian professors are walking to the university" DRS: **el ostazéen el soreyyeen dool beyemşu lel gamɛa** Tier 2: **el ostazéen el soreyyeen dool beyemwu lel gam<a**

Full dual/plural paradigm for ostaaz (and other professional titles) is in §2.3.

Resolved — Rule 8: li- and el fuse into their own single word — **lel** — bi- and el fuse into **bel**, fi- and el fuse into **fel**, the shortened a/<a (§3.4) fuses with el into ****al/<al**, and the topicalizing/emphatic particle **ma** (§5, distinct from negation **ma**) fuses with el into **Mal****:

- ما المهمة دي لازم تخلص يا حضرات — "This task has to get done, ladies and gentlemen" DRS: **Ma el mohemma di laazem texlaş ya ḥaḍaraat.** (= fused **Mal mohemma di laazem texlaş ya ḥaḍaraat.**) Tier 2: **Ma el mohemma di laazem texlaş ya 2aḍaraat.** (= fused **Mal mohemma di laazem texlaş ya 2aḍaraat.**)

But that resulting word then behaves exactly like plain el: it stays **separate from the noun that follows it**, the same free-particle treatment as el itself (§0). So the fusion is preposition/particle+el only — it doesn't extend to the following noun. Not every preposition does this: ****and ("to have") + el stays two separate words —and el, never andel**** — so this is a closed list of short/light elements (li-, bi-, fi-, the shortened a-, and this topicalizing ma), not a blanket rule for every preposition or particle.

Important distinction: this Ma+el–Mal fusion applies to the *topicalizing/emphatic* ma directly preceding el — it does **not** apply to the *negation* ma, which stays separate from the verb it negates regardless of what follows (Rule 10, §5). The two ma's are different words that happen to look identical; whether they fuse with a following el depends on which one it is, not on the letter sequence alone.

- للجامعة → lel gamʕa / lel gamʕa "to the university"
- بالكتاب → bel ketaab / bel ketaab "with/by the book"
- (= في الصميم) ف الصميم "right in the heart of it" → fel ṣameem (= fuller, unfused fi el ṣameem)

7. Honorifics (brief)

Not grammar in the strict sense, but structurally regular enough to standardize spelling for, since they appear constantly in dialogue-heavy writing (including your Fourth Alphabet fiction). No special letters needed for most of these:

Term	Arabic	DRS	Tier 2	Use
bāsha	باشا	baša	baʃa	informal address, male peer
hānim	هانم	hanem	hanem	address to a woman of high standing (archaic/humorous now)
ustāz	أستاذ	ostaaz	ostaaz	teacher/expert, generic respectful address (dual/plural: §2.3)
me'allem	معلم	meʕallem	meʕallem	working-class male address (dual/plural: §2.3)
ra'īs	رئيس	raʕees	raʕees	boss, skilled laborer's title
bashmohandes	باش مهندس	bašmohandes	baʃmohandes	engineer / generic middle-class male address

8. Summary of open items for review

Resolved:

- §5 (ma vs. -sh(i) spacing) — ma is now written separately, verb+object-clitics+sh(i) stays glued — formal Rule 10; §5.1's phonological effects on the glued portion remain formal Rule 7.
- §6.3 (li+el/bi+el/fi+el/ʕa+el/topicalizing-ma+el → lel/bel/fel/ʕal/Mal, staying separate from the following noun; ʕand+el and negation-ma never fuse) — formal Rule 8.
- §3.2 / §2.1a (noun vowel shortening) — formal Rule 9, now confirmed across two nouns (béét, zeet/de'ee') and the full clitic set: -ha/-na/-kom/-hom/-aat shorten, -i/-ak/-ek/-o don't.
- §3.4 (ala/ʕala → a/ʕa shortening before elli) — formal Rule 11.
- §6.2 (wh-in-situ has a fronted alternative — both orders are grammatical).

- The complete Form I–X × root-type verb matrix is now a standalone companion doc: `masri_verb_tables.md`.

All open items are resolved. §5.1's stem-initial elision (extaar → xtarsh(i)) is confirmed by example even with ma separated (§5). All three new rules are written into `assets/data/tier2-rules.json` directly, alongside this doc.

Source: grammar content adapted from the English Wikipedia article "Egyptian Arabic" (retrieved 2026-09-06), cross-checked against this repo's `assets/data/alphabet.json` and `assets/data/tier2-rules.json` for all letter substitutions.

CHAPTER 10

The Loanword Policy

Masri Tier 2 Loanword Policy

A rigorous, internally consistent standard for spelling loanwords in Masri Tier 2 — when to keep a foreign pronunciation, when to Egyptianize it, how to derive one canonical spelling instead of unlimited free variation, and how integration into Egyptian grammar works. Cross-checked against `assets/data/tier2-rules.json` and the letter inventory on the [Alphabet](#) page; builds on the verb and noun morphology in the [Grammar Reference](#).

Masri Tier 2 Loanword Policy Extends Masri Tier 2 — a phonemic, near-phonemic Latin/Coptic/Greek-based orthography for Modern Egyptian — to loanwords, without turning it into a transliteration scheme for the donor language and without opening the door to unlimited spelling variation.

Status: first pass, drafted for review, same convention as the Grammar Reference. Populates `loanword_examples` and adds formal `spelling_rules` ids 12–16 to `assets/data/tier2-rules.json`. Deliberately does **not** add anything to `extra_letters` in either data file — see §4 and §13, rule M4: no new Tier 2 letters are introduced for this.

0. Design goals

1. **Encode pronunciation, not source spelling.** A Tier 2 loanword spelling represents how the reference Cairene speaker actually says the word, never how it's spelled in English, French, or any other donor language.
2. **Support both retained-foreign and Egyptianized pronunciations** — both are real, attested things Cairene speakers do — decided by lexical status and attested pronunciation, never by how "English" a word looks in writing.
3. **One canonical spelling per loanword sense**, with genuinely attested secondary pronunciations recorded as explicit accepted variants — never silent, uncontrolled variation.
4. **Reuse the extra letters Tier 2 already has** (P, V, C, and J — see the [Alphabet](#) page) rather than inventing new ones, per the site's existing "no new letters" design principle. P, V, and C are loanword-specific; J is shared with two native uses (Upper Egyptian Şa'idi ج and MSA ج), so a loanword /ʒ/ simply reuses a letter that already exists for other reasons.
5. **A graded nativization threshold**, not a binary foreign/native switch — loanwords visibly sit at different points along the same continuum, and the policy should say so explicitly instead of forcing every word into one of two boxes.

1. Core principle

Masri Tier 2 primarily encodes **pronunciation** — specifically the reference Cairene speaker's actual, attested pronunciation of the word, in whatever register it's being used — filtered through Egyptian phonological structure only where that structure is actually applied in speech, never imposed on a word that isn't pronounced that way. This is the same standard the rest of Masri already holds native vocabulary to (spelling documents what's said, not an idealized "correct" form); loanwords don't get a different rule, they get the same rule applied to a wider, more variable set of attested pronunciations.

When principles conflict, this ranking applies (expanded into a full hierarchy at §12):

1. Attested pronunciation
2. Phonemic contrast Tier 2 already provides a letter for (don't collapse p/v/j into b/f/g just because the word is foreign)
3. Lexical/morphological transparency
4. Source-language spelling resemblance — lowest priority, and not a goal in its own right.

One clarification worth stating up front: the site's existing design principle "orthography over phonetics where the two conflict" (e.g. the definite article always spelled **el** regardless of sun/moon-letter assimilation) governs a specific, closed set of native morphological spellings. It is not license to spell loanwords by their donor-language letters — for loanwords, pronunciation stays on top.

2. Loanword status model

Seven categories, each with a default spelling strategy. A word's category is diagnosed from the criteria in §11, not chosen arbitrarily.

#	Category	Description	Default spelling strategy
1	Fully integrated loan	Takes native Egyptian derivational morphology (feminine, plural, verbal derivation); no longer perceived as foreign by most speakers	Spelled per its dominant Egyptianized pronunciation as an ordinary Masri lexical item; foreign phonemes may nativize (p→b, v→f) once derivational morphology is also present (§7)
2	Common code-switched word	Frequent, fixed form, only loosely integrated (at most a bare plural)	Spelled per actual attested pronunciation, keeping p/v/j if that's how it's said
3	Technical/international term	Belongs to a register (tech, science, medicine) where a source-like pronunciation is normal for speakers of that register	Canonical = dominant ordinary-speech pronunciation (often already Egyptianized); source-like form recorded as an accepted formal/technical variant, not a second arbitrary spelling
4	Proper noun	Personal, city, or country names	See §8 — prioritizes local attested pronunciation, with source form as a documentation aid only

#	Category	Description	Default spelling strategy
5	Brand/trademark	Commercial and product names	See §8 — spelled per attested local pronunciation, which is often already informally Egyptianized
6	Recent borrowing	Not yet phonologically or grammatically settled	Provisional canonical spelling via straightforward phoneme mapping of the attested pronunciation (§4); revisited once usage stabilizes — an escape valve, not license for free variation
7	Semi-integrated hybrid	Foreign root combined with a genuine Egyptian derivational pattern already in productive use	Root spelled per its adapted pronunciation; the pattern itself spelled per ordinary Masri verb/noun-pattern rules (Grammar Reference §1–§4)

3. Retained vs. Egyptianized pronunciation

The choice between a retained-foreign and an Egyptianized pronunciation is governed by **attested pronunciation and lexical status** (§2) — never by whether the word looks English on the page.

Retained/foreign-leaning is the expected default for: Category 3–5 items in formal, technical, or naming contexts, and Category 6 items too new to have developed a settled Egyptianized form yet.

Egyptianized is the expected default for: Category 1 items, and any item once its dominant attested pronunciation in ordinary informal Cairene speech shows adapted phonology (consonant substitution, cluster simplification, vowel shift).

The mechanism is the same one Tier 2 already uses for native sound change: spelling documents attested pronunciation, and if the dominant pronunciation of a Category 3 term later shifts toward the Egyptianized form (attested, not assumed), its canonical spelling updates to match. The system never *prescribes* a target pronunciation for a loanword to "become more Egyptian" — it records what's actually said.

4. Adaptation rules

Masri Tier 2 does not assume every foreign sound must be converted to its closest Egyptian neighbor. Where Tier 2 already has a letter for the foreign phoneme, that contrast is preserved by default (see §1's ranking); only where no letter exists does the sound fold into something else, and even then a digraph or existing allophonic pattern is preferred over inventing a new letter.

Sound / structure	Default Tier 2 treatment	Notes
/p/	p — own letter, not merged to b	Alphabet rule "p ≠ b"; nativizes to b only once morphologically integrated (§7), e.g. bitza → bitzaya

Sound / structure	Default Tier 2 treatment	Notes
/v/	v — own letter, not merged to f	Alphabet rule "v ≠ f"; nativization to f is rare even at full integration — an empirical asymmetry with /p/, stated as observed rather than derived (see vitrina, §14)
/ɹ/ (English r)	r	Masri doesn't distinguish r-qualities; all collapse to the one Egyptian tapped r
/ʒ/	j where the loanword's /ʒ/ is being treated as the same sound as native ج (§ Alphabet's J — the Şa'idi/MSA register); otherwise ʁ by default, or g in older, already fully nativized loans (mostly French-origin) that historically hard-g'd	Three real, attested outcomes, not a foreign-vs-native binary — which applies is decided by §11's threshold and register, not by guessing at a word's age alone (see §16)
/tʃ/	digraph t + ʁ (tsh) where retained; simplifies to plain ʁ in fully nativized forms	Genuinely two letters/one cluster, not a new unit — compare sandwich (retains tsh) vs. chips (simplifies to ʁ) at §14
/ŋ/	n before a velar consonant	Allophonic, not phonemic, in Modern Egyptian; no dedicated letter needed, matches native n-before-velar behavior
/θ/ (loanword)	t	Distinct from the native θ→s Cairene merger — a different, loanword-specific substitution (thermos → tarmas)
/ð/ (loanword)	d	Distinct from the native ð→z Cairene merger, same logic as θ above
Foreign vowel contrasts (English tense/lax, French nasal vowels, etc.)	Collapsed to the nearest Masri vowel (a/e/i/o/u, long or short)	No new vowel symbols; where Egyptian pronunciation itself doesn't preserve the contrast, the spelling doesn't either
Diphthongs	Nearest existing vowel+glide sequence (ay, aw, ...)	No new letters; see mobile → mobayl at §14
Schwa / reduced vowels	Whichever full Masri vowel the actual pronunciation uses (often short i or a, sometimes dropped)	Never written as a distinct "reduced vowel" symbol — Masri writes what's said, not the source vowel's phonetic quality
Word-initial consonant clusters	Retained as pronounced by default	Egyptian speakers commonly do keep them in loanwords, unlike native phonotactics; an epenthesized variant is recorded only where actually attested as common, never invented by rule
Word-medial/final clusters	Same — written as pronounced, epenthetic vowel only where actually said	—
Word-final consonants	No special rule needed	Masri's syllable structure already tolerates them; loanwords aren't different from native words here

Sound / structure	Default Tier 2 treatment	Notes
Stress	Not marked	Masri never marks stress orthographically, native or borrowed; stress shift under Egyptianization (very common) simply isn't written, the same way it isn't for native words
Long/short vowels	Existing double-letter/single-letter convention (Rule 1)	A loanword vowel actually pronounced long in Cairene speech is doubled; one pronounced short isn't — regardless of the donor language's own vowel length

5. Decision algorithm

A precise enough procedure that two people applying it independently should usually reach the same result:

1. **How does the reference Cairene speaker actually pronounce the word — attested, not assumed?** Same evidentiary standard the rest of Masri already holds native words to.
2. **Does that pronunciation already differ from the source-language pronunciation** (consonant substitution, cluster simplification, vowel or stress shift)? If there's no adaptation at all, treat the word as retained/foreign-leaning for now; if it's adapted, continue.
3. **What's the word's lexical status** (§2's seven categories, diagnosed via §11)? This sets the default register expectation the attested form is checked against — the attested form from step 1 always wins if it conflicts with the category default, since pronunciation sits at the top of the conflict hierarchy (§12).
4. **Has the word taken native Egyptian derivational morphology** (feminine, plural, diminutive, verbal derivation)? If so, mark it Category 1 or 7 regardless of its phonological adaptation, and *permit* (not require) phonological nativization to accompany it.
5. **Assemble the canonical Tier 2 spelling** from steps 1–4 using the phoneme-mapping table at §4. If a second pronunciation is also genuinely common, record it as an explicit accepted variant (§6) — never as a silent alternative.

6. Canonical spelling architecture

Recommended model: one canonical, attested-default spelling per loanword sense, plus explicitly flagged accepted variant(s) where a second pronunciation is genuinely common — never silent, unlimited variation. This generalizes a convention already present in `loanword_examples` (e.g. "bitza / pitza" as accepted forms, "bizza" explicitly marked wrong) into a formal rule (Rule 16, §13).

Three alternative architectures considered and rejected:

- **One canonical spelling only, no variants:** too rigid — falsely marks real attested variation (bitza/pitza) as an error, or buries a genuine register distinction (kombyuter/computer).

- **Fully free variation:** exactly the "uncontrolled spelling variation" problem this policy exists to prevent.
- **Dual-canonical by default (foreign-preserving and Egyptianized both always canonical):** overcorrects — most loanwords don't actually have two live pronunciations, and forcing a pair on every entry manufactures variation that isn't attested. Reserved for the genuine, common cases where a formal/colloquial split really exists (typically Category 3).

7. Morphological integration

Derivational Egyptian morphology (gender, plural, diminutive, verbal derivation) applies to a loanword once it has reached Category 1 or 7 status — that is, once it functions as an ordinary noun or verb slot in an Egyptian sentence, not merely as a cited foreign form. There's no separate "loanword morphology": the same rules already in the [Grammar Reference](#) (§1 nouns, §2 plurals, §4 verbs) apply directly. The one loanword-specific point: a loanword noun without natural gender takes its gender by the same final-vowel-shape and semantic-analogy defaults native nouns already use — no special-casing needed once it's a lexical item.

Key question: once a loanword is fully integrated, should the stem itself get a canonical Egyptianized Tier 2 form? **Yes — but as a form that coexists with, rather than replaces, the citation-form spelling.** The base noun (e.g. bitza) keeps its own canonical entry, whatever attested pronunciation that is (possibly retained-p per §4); its derived forms (bitzaya, bitzat) are separately canonicalized once *they* have an attested dominant pronunciation. These can genuinely diverge — p in the citation form, b in the derived form — because in practice they function as different lexical entries (a cited foreign dish name vs. a fully nativized derived noun), and Masri's job is to spell each as it's actually said rather than force visual agreement between them.

8. Proper names and brands

Recommended model: structured dual representation, not a free-for-all.

- The **canonical Tier 2 spelling** is the name's actual local Egyptian pronunciation, attested — same top-of-hierarchy rule as everything else in this policy (e.g. Pepsi — bebsi, §14).
- A **source-language reference form** may be given alongside on first mention (in parentheses or a dedicated data field) purely for recoverability. This is documentation practice, not a competing orthographic form.
- **Exception:** names whose entire social function is international recognizability — a company's own registered Latin-script logotype, a person's own preferred spelling of their name — may be cited in their original form when directly quoting or labeling that specific entity, the same way English prose still writes "iPhone" with a capital P mid-sentence. That's a quotation, not a Masri spelling.
- Personal names of Egyptians themselves are native vocabulary, not loanwords, and are simply spelled per the Grammar Reference like any other word.

9. English loanwords

English is the dominant current donor language, which is why it gets its own section — not because Masri is designed as an English transliteration scheme (§10 applies the identical language-agnostic policy to other donors).

Feature	Treatment
/p/ ↔ /b/	p retained in the citation form (§4); may nativize to b once morphologically integrated (§7)
/v/ ↔ /f/	v retained in the citation form; nativization to f stays optional/rare even at full integration (§4)
/θ/, /ð/	→ t, d in loanwords specifically (§4) — distinct from the native θ→s/ð→z merger
/r/	→ Masri's one r (§4)
/w/	Already a native Masri sound/letter; no special loanword handling needed
/ŋ/	→ n before a velar (§4); no dedicated letter
Vowel reduction (unstressed schwa)	Written per attested Egyptian pronunciation (§4), never preserved as a distinct symbol
Consonant clusters	Retained as pronounced by default (§4)
Plural -s	Not a Masri plural — a frozen part of the borrowed citation form where it survives (e.g. "chips"). Real Egyptian pluralization of a fully integrated loanword uses native plural patterns instead (§7), not a re-added English -s
English -ed / -ing	Essentially never borrowed as productive English morphology; a loanword verb takes Egyptian verbal morphology instead (§2 Category 7, e.g. sayyiv/yisayyiv "save (a file)"). A fixed frozen noun like "parking" simply has -eng as part of its citation spelling, not a live suffix
Acronyms / abbreviations	Spelled as pronounced — letter-by-letter if that's how they're actually said, or as a full word if re-lexicalized as one (rare). No rule beyond "spell the attested pronunciation"
Spelling–pronunciation mismatches	Irrelevant by design — Masri encodes the Egyptian pronunciation of the loanword, never the English word's own (famously irregular) spelling

10. Other source languages

The underlying policy (§1–§6) is language-agnostic; donor-language identity by itself never determines category or spelling — only attested pronunciation, frequency, and morphological behavior do. The notes below are empirical tendencies per donor, not separate rules:

- **French:** historically the older, more deeply integrated European donor (otobees, garaaj, asanseer, ʊofeer). Many French loans are old enough to sit solidly at Category 1, and /ʒ/ in this layer nativizes to hard g (§4's "older loans" branch) rather than ʊ. French nasal vowels collapse to the nearest oral Masri vowel.
- **Italian:** mostly Category 1–2 food, craft, and household vocabulary (pizza, vitrina); generally short, low-cluster words that Egyptianize easily.

- **Greek:** mostly very old, deeply nativized loans (terabeeza "table," from trapezi) that predate the modern code-switching layer entirely — treated as Category 1 by default, spelled purely by long-established Egyptian pronunciation with no synchronic Greek phonology preserved.
- **Turkish:** a substantial Ottoman-period layer, almost entirely Category 1 already (afandi, kubri, tarboosh) — spelled per Egyptian pronunciation with no live link back to Turkish vowel harmony or phonology.
- **Persian:** a smaller, older, often indirect layer (frequently via Ottoman Turkish or Classical Arabic) — treated the same as the oldest Greek/Turkish loans, sometimes indistinguishable in behavior from native vocabulary (dulab, \$14).
- **Spanish:** minimal direct borrowing into Modern Egyptian. Where a plausible candidate exists it's typically media-mediated and marginal (Category 6) rather than a settled loan — see \$15's stress-test entry 30 for how the policy handles this "empty category" case honestly rather than manufacturing an example.

11. Nativization threshold

Nativization is modeled as **graded, not binary** — a very new tech term and a centuries-old Turkish loan aren't in the same state, and treating them identically would either over-nativize the new one or under-nativize the old one. Each axis below is scored Low / Medium / High from attested usage; the categories in \$2 are qualitative bands along this same continuum, not a separate decision.

Axis	Low integration	Medium	High integration
Frequency	Rare, occasional code-switch	Common in a specific register	Common in everyday general speech
Age of borrowing	Recent (years)	Established (a generation)	Old (multiple generations/centuries)
Phonological adaptation	Retains source phonemes closely	Partial adaptation (some substitution)	Fully adapted to Egyptian phonology
Grammatical integration	Cited as a fixed foreign form	Takes at most one Egyptian process (e.g. a bare plural)	Takes full Egyptian derivational morphology
Speaker perception	Perceived as clearly foreign	Perceived as borrowed but normal	Perceived as ordinary Egyptian vocabulary; origin often unknown to most speakers
Pronunciation variability	Wide, unsettled variation	Narrowing — a dominant + minority form	Single stable pronunciation
Lexical/dictionary status	Not lexicalized, ad hoc	Lexicalized in slang/technical glossaries	Lexicalized as ordinary vocabulary

Banding: mostly-Low axes → Category 6 (recent borrowing); a mixed profile → Category 2/3 (code-switched/technical); mostly-High → Category 1 (fully integrated). This is a banding, not a formula — no single axis is decisive on its own (age alone doesn't guarantee integration: some old borrowings stayed marginal, some fast tech terms nativize within a couple of years), so the threshold is crossed

when enough axes independently tip High that the word behaves, spells, and inflects like ordinary Egyptian vocabulary.

12. Conflict-resolution hierarchy

A first-pass hierarchy — actual pronunciation, phonemic contrast, lexical identity, morphological integration, source-language recoverability, visual recognizability — is close, but two changes make it more usable in practice:

- **Merge "lexical identity" and "morphological integration"** into one combined tier: in practice they resolve together, since a word's derived-form behavior is how its lexical identity in Egyptian shows up (§7).
- **Explicitly demote** "source-language recoverability" and "visual recognizability" from merely lower-priority to actively subordinate, so a writer doesn't unconsciously reach for source spelling as an early tiebreaker.

Revised, five-tier hierarchy:

1. **Attested actual Cairene pronunciation** — never overridden by anything below.
2. **Phonemic contrast Tier 2 already encodes** — use p/v/j/etc. where the sound is genuinely there; don't erase a real contrast for tidiness.
3. **Lexical identity and morphological integration together** — does the word's derived-form behavior indicate further nativization (§7)?
4. **Source-language recoverability** — a tiebreaker only, between two otherwise equally attested variants; never a deciding factor on its own.
5. **Visual resemblance to source spelling** — lowest, a courtesy only, essentially never decisive given the constraints above.

13. Normative standard: Masri Tier 2 Loanword Standard

Mandatory

- **M1.** Spelling encodes actual attested Cairene pronunciation, never source-language spelling.
- **M2.** Every loanword gets exactly one canonical Tier 2 spelling per lexical status/register; a second attested pronunciation is recorded as an explicit accepted variant, never silently (§6).
- **M3.** P and V are used whenever the corresponding foreign phoneme (/p/, /v/) is actually retained in the *citation form's* pronunciation; they are never silently replaced by B or F "to look more Egyptian." J is used whenever a loanword's /ʒ/ is retained — the same letter Ṣaʿīdi and MSA registers already use for native ج — and is never silently replaced by G, which is reserved for the Cairene hard-/g/ reading.
- **M4.** No new Tier 2 letters are introduced for loanword sounds Masri doesn't already have a letter for (/tʃ/, /ŋ/) — use the digraph/allophone rules at §4 instead. /ʒ/ is the one exception

worth stating explicitly: Masri already has a letter for it, J (shared with native Ṣaʿidi/MSA ج), so a retained-foreign /ʒ/ may use J directly rather than only falling back to ʁ or g.

- **M5.** Loanword θ→t / ð→d is kept distinct from the native θ→s / ð→z Cairene merger; the two are not the same rule and must not be conflated.
- **M6.** Once a loanword takes native Egyptian derivational morphology, that derived form follows ordinary Masri grammar rules (Grammar Reference §1–§4) — there is no separate loanword morphology.

Default (apply unless a specific attested exception is documented)

- **D1.** Word-initial and word-medial consonant clusters are retained as pronounced, not broken up by an inserted vowel.
- **D2.** Proper names and brands are spelled per their actual local Egyptian pronunciation; a source-form reference may be added alongside for recoverability but isn't itself the canonical spelling.
- **D3.** Technical/international terms default to their dominant ordinary-speech pronunciation as canonical, with a source-like form as an accepted formal-register variant where genuinely in use.
- **D4.** Stress is not marked, for loanwords or native words alike.

Optional

- **O1.** A source-language reference form may be included in glossary/dictionary entries alongside the canonical spelling, for recoverability — documentation, not an alternate orthography.
- **O2.** Writers may deliberately use a more foreign-preserving pronunciation for stylistic or register effect, provided it's a pronunciation someone would actually say, not an invented one.

Prohibited

- **X1.** Do not invent a spelling for a pronunciation nobody actually uses.
- **X2.** Do not silently multiply spellings for the same attested pronunciation — use the canonical + variant mechanism (§6), not free-for-all.
- **X3.** Do not use donor-language spelling as the basis for a Tier 2 spelling when it conflicts with actual Egyptian pronunciation.
- **X4.** Do not add new Tier 2 letters to chase foreign phonemic precision Masri has decided not to represent.
- **X5.** Do not force phonological nativization (p→b, v→f) on a citation-form loanword that hasn't reached full morphological integration (§7) — premature nativization erases the retained/Egyptianized distinction this policy exists to preserve.

14. Worked examples

Source	Pronunciation	Tier 2	Morphological behavior	Status
pizza (Eng./Ital.)	pitza ~ bitza	bitza (citation)	—	Cat. 2/6
pizza, derived	bitzaya, bitzat	bitzaya (fem. sg.), bitzat (pl.)	full fem./plural derivation, p→b nativized alongside it (§7)	Cat. 1
computer (Eng.)	kombyuter ~ computer	kombyuter (canonical) / computer (variant)	plural kombyuteraat	Cat. 3
television (Eng.)	televezyon	televezyon	plural televezyonaat	Cat. 1
sandwich (Eng.)	sandawitsh	sandawitʃ	plural sandawitʃaat; /tʃ/ retained as tsh	Cat. 1
internet (Eng.)	internet	internet	mass noun, no derivation attested	Cat. 3
chips (Eng.)	ʃibsi	ʃibsi	plural ʃibsiyaat; /tʃ/ simplified to ʃ (contrast sandwich)	Cat. 1
jacket (Eng.)	jaket	jaket/jaketta	plural jakettaat/jawaaket; dedicated j used, not native hard g	Cat. 2/3
parking (Eng.)	parking	parking/barking	mass/locational noun; p retained or→b, ŋ→n+k	Cat. 3
plastic (Eng.)	blastik	blastik	adjectival use; initial pl- cluster softend to bl-	Cat. 2/3
save (Eng., tech verb)	sayyiv/yisayyiv	sayyiv/yisayyiv	full Egyptian verbal paradigm (Grammar Reference §4)	Cat. 7
Pepsi (Eng., brand)	bebsi (universal)	bebsi	proper noun, no derivation	Cat. 5 — attested pronunciation overrides the default p- retention rule, exactly as §12's hierarchy predicts
video (Eng.)	vidyu	vidyu	adjectival ("el mokalma el vidyu")	Cat. 2
vitrina (Ital.)	vitrina	vatrina	plural vatrinaat; v retained even at full Cat. 1 integration	Cat. 1
autobus (Fr.)	otobees	otobees	old, fully nativized	Cat. 1
garage (Fr.)	garaaj	garaaj/garaaʃ	plural garajaat/garaaʃaaat; /ʒ/→hard g (older-loan branch)	Cat. 1
ascenseur (Fr.)	asanséér	asanseer/ asanséér	fully adapted consonant/vowel shape	Cat. 1
chauffeur (Fr.)	ʃoféér	ʃoféér	plural ʃoféraat	Cat. 1

Source	Pronunciation	Tier 2	Morphological behavior	Status
trapezi "table" (Gr.)	terabeeza	terabeeza	ordinary native-feeling noun	Cat. 1
effendi (Turk.)	afandi	afandi	plural afandiyya	Cat. 1
bank (Eng./Fr.)	bank	bank	broken plural bonuuk, exactly like a native noun	Cat. 1

15. Stress test — 30 loanwords

Testing the policy against loanwords from several donor languages, including both heavily Egyptianized and largely source-like pronunciations. Items already worked through at §14 are cross-referenced rather than repeated in full.

#	Word	Source	Tier 2	Why
1	pizza / bitzaya	Eng./Ital.	bitza / bitzaya	§14 — citation vs. derived-form split
2	computer	English	kombyuter	§14 — Cat. 3 default is dominant ordinary-speech form
3	television	English	televeyzon	§14 — long-settled Cat. 1
4	sandwich	English	sandawitʊ	§14 — /tʃ/ retained as tsh
5	internet	English	internet	§14 — Cat. 3 mass noun
6	chips	English	ʊibsi	§14 — /tʃ/ simplified to ʊ, contrast with #4
7	jacket	English	jaket	§14 — dedicated j letter for retained /ʒ/
8	parking	English	parking	§14 — p retained (M3); ŋ→n+k
9	plastic	English	blastik	§14 — initial pl- softened to bl-
10	printer	English	printer	p retained (M3); "brinter" is prohibited (X2/X3), matching the existing loanword_examples entry
11	passport	English	passport / passpour	two genuinely attested pronunciations, recorded as a canonical/variant pair (§6), matching the existing entry
12	project	English	project	p retained; "broject" prohibited, matching the existing entry
13	pump	English	pump	p retained; "bumb" prohibited, matching the existing entry
14	mobile	English	mobayl	diphthong respelled per pronunciation (§4) — shows the policy isn't only about p/v
15	video	English	vidyu	§14 — v retained (the p/v asymmetry)
16	vitrina	Italian	vitrina	§14 — v retained even at full Cat. 1 integration, confirming the asymmetry isn't a citation-form artifact
17	autobus	French	otobees	§14 — old, fully nativized
18	garage	French	garaaj	§14 — /ʒ/→g in an older French-origin loan
19	ascenseur	French	asanseer	§14 — fully adapted shape

#	Word	Source	Tier 2	Why
20	chauffeur	French	ʔoféér	§14 — French /ʃ/ maps straightforwardly onto native ʔ
21	blouse	French	blooza	initial bl- cluster retained (D1); fully nativized with native fem. -a already built in
22	trapezi "table"	Greek	terabeeza	§14 — ancient, fully native-feeling; no synchronic Greek phonology preserved
23	effendi	Turkish	afandi	§14 — old Ottoman-layer Cat. 1
24	köprü "bridge"	Turkish	kubri	old Ottoman-layer loan; source-language vowel harmony not preserved, spelled purely by Egyptian pronunciation
25	tarboosh	Turkish/Persian	tarboosh	old headwear loan, fully nativized, no live foreign-phoneme contrast left to mark
26	dulab "cabinet"	Persian	dulab	extremely old borrowing, behaviorally indistinguishable from native vocabulary — shows the Cat. 1/native boundary is genuinely fuzzy at the oldest end
27	bakhshish "tip"	Persian (via Turkish)	ba'sheesh	old enough that the ordinary glottal-stop rule (Rule 3/5) applies exactly as it would to a native word
28	shampoo	English (ultimately Hindi)	shambu	the donor-language chain is irrelevant to spelling (§10) — only attested Egyptian pronunciation matters
29	bank	English/French	bank	§14 — broken plural bonuk, fully native-feeling despite a recognizable European donor
30	(no direct Spanish loan)	Spanish	— no canonical entry —	Spanish has essentially no directly attested loanword in ordinary Cairene speech; the policy's honest output here is "don't manufacture one." An absent or Category-6/marginal status is a valid result of the policy, not a gap it needs to paper over.

16. Weaknesses and proposed improvements

The design brief explicitly asked not to just agree with its own assumptions. Six real issues, with proposed fixes:

- **Apparent contradiction between M3 and §7's nativization allowance.** M3 says P/V/J are never silently replaced; §7 then allows p→b at full morphological integration. Read carelessly, these look inconsistent. *Fix:* M3 is explicitly scoped to the citation form (now stated directly in §13) — the derived form is a distinct lexical entry, not a "replacement" of the citation spelling.
- **"Attested pronunciation" is doing enormous load-bearing work** throughout this policy, but no corpus or attestation source is defined. In practice, deciding what counts as "dominant" will often be a compiler's own judgment call — the same subjectivity problem the policy was built to eliminate, just relocated from spelling to pronunciation-selection. *Fix:* either document a specific reference source (a corpus, a defined speaker community) or explicitly acknowledge the judgment call and resolve disagreements the same way the Grammar Reference already does — with a documented, revisable decision, flagged the way that document flags genuinely open items.

- **Genuine 50/50 pronunciation ties aren't addressed.** The canonical+variant model (§6) assumes a dominant form exists; a true tie (common right at the moment a tech term is adopted) isn't covered. *Fix:* allow a rare, explicitly-labeled "dual-canonical, unweighted" tag for this specific case, distinct from the ordinary canonical/variant pair, expiring once usage settles.
- **The 7-category status model (§2) and the graded threshold (§11) substantially overlap.** Categories 1/2/3/6/7 are largely just verbal labels for different points on the same continuum §11 already grades, while 4/5 (names/brands) are a genuinely separate axis about naming, not integration. *Fix:* keep §2's seven-way taxonomy as descriptive/documentation vocabulary only; for actual spelling decisions, collapse 1/2/3/6/7 into three practical buckets — "ordinary vocabulary" (post-threshold), "unsettled/marginal" (pre-threshold), and "name" (§8) — driven directly by §11, not by a separate categorical judgment.
- **The /z/ "older loans → g, newer → ʁ" rule (§4) has no crisp age boundary,** and now sits alongside a third option (J, per M4's exception) with no clear line telling a compiler which of the three to reach for. *Fix:* drop the vague "old/new" language for the ʁ/g choice; default to ʁ unless the specific loan is already independently established as Category 1 with an attested hard-g pronunciation — i.e. let §11's threshold decide, not raw age — and reserve J for loanwords where the speaker is consciously equating the sound with native ج (Ṣaʿīdi/MSA register) rather than simplifying it.
- **Source-recoverability genuinely conflicts with phonemic consistency for proper nouns and brands** — a heavily Egyptianized brand spelling can obscure the name's international recognizability. The policy already resolves this correctly (pronunciation wins, recoverability is a documentation add-on, §8/§12), but that's a real, acknowledged cost, not a free win, and should be stated as such rather than glossed over.

Source: policy designed for this project's stated goals; cross-checked against this repo's `assets/data/alphabet.json` and `assets/data/tier2-rules.json` for existing letter and rule conventions (P/V/J/C entries, `spelling_rules` ids 1–11, and the pre-existing `loanword_examples` list).

CHAPTER 11

From Franco to Masri

Turn Franco into Masri

You type 3ashan and 7abibi... Now see it in Masri — how it was meant to look

Franco is the informal way many Egyptians write Arabic using Latin letters and numbers. Masri turns it into a standardized writing system.

Why switch from Franco?

Because Masri keeps everything you already know—while fixing the parts everyone complains about.

- No more 3, 5, 7 and 8 replacing letters.
- Cleaner and easier to read.
- One spelling instead of five different versions.
- Still feels like the Modern Egyptian you already type.
- Works for everyday texting—and can grow into books, education and culture.

Why Masri?

Masri is a standardized writing system for Modern Egyptian designed for everyday communication, education, and the digital world.

Masri is what Franco would look like if it had been designed as a real writing system instead of an internet workaround.

Look at the difference

Franco	Tier 1	Masri (Tier 2)
3ashan	`ashan	Ⲙⲁⲩⲁⲛ
7abibi	habibi	ⲕⲁⲃⲓⲃⲓ
For2o3 loz	For'o` Loz	ForⲟⲟⲘ loz

Same words. Cleaner writing.

Franco isn't one system — that's the problem

Every writer spells the same word differently. Masri's dictionary recognizes the common variants and normalizes them to one canonical spelling (Tier 2, More formal mode shown here).

People type...	Masri writes
3ashan · ashan · 2ashan	◀aʿaʿan
7abibi · habibi	ʒabeebi
hamdilla · elhamdolillah · elhamdilla	Elʒamdolellaah

This is inspired by how Egyptian writing evolved — long before keyboards.

You're just picking it back up.

Maltese descends from Arabic and has its own standardized Latin-script writing system.

Modern Egyptian is spoken by over 100 million people.

Isn't it time it had one too?

Coptic — 2 ʿ ◀ · Greek — θ γ · Latin extended — ð ʂ ɖ ʈ ʐ ʋ

The full system, in the open

This is an educational project — the whole framework is public, not just the parts that convert nicely.

Conversion rules applied (Franco digits, digraphs & Tier 1 marks)

Franco digits — read as input only

Masri never writes a digit as a letter. These are the digits people type in Franco: the converter reads them and writes the letter.

Franco	Arabic	Tier 2	Tier 1
2	ق / ء (Cairene)	ʋ (silent word-initially — Rule 3)	' (mid-word / final only)
3	ع	◀	`
3'	غ	ʒ	gh
4	ش	ʿ	sh
5	خ	x	kh
6	ط	t̤	t^
6'	ظ	ʐ	z^
7	ح	2	h^
8	غ (alt.)	ʒ	gh

Franco	Arabic	Tier 2	Tier 1
9	ص	ṣ	s^
9'	ض	ḍ	d^
'	؍ (mid/final)	ʾ	'

Tier 1 spellings → Tier 2 letters

Tier 1	Arabic	Tier 2
kh	خ	x
sh	ش	ʃ
gh	غ	ɣ
th	ث	θ / s if merger on
dh	ذ	ð / z if merger on
`	ع	◀
s^	ص	ṣ
d^	ض	ḍ
t^	ط	ṭ
z^	ظ	ẓ
h^	ح	ḥ

A caret after a plain letter marks an emphatic. h^ is the emphatic h (ح); plain h stays ه.

Hyphen rule. If a digraph letter meets h or h^ and both must be pronounced, a hyphen keeps them apart: مشهور Mashhoor (sh + h), مسحور Mas-h^oor (s + h^).

Spelling Rule 4 (Digraph Integrity) only applies to Tier 1. In Tier 2 these become single characters (ʃ, x, ɣ), so digraph integrity is superseded by direct single-character mapping.

Rule-based, not a language model — ambiguous cases (gemination, vowel length, formal/merger consonants) may need manual review against the Framework's standardised word list.

CHAPTER 12

Language in Egypt

Language in Egypt: A Full Timeline

Egyptian history is a long sequence of shifts between everyday speech, official language, and prestige registers — sometimes all one and the same, sometimes three different things at once. Here's the full sweep, from the Old Kingdom to today.

One language, every register

Old Kingdom • c. 3200–2100 BCE

Old Egyptian was spoken, governed, and written in — no split yet between the street and the state. Hieroglyphs carried monumental and religious weight; early Hieratic handled day-to-day administration.

Masri's take

The starting point every writing system eventually drifts away from: a script that matches how people actually talk.

The first prestige/vernacular split

Middle Kingdom • c. 2100–1700 BCE

Speech kept evolving, but Middle Egyptian froze into the literary and administrative standard — becoming Egypt's first "classical" language, outliving anyone who spoke it natively.

Masri's take

This is the oldest ancestor of today's gap between Modern Standard Arabic and Masri — a formal register that stopped moving while speech kept going.

Vernacular finally gets written down

New Kingdom • c. 1550–1070 BCE

Late Egyptian — the actual vernacular — started appearing in writing for everyday administration, while Middle Egyptian stayed locked into temple and monumental use as a classical register.

Masri's take

Proof that vernacular writing isn't a modern shortcut — Egyptians have been writing down their everyday speech for over 3,000 years.

A new everyday script, and a new ruling one

Late Period–Ptolemaic · c. 700–30 BCE

Demotic — a fast cursive script — became the everyday popular hand. Then Ptolemaic rule brought Greek in as the language of administration and elite scholarship, while temples kept hieroglyphs alive for religion.

Masri's take

The first time in Egyptian history that the ruling language and the popular script came from entirely different sources.

Coptic script is born

Roman Egypt · 30 BCE–4th c. CE

Greek stayed the language of administration under Rome. But spoken Egyptian, drifting from Demotic toward what we now call Coptic, started being written with the Greek alphabet plus a handful of Demotic-derived signs for sounds Greek didn't have.

Masri's take

The exact move Masri makes today: borrow letterforms from more than one script to represent Egyptian sounds a single alphabet can't cover.

A full script change, driven by identity

Byzantine / Coptic period · 4th–7th c. CE

Coptic became the everyday spoken and religious language of Christian Egypt, written entirely in its own alphabet. Greek remained the administrative language of the Byzantine state.

Masri's take

A clean historical precedent: Egyptians have adopted a distinct, non-inherited script before — not for convenience, but to mark who they were.

Arabic takes over administration

Early Islamic Egypt · 641–9th c. CE

Coptic stayed widely spoken for generations after the conquest. Arabic gradually became the sole administrative language by the early 700s, while Classical Arabic carried religious and scholarly prestige.

Masri's take

Script and language shifts in Egypt have always taken generations, not overnight — a useful reminder for how long real adoption takes.

Modern Egyptian emerges — unofficial from day one

Medieval Egypt · 10th–17th c.

Modern Egyptian developed as the spoken vernacular while Classical Arabic held every official and prestige role. Coptic finally died out as everyday speech by around the 17th century, surviving only in the church.

Masri's take

From this point on, Modern Egyptian never once holds official status — the gap Masri exists to address has been open for roughly a thousand years.

A third layer joins the stack

Ottoman Egypt · 1517–1867

Modern Egyptian stayed the spoken vernacular. Ottoman Turkish became the language of the ruling elite, and Classical Arabic kept its religious and legal prestige — both written in the Arabic script.

Masri's take

Even at its most linguistically layered, Egypt never lost the Arabic script as the common thread across every official register.

European prestige, Latin script enters

Khedival & British era · 19th–20th c.

Modern Egyptian remained the vernacular. Modern Standard Arabic emerged as the modern official register, while French carried social and administrative prestige among the educated elite, later joined by English.

Masri's take

The first time Latin script enters Egyptian daily life at scale — decades before Franco, setting the stage for it.

Franco fills the gap — Masri proposes closing it*Contemporary Egypt · today*

Modern Egyptian (Masri) remains unofficial and spoken, informally written as Franco online. Modern Standard Arabic holds official and formal-prestige status; English carries international/business prestige. Masri proposes a standardized script for the vernacular itself.

Masri's take

Every era before this one solved the popular-writing problem with something inherited from a conqueror or a neighbor. Masri is Egypt building its own answer this time.

The full picture at a glance

Popular speech, official administration, literary prestige, and script — side by side, era by era.

Era	Popular / vernacular	Official / administrative	Prestige / literary	Script(s)
Old Kingdom	Old Egyptian (spoken)	Old Egyptian	Old Egyptian	Hieroglyphic, early Hieratic
Middle Kingdom	Late Old Egyptian	Middle Egyptian	Middle Egyptian (classical)	Hieroglyphic, Hieratic
New Kingdom	Late Egyptian	Late Egyptian (admin)	Middle Egyptian (temples)	Hieratic, Hieroglyphic
Late Period–Ptolemaic	Demotic Egyptian	Demotic → Greek	Greek; Middle Egyptian (temples)	Demotic, Greek, Hieroglyphic
Roman Egypt	Egyptian → Coptic	Greek, Latin (top tier)	Greek	Greek alphabet; Coptic emerges
Byzantine / Coptic	Coptic	Greek	Greek (state), Coptic (church)	Coptic alphabet, Greek alphabet
Early Islamic Egypt	Coptic, then Arabic	Arabic (from early 700s)	Classical Arabic, Coptic (church)	Arabic script, Coptic script
Medieval Egypt	Modern Egyptian	Classical Arabic	Classical Arabic	Arabic script dominant
Ottoman Egypt	Modern Egyptian	Ottoman Turkish, Classical Arabic	Ottoman Turkish, Classical Arabic	Arabic script (both languages)

Era	Popular / vernacular	Official / administrative	Prestige / literary	Script(s)
Khedival & British era	Modern Egyptian	Modern Standard Arabic, French/English (admin)	MSA; French (elite)	Arabic script; Latin script (elite)
Contemporary Egypt	Modern Egyptian (Masri)	Modern Standard Arabic	MSA; English (international)	Arabic script; Franco; Masri (proposed)

Modern Egyptian has never held official status at any point on this timeline — it's always been the popular register underneath whatever language ruled or carried prestige. And Egypt has changed its script for non-linguistic reasons — conquest, religion, identity — several times before. Masri isn't a break from that pattern; it's the next chapter of it.

Sources

- [Encyclopaedia Britannica — Egyptian language](#)
- [UCLA Encyclopedia of Egyptology — Coptic](#)
- [Encyclopaedia Britannica — Demotic script](#)

CHAPTER 13

Before Masri: Why Not Franco?

Before Masri: A History of the Problem

Masri isn't the first attempt to fix how Modern Egyptian gets written. It's the ninth. Here's what the eight before it got right, what sank each one — and why Masri is built differently.

The Orientalist Grammars

Academic · 1880 – 1901

European Arabists — Wilhelm Spitta (1880), Carl Vollers (1890), John Selden Willmore (1901) — wrote the first serious scholarly grammars of spoken Modern Egyptian, each inventing his own Latin transliteration to describe it for Western students. Three scholars, three different systems, none of them agreeing on how to spell the same sound. Spitta's own alphabet was the most complete of the three, and the most fully worked out: American librarian Daniel Willard Fiske later popularized it in English as "An Egyptian Alphabet for the Egyptian People" (2nd ed., Florence, 1904) — 34 letters, built entirely from Latin diacritics (macrons on the long vowels, dots below the emphatics, a bare, repurposed "c" standing in for ع), with no digraphs anywhere and, on principle, no capital letters at all — Fiske explicitly modeled that choice on the Brothers Grimm's push to abolish uncial type. It was elegant and phonetically airtight, and it needed special diacritic type-sorts no ordinary Cairo print shop had lying around. All three grammars began as outsiders' tools for outsiders — pronunciation guides for foreign students of Arabic — though Fiske, to his credit, closed his edition with something closer to a manifesto: a hope that Egypt's own educated youth would one day carry the alphabet forward as their own.

I. *The Alphabet.*

(alifbê).

a	ah	}	(١)	h	hâ	(ح)
â	â			d	dâl	(د)
e	eh			ḏ	ḏâd	(ض)
ê	ê			r	rê	(ر)
i	ih			z	zên	(ز)
y	y			s	syn	(س)
o	oh			ś	śyn	(ش)
ô	ô			ş	şâd	(ص)
u	uh	}	(٢)	°	°ên	(ع)
û	û			f	fê	(ف)
b	bê			q	qâf	(ق)
t	tê			k	kâf	(ك)
ṭ	ṭâ			l	lâm	(ل)
g	gym			m	mym	(م)
ğ	ğên			n	nûn	(ن)
h	hê			w	wau	(و)
ḥ	ḥâ			j	jê	(ي)

The following names have been used or suggested for the vowels: *naşba* for *a*; *heşda* for *e*; *hişda* for *i*; *roş°a* for *o*; and *ruş°a* for *u*.

Fiske's 1904 alphabet table — 34 letters built entirely from Latin diacritics, no digraphs, no capitals.

Masri's take

Fiske's closing pages read like a manifesto — a plea that Egypt's own sons one day inherit and carry the alphabet forward, so that education might belong to "the people, of the people and by the people." That instinct is real kinship, not a coincidence to wave away: Masri shares the same conviction, that the vernacular deserves a graphic home of its own and that literacy shouldn't have to wait for institutions to catch up. But the resemblance is convergent, not inherited. Masri wasn't built as a descendant of Spitta's alphabet — it arrived at a similar ambition from an entirely different direction: not scholars codifying Egyptian speech for foreign students to study, but a natural outgrowth of Arabizi, the improvised Latin shorthand Egyptians had already been typing to one another for thirty years before Masri gave it rules. And where Spitta reached for bare diacritics with no particular Egyptian pedigree, Masri reaches into Egypt's own older alphabet — Coptic and Greek-derived letters that were already home-grown, centuries before any Orientalist opened a notebook. Fiske hoped the sons of Egypt would one day take up the project themselves. Masri is close to what that looks like — with the added patriotism of letters that were never anyone else's to lend.

The al-Muqtataf Models

Academic · 1889 – 1897

Cairo's leading science magazine, al-Muqtataf, published two of its own Latin-script Arabic systems in 1889 and 1897, each one a direct rebuttal to a rival scheme — the 1889 model answered a diacritic-heavy transliteration method the magazine had just published by Damascene scholar Ilyas al-Qudsi, and the 1897 model answered American linguist Daniel Willard Fiske's Latin-script Modern Egyptian project. The real target wasn't foreign students but cost and confusion: minting new Arabic type was expensive, and loanwords were getting mangled — the editors showed how the word Gravy alone could come out as grafi, graphy, or jrvay depending on which Arabic letters a writer picked. The 1889 model bolted extra punctuation marks onto ordinary Latin letters; the 1897 version replaced missing sounds with inverted and mirrored Latin letters instead, chosen partly for sound and partly for how closely a flipped shape happened to resemble the Arabic original. Even Egypt's own government had flagged the same chaos — its Minister of Education tried to standardize Arabic-French transcription in official bulletins back in 1892, after 'Capitaine' turned up spelled two different ways in the same gazette. None of it — magazine model or government fix — ever stuck.

Masri's take

Sarruf and Nimr solved the printing-cost problem perfectly and lost on the one thing that actually decides adoption: a reader wrote in that an upside-down letter "bothers the eye," and he was right — familiarity beats cleverness every time. Masri learned that lesson before it shipped: instead of asking every reader's eye to accept inverted Latin type, it borrows whole letterforms that already existed in Egypt's own alphabet, so nothing on the page needs to look upside-down to make sense.

The State Latinization Proposal

Formal / State · 1944

Abd al-Aziz Fahmi, chairman of the Egyptian Language Academy's writing committee, formally proposed replacing the Arabic script with Latin letters entirely — explicitly modeled on Atatürk's 1928 Turkish reform. A rival proposal from Ali al-Garim wanted to keep Arabic letterforms but add new symbols for short vowels instead. The Academy rejected both within a month and opened an international contest for a better idea instead — which went nowhere.

ā	ا	ألف	ز	زاي	q	و	قاف
b	ب	باء	s	سين	k	ك	كاف
t	ت	تاء	sh	شين	ll	ل	لام
th	ث	ثاء	ch	صاد	m	م	ميم
j	ج	ميم	kh	ضاد	n	ن	نون
h	ح	حاء	l	طاء	h	ه	هاء
x	خ	خاء	zh	ظاء	w	و	واد
d	د	دال	c	عين	o	و	هَمْزة
dt	ذ	زال	g	غين	y	ي	يَاء
rr	ر	راء	f	فاء	أما الحروف المرسومة : (a) للفتحة و (u) للضمة و (x) للكسرة .		
ويلاحظ أن الحروف المرسومة لها هي حروف عادية أما الكبيرة اللاتينية (majuscules) فعرفنة، وتكتب الحروف المأخوذة من العربية يكون بتكبير رسمها عالية رؤسها دون كاساتها .							
				وأما الأحرف التي لا شبيه لتعتمدها في العربية فهي : <i>e, g, j, p, v, x.</i>			

Fahmi's own letter-mapping chart, with handwritten notes on capitals and sounds with no Arabic equivalent (e, g, j, p, v, x).

Masri's take

Fahmi's mistake wasn't linguistic, it was diplomatic — he asked Egypt to trade its script for someone else's. Masri doesn't ask that: the Coptic letters it borrows aren't foreign, they're Egypt's own alphabet, one chapter earlier. You're not defecting to Rome. You're going home.

Said Akl's Lebanese Alphabet

Linguistic / Nationalist · 1961

Lebanese poet Said Akl designed a full 36-letter Latin-based alphabet for spoken Lebanese and published an entire poetry collection, *Yara* (1961), and a newspaper entirely in it — proving a Latin script really can carry serious dialect literature. But he tied it to a political claim that Lebanese wasn't Arabic at all, descending instead from Phoenician — a premise most of his own readers didn't share, and the alphabet never spread past a small circle of believers.

Masri's take

Said Akl proved the hard part — a Latin script really can carry real dialect literature. He just welded it to a political argument most of his own readers didn't buy. Masri keeps the engineering and drops the politics: it never asks you to stop being Egyptian-Arab to use it.

The Library Standards

Formal / Standards · 1950s – 1982

ALA-LC romanization (Library of Congress) and Germany's DIN 31635 (1982) are precise, one-to-one scholarly systems built so a library catalog can represent any Arabic book title unambiguously — full of macrons and dots-below characters that need special keyboard input. They were designed for Modern Standard and Classical Arabic in a cataloguing context, with no attempt to capture spoken Cairene sounds at all.

Masri's take

ALA-LC can tell a librarian in Chicago exactly how to alphabetize a book title. It has never once helped an Egyptian text 'Gamal' to a friend. Beautiful precision, wrong job.

Buckwalter Transliteration

Computational · 1988

Linguist Tim Buckwalter, working on the ALPNET Arabic project, built a strict ASCII transliteration where every Arabic letter maps to exactly one Latin character and back — fully reversible, still powering Arabic natural-language-processing research today. It's brilliant for a computer: ع becomes 'E', ث becomes 'v', ذ becomes '*'. No human would ever choose to write like that.

Masri's take

Buckwalter is the writing system you'd design if your reader were a parser, not a person. Perfect for a machine, unreadable for a human — exactly backwards from what daily writing needs.

Arabizi / Franco

Informal / Grassroots · 1990s – today

No single inventor — Franco emerged organically across the Arab world in the 1990s once pagers, early mobiles, and chatrooms only supported Latin characters. Numerals were pressed into service because their shapes loosely echoed the missing Arabic letters: 3 for ٧, ٤ for ح. It spread with zero institutional backing because it only needed two people who wanted to text each other.

Masri's take

Franco is proof of concept, not a finished product — it proved millions of Egyptians would rather invent a writing system than not write the dialect at all. Masri takes that appetite and finally gives it rules — Masri's own lineage runs through this entry, not through the Orientalists above.

eg-lang

Contemporary · 2020s

eg-lang proposes a fully Latin, diacritic-based orthography for Modern Egyptian — one alphabet, precisely tuned to Cairene phonology, with a complete pronunciation reference and audio for every letter. Where Masri treats canonical orthography and its representations as separate layers (Tier 2's own letter inventory, with Tier 1 and DRS as derived forms of it), eg-lang combines both into a single Latin system that is itself the standard. Masri's DRS representation is built to serve the same practical need eg-lang addresses: a fully Latin, keyboard-typable rendering of the underlying orthography — offered alongside Tier 2, rather than replacing it.

Masri's take

eg-lang and Masri's DRS aim at the same practical need: writing Modern Egyptian in Latin letters with real phonological precision. The difference is architectural rather than one of accuracy — eg-lang is a single Latin standard, while DRS is one of three representations (alongside Tier 1 and Tier 2) of a canonical orthography that also has its own dedicated alphabet.

Full homepage text belongs to eg-lang; read it at eg-lang.com/en. Below: their own opening line, and the same line rendered in Masri.

eg-lang

"Ahlan biiku fi maṣruughḥ ketaabet elgharabi elmaṣri belḥuruuf ellatiniyya!" — eg-lang.com/eg

Masri	Ahlan beeko fi maṭrooḵ ketaabet el ʿarabi el Maşri bel ʿoroof el Latineyya!
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The scoreboard

Eight attempts, each brilliant at exactly one thing and missing the rest. Masri is built by looking at all eight gaps at once.

Attempt	Typable anywhere	Reads naturally	Captures Cairene sounds	Carries identity	Actually caught on
Orientalist grammars	✗	~	~	~	✗
al-Muqtataf models	~	✗	✗	✗	✗
Fahmi Latinization	✓	~	✗	✗	✗
Said Akl's alphabet	✗	✓	~	~	✗
Library standards	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
Buckwalter	✓	✗	✗	✗	~
Arabizi / Franco	✓	~	✓	~	✓
eg-lang	~	✓	✓	~	~
Masri	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Every attempt before Masri nailed exactly one piece of the puzzle and dropped the rest. The orientalist grammars nailed rigor and dropped usability. The al-Muqtataf editors nailed the printing economics and dropped legibility. Fahmi nailed ambition and dropped identity. Said Akl nailed literature and dropped inclusiveness. The library standards nailed precision and dropped humans. Buckwalter nailed machines and dropped readability. Franco nailed adoption and dropped structure. eg-lang nailed the phonology, and Masri's DRS carries that same precision into a keyboard-typable form. Masri was built by looking at all eight gaps at once — not to be smarter than any single one of them, but to stop repeating the specific mistake that sank it.

Sources

- [Verlato, O. — "A Latin Alphabet for the Arabic Language." IJMES \(2023\)](#)
- [Wikipedia — Romanization of Arabic \(Fahmi, 1944 proposal\)](#)
- [Wikipedia — Said Akl](#)
- [Wikipedia — Buckwalter transliteration](#)
- [Wikipedia — Arabic chat alphabet \(Arabizi / Franco\)](#)
- [Spitta-Bey, W. — Grammatik des arabischen Vulgärdialectes von Aegypten \(1880\)](#)
- [Fiske, D.W. — An Egyptian Alphabet for the Egyptian People, 2nd ed. \(Florence: The Landi Press, 1904\)](#)
- [eg-lang.com — the modern Egyptian Latinization project](#)

CHAPTER 14

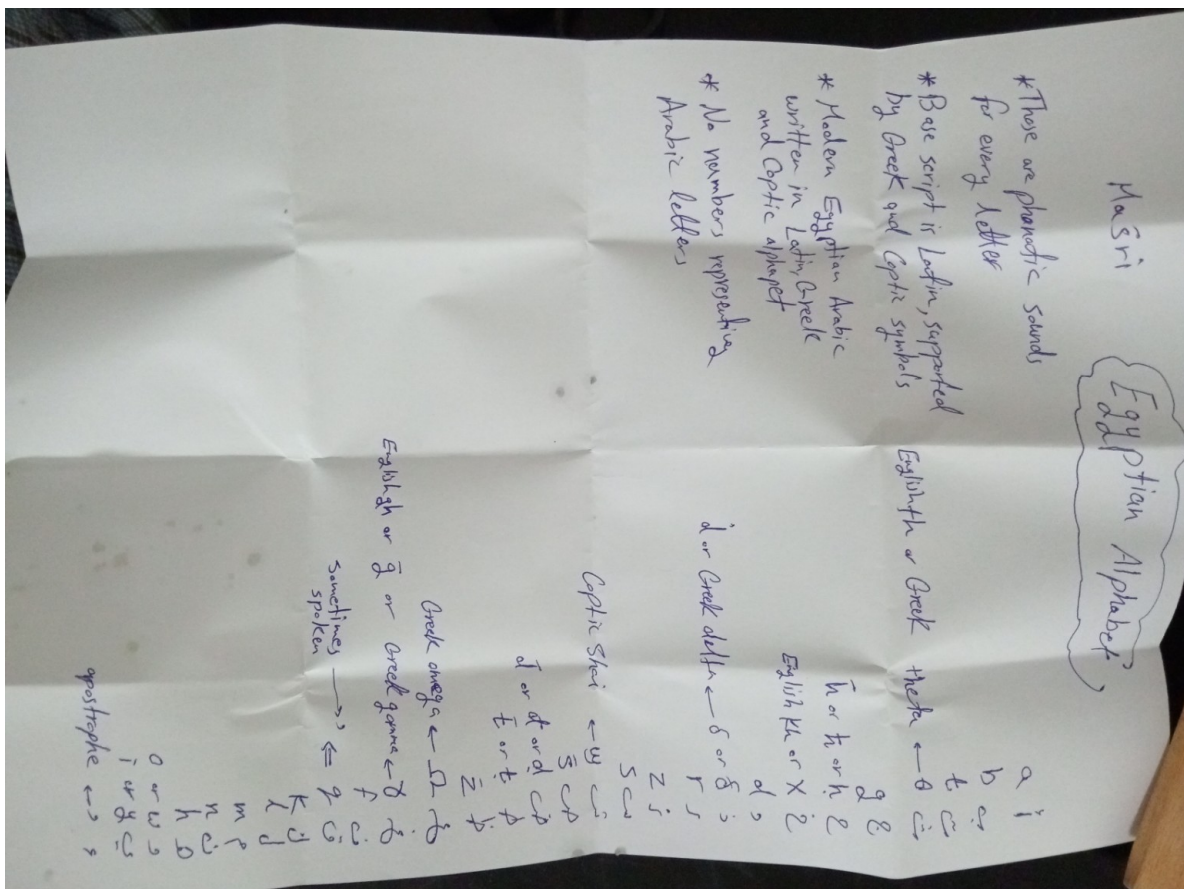
How Masri Was Made

Before the website, the converter, and the framework documents, Masri was two handwritten pages. Here they are — the sketch that set the rules, and the manuscript that put them to the test.

A Scrap of Paper

First sketch

Before there was a font, a keyboard layout, or a website, there was one handwritten page headed “Masri — Egyptian Alphabet.” It already lays out the rules the whole system still follows today: one phonetic sound per letter, Latin as the base script filled out with Greek and Coptic letters where Latin runs short, the target is spoken Modern Egyptian rather than Classical Arabic — and on principle, no digit is ever allowed to stand in for an Arabic letter, a deliberate break from Arabizi’s 3/7/2 numeral conventions. A column down the right side sketches sound-by-sound candidates for every Arabic letter, several of which made it into the final alphabet largely unchanged — Greek theta for the th-sound, Coptic shai for sh, Old Coptic Ain < for ع.



The first working draft — four rules on the left, letter-by-letter candidates on the right. Most of it survived to the final alphabet.

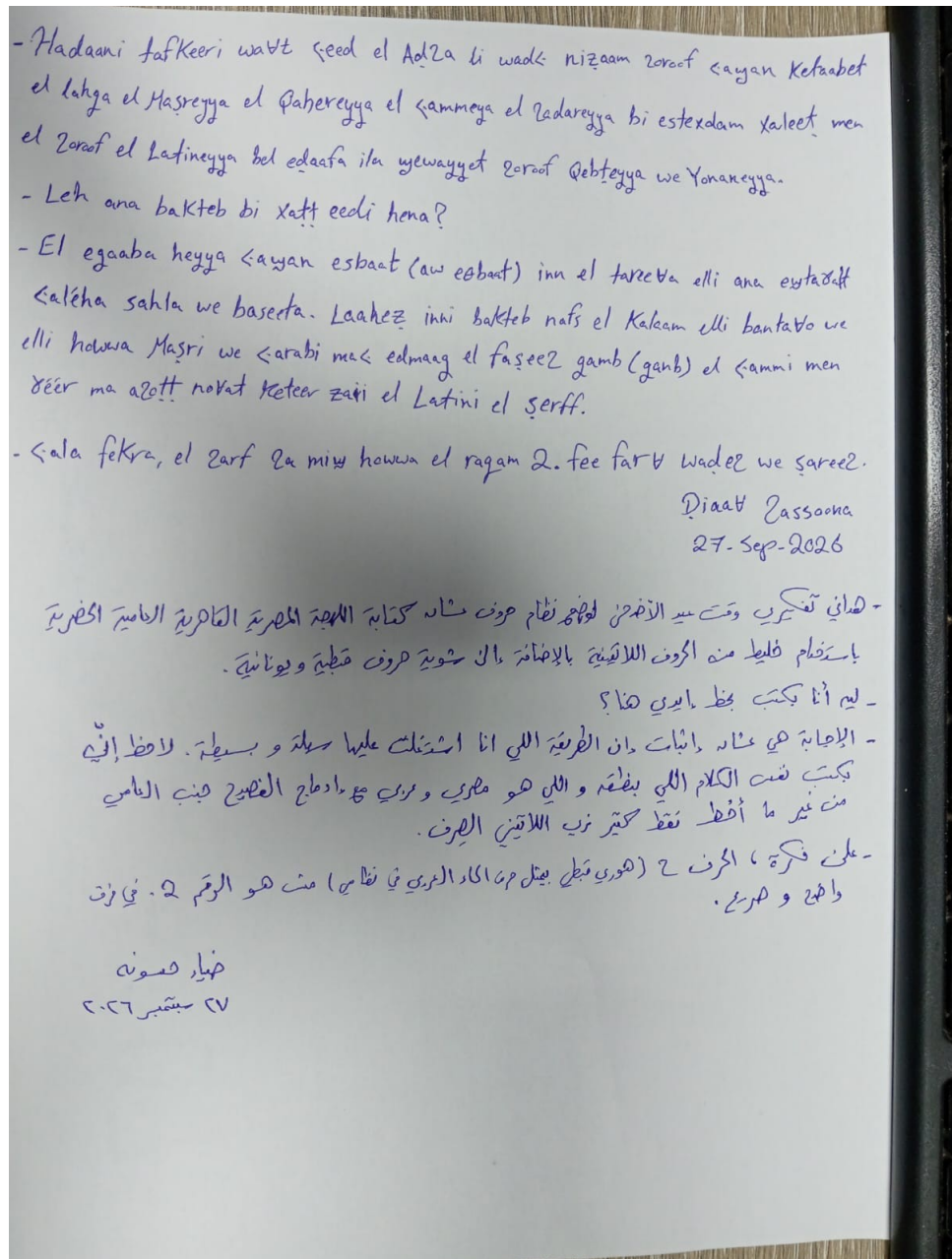
Proof by Practice

27 Jul 2026

The idea came together around Eid al-Adha: a letter system for writing urban Cairene Modern Egyptian, built from a mix of Latin letters filled out with a handful of Coptic and Greek ones. The note explains itself as it goes — it's handwritten to prove the system is genuinely easy and simple, by writing the same sentence twice, once in Masri and once in Arabic underneath, blending formal and colloquial registers side by side without loading the line down with the diacritics a purely Latin transliteration would need. It closes with a pointed correction: the letter 2 (Coptic hori, standing in for ح) is not the digit 2 — there's a clear, deliberate difference between them. Signed Ɖeaaʋ Ɖassoona and dated 27 Jul 2026.

The manuscript's opening sentence, transcribed — in Masri, then in Arabic underneath, exactly as written on the page.

Masri	Hadaani tafkeeri waʋt Ɖeed el Aḍḍa li waḍƉ nezaam Ɖoroof Ɖaʋaan kataabet el lahga el Maşreyya el Qaahereyya el Ɖammeyya el Ɖaḍareyya bi estexdaam xaleet men el Ɖoroof el Lateneeya bel iḍaafa ila Ɖewayyet Ɖoroof Qebṭeyya we Yonaaneyya.
Arabic	هداني تفكيري وقت عيد الأضحى لوضع نظام حروف عشان كتابة اللهجة المصرية القاهرية العامية الحضرية باستخدام خليط من الحروف اللاتينية بالإضافة إلى شوبة حروف قبطية و يونانية.



The same page, twice: Masri on top, Arabic underneath — closing with a note that 2 isn't the digit 2. Signed and dated 27 Jul 2026.

From notebook to a live system

Those two pages turned into a full 37-letter alphabet spanning Latin, Coptic, and Greek letterforms, a Tier 2 academic ruleset, and a public framework released under CC BY 4.0. The alphabet now has a working Arabizi-to-Masri converter, keyboard layouts, and a reference site. The handwriting is still where all of it starts: every rule on this page traces back to a decision made with a pen, not a keyboard.